

Clash of Dragon and Demon Arc

Chapter 162: Rewards and Evolution I

It's now the second day after I revived the 700,000 soldiers of the Empire's forces.

Since there wasn't sufficient space in the grand hall of Tempest, I gathered my subordinates in the battle arena to test out the evolution ritual.

This will also serve as the rewards for repelling the empire's armies.

It's also a victory celebration of sorts.

Actually, since the war hasn't ceased yet we shouldn't let down our guards, but it'll be an exception this time.

This is also for the sake of improving soldier Morale.

The Ten Lords of the Labyrinth also made their formal appearances, and the battle arena's jam-packed with soldiers.

Oh, for confidentiality, the human volunteers, the adventurers weren't invited.

The city around the Dungeon—the fact it's now named Labyrinth-Gard—hasn't been conveyed into the inside of the dungeon yet.

This is in consideration of the fact we may face surprise attacks during a war, it's for the sake of caution.

The barrier stones haven't been implemented into the surroundings of Labyrinth-Gard. Once the war is over I plan to perform a defensive ritual targeting wide-scale attack spells.

Due to present situations, there isn't enough time to implement any defenses, but it can't be helped.

Although the dungeon can't be explored at the moment, food ingredients can still be traded.

Other than the adventurers, business is going as usual.

The volunteer soldiers have returned to Labyrinth-Gard, currently on standby in their own homes.

Only a section of individuals such as Masayuki and Arnaud were allowed to participate as representatives.

Anyways, rewards and commendations were given.

Incidentally, I also experimented on the Demon Lord Ascension.

My evolution took 2~3 days, my level of activity has dropped due to the effects of [Harvest Festival](#), however at the moment the empire's armies aren't here.

収穫祭, Harvest Festival is the term used by the author to describe the evolution of a monster into a demon lord, probably because they harvested a load of souls for this.

It would seem the airship corps would take 3 days to fly around the back of The Holy Empire Ruberion's territory, but

after adjusting their advancement speed, they would hit open seas in 2 days.

When flying near supersonic speeds, they could reduce travel time by 1 day. However, magic consumption was immense, and they could only maintain their top speed for a short amount of time.

In this world, the ability to move at supersonic speeds is quite a threat, so I think a short amount of time is enough.

In any case, since the average speed for an airship is about 400km/h, when compared to a ship or a train this is pretty fast.

That's why, you can say this is good timing.

It was an overwhelming victory this time, but the possibilities of a strong adversary lurking in the midst of the enemies still exist.

If Yuuki appeared, among all of my executives the only ones

who could deal with him would probably be either Diablo or Benimaru.

If they messed up badly, there would be the risk of being dominated effect due to the information overwriting over the soul, resulting in the possibility of having a subordinate

Regarding the information overwrite on the soul, Wisdom King Raphael seem to provide protection against it.

However, I think it's probably only a temporary effect.

I think it's possible to set up a perfect defense against it if I directly saw Yuuki's ability, but at the moment this is only a conjecture so overconfidence is very dangerous.

The improvement of overall abilities through the Demon Lord ascension will serve as insurance for those "oh shit moments".

Perchance, even if my subordinates were still defeated after they ascended and their souls were rewritten, it's still possible

for them to stall for time.

The plan is to contact me in the event of a chance encounter, commence a pincer attack with me and finish him off.

According to Wisdom King Raphael's prediction there would be no problems in resisting the rewrite; even so I still want to be extremely cautious though.

Naturally, Benimaru was the first to be nominated.

As supreme commander of the army, he commanded the troops wonderfully.

There was a situation where a demon went wild and wrecked everything, but that's not a problem.

You could probably even call it a job well done.

“Alright then, Benimaru. Do you know as of today you might even become a demon lord?”

“What are you saying, Rimuru-sama?”

Shuna is currently giving a speech to all the soldiers with words of appreciation for this battle.

With my words as the introduction, she read a script out loud

Naturally it wasn't me who came up with the manuscript. It was Shuna, but let's not mind the small details.

Recently, techniques relating to fabrics and sewing have been completely passed down; Shuna herself has been allocating her time for her hobbies.

Even so, she spends a lot of her time as my secretary.

At the moment Shion was listed as my chief bodyguard as well as my chief secretary but is currently busy training her subordinates.

Thus recently it was mainly Shuna who was handling the work of being my secretary.

That's why, while Shuna was giving a speech the conversation between Benimaru and I continued.

“Well, we acquired some souls didn't we? It seems it's possible to ascend to a demon lord using them.”

“Why haven't I heard about this?”

“Oh? Didn't I just explained about it?”

I and Benimaru locked eyes.

I wonder was it distasteful for me to not tell him beforehand?

No, I'm pretty positive I've already told him I would be granting him new powers.

“For the moment, I did say I'll bestow power to you?”

No no no, wouldn't one usually think it would be some kind of weapon!?

“Mu mu mu, If you say so it might be but...”

But you know, there wouldn't be much change right?”

“there will be!”

We once again locked eyes with each other, the stare was broken this time by Benimaru's sigh as he gave up.

He seems to have decided to prepare himself.

You may have resigned yourself to this, but I'm sure there won't be any significant differences.

“It's not just me right? What are you thinking?”

Good question.

In my case, my magic essence and my magic increased 10 folds, and everyone soul-linked to me was bestowed a blessing.

It's unknown how it will turn out this time, but it's certain that he will drastically increase in power.

But, this guy was stronger than I was before I ascended, if he underwent the same evolution wouldn't he be stronger than I am now?

To be honest I feel a sense of anxiety.

Basically, I don't think my follower will betray me, but the possibility of them unable to control their powers and go berserk couldn't be denied.

Although Veldora is nearby, someone of my level going berserk ——or rather an unreasonable level——would be a serious matter.

Hence I'll start off with performing the evolution ritual on only one individual to make an absolute confirmation.

I explained the circumstances to Benimaru and he seemed to have understood.

And, he boasted he would definitely not go berserk. What a reliable thing to say.

As Shuna's speech ended, I quickly tried to reward him.

“You have done well in this battle! You will be known as

“Wrathful King(Flare Lord)” from today on!

“Haha! I am thankful for this blessing!!”

The ceremony was performed.

He was usually friendly, but as expected before his soldiers he was their supreme commander.

Benimaru has perfectly differentiated between public and private.

Wrathful, it meant extreme anger.

Benimaru was usually impatient, but now he could calmly control his anger, his nature is like that of a raging fire.

As one of the (demon) lords who serve me, there is no better name than this.

So, would this be a second name, or a rank?

<< Announcement. Using fixed quantity [soul: 100,000], will you evolve individual name: Benimaru YES/NO>>

YES.

When I had commemorated him, I have also simultaneously sent 100,000 souls from the corridor of souls to Benimaru.

Once the souls were awarded, Benimaru's evolution ——— had not begun.

There was no change.

hmm, did it fail?

“There seems to be another condition....

This problem, seemed to be on my end.

I heard the voice of the world.

It seems, procreation becomes impossible after evolving from an Ogre to a Demon Lord.

Because the concept of life span would disappear, the ability to make a child does not seem necessary.

“Regretfully, until I complete my job as the leader of my species, I cannot complete the evolution....”

“....In other words, you wouldn’t evolve unless you bear kin?”

“U,mu...that’s how it is.”

Benimaru and I locked eyes again.

There were a lot of stare downs today, but my gaze was overwhelmingly stronger.

Feeling uncomfortable, Benimaru's eyes started to sway.

"You better be resolute, Benimaru."

I whispered silently,

"Momiji, come forth! I hereby recognize the binding of souls between you and Benimaru!"

I declared with a loud voice.

Benimaru looked down with his bright red face, however, a smile is engraved onto his mouth.

You look pretty happy.

Although he seemed like a hardliner, he was a pure man at heart.

I didn't dislike this, but if I left him alone, he'll end up single til the end.

...We-well, I am in no position to judge others about such things though.

Shuna looking surprised had widened her, but it seems she intends to bless her older brother.

The arena echoed with blessings and outcries of jealousy, Benimaru and Momiji received congratulatory words.

Well, it is only an announcement now, but after the ascension ceremony that was our victory celebration in name ended, I'm going to have to host Benimaru's marriage.

Benimaru and Momiji seemed happy, After I told them to come off the stage I ordered Shuna to prepare.

Momiji bowed down joyfully to me and left clinging to Benimaru.

The cheers did not stop sounding for a while, once I raised my hand the cheers finally silenced.

When there isn't time later on, I'd like to bless them just as it is, but for now this ceremony takes priority.

It was an unexpected incident, but I had time to spare, so we continued our progress.

Consequently, it was Gobuta.

Gobuta went up onto the platform.

“For you, no reward!”

So it was declared.

“EH!? That’s terrible-tsu! Then why did you call me up here?”

“That’s a good question. There is no reward for you, but instead I’m going to bestow you a right.”

“A right-tsu?”

Gobuta was confused, unable to fully understand the meaning of my words; he had a confused expression on his face.

Does he have no confidence in the words ‘right’?

I look at Gobuta’s confused expression with a broad grin.

“You are given the right to [“converse in a casual tone”](#) with me!

Basically Rimuru is telling Gobuta he can talk casually with the king of Tempest as he would with his pals, which he already does to be honest.

So I declared.

With these words, an even louder outcry of jealousy even greater than the previous one towards Benimaru was aimed towards Gobuta.

Even Shion and Shuna, were staring at Gobuta with scary gazes.

They seem to be jealous.

Or rather, I usually told them they could converse with me in a casual tone, but they looked like they were having difficulties.

Meanwhile, there were plenty of complaints given to Gobuta for being given the right to talk casually.

Because it was troublesome, I decided to recognize it as a “right”.

After all, this tone is something like a dialect, it doesn't mean they're being disrespectful to me.

It's clear when I looked into his eyes.

Gobuta had eyes that didn't even mind death for my sake.

Fundamentally, you wouldn't give medals of honor or money to a general class, they wouldn't need it.

Giving a territory would probably also be meaningless since they can't govern it anyways.

As for weapons and armor, since he had Ranga as well as their union skill it also wasn't necessary, so I was troubled in finding the proper reward.

Well, honor and authority were options, a system of formality wasn't necessary for us monsters though.

I just do what I want to do.

Gobuta seemed joyful,

“Thank you very much-tsu!!!!”

Afterwards, he bowed to me in a 90 degree angle and waited in line.

It's delightful not having to deal with the formalities.

He was probably also trying to fix his tone. However it didn't

seem to work.

That seemed to be the best reward for Gobuta, for that I too am happy.

Finding the appropriate reward was truly difficult.

By the way, speaking of Gobuta, Ranga is next.

As I called for him, he silently emerged from my shadow.

“Ranga, you’ve been a great help to Gobuta. I give you my thanks.

Well, from today on, you may call yourself “Star Wolf Lord(Star Lord)!”

Ranga gave a bellowing roar, and accepted it.

And then I began the Ascension Ritual. Unlike Benimaru, Ranga immediately began evolving.

Like what happened to me, the Harvest Festival has begun.

Ranga immediately went back into my shadow and fell asleep. Perhaps, his star wolf subordinates will also receive a blessing gift from him.

Whatever happens to him after his evolution is sure to be great.

Ranga running out of control didn't seem like it was something that we needed to worry about.

Safely back in my shadow, Ranga went back to sleep.

I called forth Gabil.

With the third army air corps, he performed an excellent aerial dogfight.

When I gave him my words of appreciation, Gabil meekly,

“There’s still a lot to improve upon.

People were injured by my command....”

I still have a lot to improve upon.

For the sake of using 『Dragon warriorization』 freely, we’re willing to put in the effort!”

He answered so.

He seems to be determined.

I felt nostalgic, I remembered the time when he got defeated by one of Ranga's subordinates when going with the flow.

His tendencies to get cocky has settled down, he has become an experienced general who can perceive his surroundings.

Through experiencing defeat and communicating with Bester and co, His original prudent quality has surfaced.

He's an existence that can be relied on now.

"I will grant you "power".

You have managed the army wonderfully, "Heavenly Dragon King (Dragon Lord)" awaken and show me your powers."

The souls were given and the ascension has begun.

The evolution of Gabil was dramatic.

His scales turned from blackish purple to reddish purple, magic essence energy wrapped around his body as if he was burning.

However, with the same conviction he used to control 『Dragon warriorization』, he didn't went berserk.

Gabil endured the evolution wonderfully.

“Uooooo~! From today onwards, I will be known as “Heavenly Dragon Lord”!

For that, I will master this level of strength!”

Purple electricity discharged about, Gabil's body appeared as if it was burned by energy.

It seemed to have succeeded.

Ranga went into my shadow and fell asleep immediately, but in his place I got to see Gabil's successful evolution.

As for the blessing gift from Gabil, 100 Hiryyuu as well as the [5 individuals of Souka and co.](#)

(There's a 5 of something ソーカ translates to sōka in Romanji. I think they're the female ninjas in Souei's group? Would greatly appreciate the help.)

Yes they are, actually it was "the 5 individuals consisting of Souka and co, and there's actually some males amongst them.

The 3,000 lizardman from the Blue Corps were affected by the blessing as well and evolved into Dragonnewts.

The 5 individuals of Souka and co had attained strength equivalent to Arc Demons.

The Hiryyuu folks had reached Majin class, and well surpassed A rank.

The skill “Dragon Warriorization” seems to have disappeared since they’ve evolved into the very thing itself.

In its place, they seem to have acquired the ability 『Dragon Scale Armor』 instead, an ability that turns their scales into armor.

Gabil and the rest already had defenses that were equal to Legendary class, but using this new ability would their defenses jump to be close to god class.

Naturally, not only did their defensive power rise, their offensive power rose as well.

Their race remained as DragonNewts but they received a drastic increase in power.

Souka and co, the females too had defensive power that was higher than usual. They’re appearance is usually like a human being’s, [but if they were their skin would unconsciously change into scales.](#)

If case anyone forget, the female dragonewts have a human-like form since they desired it, but the males looked like winged lizardman since they find no need for a human form.

Perhaps, when using “Dragon Scale Armor” the distinction between males and females may become impossible.

Through time, the reddish-purple scales had gradually faded back to their original blackish-purple.

But, the brightness as well as depth within the scales have been increased compared to before, it had obsidian-like artistic quality.

Even one piece of the scale seemed to fetch a high price. Well they’ll probably dislike it though, so there’s no point asking.

However, because I called Gabil a king, splendid horns had protruded from his forehead.

Due to Gabil’s conceited air, it complemented him well. But,

that's all good.

This was suitable for a “Heavenly Dragon Lord”, he had an excellent evolution that united power with dignity.

Unlike my evolution, he completed his evolution without the need to sleep.

He was quite suitable to be the king of my subordinates, “Heavenly Dragon Lord” was born.

Next, the people who participated in the capital defensive battle on the surface.

These three were Gerudo, Shion and Diablo.

There doesn't seem to be any danger of them going berserk, but just to be safe we'll do it one by one.

I will give out my words of appreciation and grant “power” to them.

Starting off with Gerudo.

However,

“I am thankful for the proposal, but isn’t there a person more qualified than I am?

In this defense, Rimuru-sama assigned Carrera-san as my support.

If she wasn’t there, the defensive battle would have been a lot more difficult.”

He declined the awakening to Demon Lord with the power of his spirit.

It's just a gest, but the rampage of the Orc demon lord [Orc·Disaster](#) was probably another reason.

Orc disaster was the orc that led the orc army against the lizardman and destroyed most of the ogres, but was eventually defeated by Rimuru early on.

Gerudo probably wouldn't run out of control. However, I can't clear away his uneasiness.

Besides, this is probably also a form of atonement.

He was a person that once carried the responsibility of spreading calamity within the Great Jura Forest when they were out of control.

His eyes shone with a strong will and unbending determination.

"I understand. Then strive harder, in order to perform a suitably distinguish military service.

However, there is no denying that the defense battle was splendidly executed.

Your work was without a doubt, wonderful. Above all, from now on you will be playing an active role in the construction of the city.

This time, I will grant this to you. From today on, you will be known as “Barrier Lord”!

After saying so, I took out the remodeled legendary ranked equipment that I attained during the war, and granted it to Gerudo.

There was a mixed response in Gerudo’s Youki; this piece of equipment will be Gerudo’s private arms.

The difference between Myth class and Legend class is based on the user’s own level of skillfulness with the arms.

The arms would constantly evolve over time. However, the

speed of the evolution rises incredibly when it's wielded by a skillful owner.

Because Gerudo's ability is specialized in defense, even if it's legendary class equipment, his defensive power will probably rival a god rank, that's what I predicted.

The big shield was prepared for him, I expect defensive power would further increase.

Gerudo received the rewards respectfully and bowed to me.

"I gratefully accept! I'll devote myself to living up to this new title "Barrier Lord"!

Gerudo declared, and went back into line.

Under present conditions, I don't have enough souls to awaken everyone. So I'll accept Gerudo's response this time.

But, you should forgive yourself for going out of control back then; forget all about it during the next opportunity. I want you to ascend magnificently.

Nobody's shunning Gerudo for what happened in the past anymore.

Though the refusal by Gerudo was unexpected, the remaining two people will probably accept it.

After all, it's Diablo and Shion.

You could even call them the evilest Individuals.

If these two people run out of control at the same time, there will be some serious damage.

If it was Benimaru, I would be cautious, but I wasn't worried.

Shion already has some self control now; but Diablo isn't exactly unlinked to rampaging though.

And so, we begin with Shion.

“Shion, I appoint you as “War Lord”.

Henceforth, please protect everyone without going berserk.”

While saying so, I granted her the souls.

But, huh? There was no change.

Shion was blankly staring at me.

We stared at each other for a while, but there was no indication of change.

A dud?

As a result, it seemed as though as if I didn't reward Shion, well this is awkward.

I have suddenly fallen into quite a pinch. In any case, I haven't prepared anything else.

That was what I thought, but something unexpected happened.

Although there were no changes in Shion, the members of Yomigaeri suddenly started to evolve.

Although I don't understand, since these are Shion's subordinates, things like this will probably happen. Because monsters have a lot of strange quirks and features, you shouldn't be surprised by every single one of them.

That's why, leaving Shion alone is a good idea.

Shion seemed to be dissatisfied, but after whispering to her about being taught the recipe for the latest dish, she nodded in satisfaction and went back into line.

She was easy to handle.

However, there's still Shion's subordinates the folks of Yomigaeri.

They seemed to have turned some half-spirit life forms. Rather than calling them a demon, perhaps it would be more appropriate to call them a Yoma.

It seems that they've evolved into a kind of unique race that resembles [spirits](#).

Not spirits as in dead people, but more like spirits as in Tree spirits (Dryads) and Fire Spirits (Ifrit).

They possessed bodies, but their existences were closer to demons.

They had lower magic essence compared to the Hiryyuu, they also seemed to have lower defensive power as well.

If you considered their immortality trait, it would be difficult to determine who's the stronger one.

Though they were formerly part of the hobgoblin race, they're completely different now.

Since Shion's ogre traits had greatly surfaced, they also look more becoming than the others.

Nobody would believe that her subordinates were goblins in the past.

It's unexpected that there were no changes in Shion, but evolution has in fact occurred.

In this sense, the victory celebration continued.

Chapter 163: Rewards and Evolution II

Now then, the problem was Diablo.

He would, without question, become the strongest among the candidates for evolution.

Not just the strongest among my subordinates, but peering even my own strength.

Diablo was now stronger than when he fought with Benimaru. His defeat at that time only fueled a desire to overcome such adverse conditions the next time.

To that effect, he was, even at present, the strongest among my subordinates.

Wisdom Lord Raphael had calculated thus, so there was no doubt.

Following Diablo in the ranks were, Benimaru, Shion, and

Zegion in that order.

Following them are the 3 Demon Dukes.

Zegion was a bit of a surprise, but Diablo was still many degrees stronger.

This Diablo was to be evolved.

With his strength now surpassing that of mine when I first evolved, his evolution is one that I highly anticipate.

“I bestow you with the title ‘Demon Lord’.

Keep serving me as my loyal confidant and as the leader of the Demons.”

“Kufufufufu, it would be my honor, Rimuru-sama!”

And the Devil was born.

Diablo's evolution put him at the highest peaks along with this world's strongest.

With Benimaru and Shion's evolutions being rather underwhelming, he was truly the one who could stand beside me.

It was done in an instant.

I thought for a moment that it was going to be similar to Shion's, but it wasn't in the least.

He had all the increased energy perfectly under control, and didn't let it show.

That's Diablo for you, only excellence.

The compressed magic rivalled or even surpassed the amount I saw before in Demon Lord Dagrul.

With this evolution, we have gained another great asset.

Could I fight him all out this time? Was my secret thought.

Diablo's Gift propagated through his lackey Venom, and the 100 demon troops subordinate to him.

Venom evolved to Demon Duke class.

But he was still weaker than the likes of Testarossa or Carrera.

Even being the same Demon Duke class, his stats were not as high.

Among the Demon aristocracy, there were such things as Dukes, Barons, and Knights.

In the first place, the 3 Demon Dukes that Diablo had brought along had enough power to almost match himself.

The three who had held positions amongst the strongest for so long wouldn't lose to some greenhorn like Venom.

It wouldn't be a battle of luck, nor would the increased energy levels give him increased intelligence.

This difference in level would create an insurmountable difference in strength.

Still, it may be my imagination, but Diablo seemed to hold back the propagation of his Gift.

I don't honestly know if that's even possible, I felt like that was the case.

But it was Diablo, so anything could happen. So this result was expected.

Diablo seemed to have the view that one must gain strength by their own means.

Even so, Venom wasn't that weak to begin with.

For better or worse, he did become a Demon Duke.

It was enough of an evolution.

Further, he didn't get in over his head after becoming the same class as Testarossa and co., and duly noted the difference in power between him and them.

His being Diablo's subordinate showed.

Well if he did get too ambitious, Diablo would probably have ended him right there.

Diablo wasn't soft on those under his command.

Besides Venom, there were others who received the Gift.

The 100 subordinates of Venom who here given automaton bodies from the Culture Capsules, have become elite Demon Chevaliers

They were not as strong as Arch Demons, but surpassed the strength of Devils. They could probably finish a Greater Demon in a single hit.

To be honest, their strength was unexpected.

Diablo exceeds common sense as usual.

But the person in question didn't seem to care, and left the Demon Chevaliers to the management of Venom.

Diablo's priority was to be of use to me it seems.

Even after the evolution, Diablo be Diablo.

Next, would be the rewards for the guys in the Labyrinth.

Zegion, Kumara, Adalman.

They called themselves members of the 10 Lords of the Labyrinth.

At this point, worrying about them going berserk was unnecessary.

But to be safe, I did their evolution one by one.

First: Kumara.

Her new title would be 'Chimeric Lord' Kumara.

The Kumara I had picked up, yet a small silver furred fox, was now master of several Demonic Beasts.

I had hidden her in the Labyrinth — originally for protection — but, at some point, she had risen up the ranks of Floor Bosses, and was now one of the Labyrinth Guardians.

I still remember her as a Floor Boss.

I named her Kumara because she was a Nine-Tailed Fox.

I had left her in the freshly made floor 90 where the adventurers would likely never get to, and she later asked me to name some of her friends on that floor.

It's important to note that I didn't accept just because a little girl asked.

It was just on a whim.

Naming monsters came with some high risks, but naming Demonic Beasts decreased that risk somewhat.

Plus, these beasts were like children, so I named them with no problem.

And that had resulted in a shocking before -> after. It was shocking to anyone. It was shocking to me!

What's done was done.

The Demonic Beasts being parts of Kumara herself, she had acquired nine names from me..... and her current strength was made possible by acquiring the dense Demonic Energy of nine named monsters.

It was past the time when they were just kids, and the 8 of the Demonic Beasts were lined up in front of me.

At a glance, they were each pretty strong.

Kumara successfully evolved into Demon Lord class.

Kumara's tails all became shining golden, and her hair, a beautiful mix of silver and gold, flowed gently down her back.

Was it only her beauty that evolved?

No, certainly her Energy also increased greatly.

Kumara was very strong in her original body.

But, only after combining with her 8 Beasts in Chimera Mode would her true strength be known.

Energy levels $\neq$ real strength, but their combined force was by no means weak.

In other terms, Kumara's being strong = the 8 Beasts being strong.

In addition, on top of being named by me, Kumara's Gift was also properly allocated among them.

It was like all the power given to the Beasts were unfairly transmitted back to her.

No one could guess from her appearance as a beautiful lady, but she seemed to be the cold and calculating type.

Naturally, she could not get along with the naïve and impulsive Apito.

From an Energy stand point, she now surpassed Gabil easily.

And this enormous power was still rising.

She desperately kept her senses, so as to not go berserk.

“Go back and rest!”

She was a bit frustrated at the order.

That part of her was still childlike.

I figured that she wouldn't lose it even without me watching, and made her go rest.

Probably like Ranga, after a good sleep, her body would be adjusted to the new power.

In any case, I was looking forward to her growth.

Please don't think I'm looking forward to her new beauty. I'm totally not.

Though her new beauty would be a certain reality anyway.

With that, Kumara returned back to her own domain.

Now for Zegion.

The strongest in the Labyrinth.

His Energy was equal to that of Benimaru.

His specialty in martial arts and ability to train one-to-one with Veldora made his level of power obvious.

And the heights of his strength was shown clearly, as he beat the 7 strongest sent by the Imperial Army in the last battle.

Now that I think about it, its like we're popping out Demon Lords left and right.....

It couldn't be helped saying it was too much; the souls had been granted to six of them already, and 2 had even finished their evolution.

There were those still in their Harvest Festivals, and I've been feeling their new power flowing in.

Was it really ok to grant more souls? I was thinking, but my body had been greedily absorbing all the energy flowing in without problem.

The process wasn't making them unstable, so there was no need to worry.

I needed to bulk down and finish the job.

Fear not, charge! was the feeling.

How much stronger could Zegion get? The thought gave me goosebumps from excitement.

He could end up surpassing me, but that wasn't an issue as long as I had 'Food Chain'.

Let's look forward to it without worries.

“You are strong. I never imagined you to become this strong.

It is thanks to your unrelenting efforts, well done!

Continue polishing that strength for me from here on out.

And from now on, your title shall be ‘Mist Lord’.”

“I am eternally grateful!”

The normally stoic Zegion trembled with appreciation at my words.

My carelessly constructed phrases sounded like excerpts from a holy book to Zegion.

He seemed to be looking to me under some strong divine lenses, but I appreciated his passion.

I had set out to gather up and save rare and endangered Insects, but they had in turn become strong enough to protect me.

Zegion's strength wasn't merely a fruit of effort, but also thanks to his insane talent in handling Energy, and also, training with individuals much stronger..... well, those were just the details.

He was strong, 'nuff said.

I awarded the souls.

He trembled for a moment, but then crushed the raging power with his spirit.

He proved that he was in control.

It was certainly not a feat achieved with effort alone..... but similar to Diablo, he had taken control of and suppressed his newly attained power.

To be accurate, it was not an instant transformation like that of Diablo.

He was also currently in a transitional state, but didn't show it.

His transformation was nonetheless fearsome.

He morphed his outer shell into the ultimate metal, God Steel, through willpower.

His body itself, a weapon.

Surpassing various laws of nature, he manipulated his exoskeleton into one that rivalled God-class armours.

He had become, without a doubt, the strongest in at least melee combat.

Melee was weak against spiritual beings, but it shouldn't be a threat for him.

He had acquired many other abilities, and was still in the process of evolving.

He was suppressing it, but his body was still being remade again and again.

I would later slowly confirm exactly how much he had changed.

And in this fashion, the Harvest Festival continued.

Zegion's Gift had only one receiver: Apito.

Those who I had 'named' and also remodelled with my own flesh were Zegion and Apito only.

So for Zegion, Apito was like a sister.

The Insect floors had many other endangered species, but the Gift wasn't spread to them.

After eating her fill of her minion bees, Apito became a chrysalis and came out reborn.

The enormous scale of energy flowing in from the Gift would have destroyed her current body.

But now she was reborn, to rule as a true queen.

After being reborn, she created several Demonic Insects.

The community built with these Insects would become the

new image of those floors in the near future.

With the power accumulated from the insects she ate, Apito became Devil class and attained the power 'Queen's Reverence'. And in addition to being one of the Ten Lords, she became a subordinate to Zegion.

Diablo had suppressed the propagation of his Gift, but Zegion gave his to Apito without reserve, resulting in her extreme transformation.

Zegion didn't mind Apito receiving this much of a terrific Gift.

But all this was a story of after the victory party.

Apito never showed any sign of pain during the celebration.

It was an effort to show her dignity as a queen; truly a splendid sibling of Zegion.

After the festivities, Zegion and Apito would become chrysalis inside the Labyrinth, and complete their evolution.

Zegion had attained a new power from the evolution.

Apito's 'Queen's Reverence' surpassed the power of a Unique Skill and became a pseudo-Ultimate Skill, the likes of 'Absolute Defence'.

It was an amazing power, yes, but didn't compare to that of Zegion.

He had acquired a true Ultimate Skill 'Illusion King Mephisto'.

A splendid ability, considering he was Veldora's disciple.

With this power, Zegion made his position in the Labyrinth unshakable.

Chapter 164: Rewards and Evolution III

Well then, let us now get to Adalman's team, the last of the Labyrinth group.

Adalman had large reserves of magic, but was weak against melee combat.

However, he was a genius who could use Holy-Demonic Reversal.

It was strange how he was so smart, considering he was missing a brain.

It was a power involving Mathematical Circuits imbued onto the soul.

Furthermore, wielding special Skills like 'Perfect Memory' and 'Soul Think', his existence came close to that of a Spiritual Form.

All ordinary physical attacks were nullified, and only Legendary-tier and above weapons could actually harm him.

It was similar to Hinata's Spirit Armour, and against enemies donning Legendary-tier equipment, it did not provide much defence.

Albert had been pushed back by such enemies, so it was unreasonable to blame him.

His weapon being broken, compromising the vanguard, was one of the main reasons for their defeat.

“Having been defeated, I cannot possibly accept this reward.....”

Adalman stated in frustration.

No, he was worrying too much.

“Don’t say that. You’ve done well.

I’m saying this, so believe me won’t you?”

To begin with, I had not expected it, but Adalman had beaten Shinji’s team.

He had obviously developed far more than I had anticipated.

His fight up with Krishna, one of the Emperor’s Personal Guard, was just a bad match up.

So I had already pardoned him, and was going to start the Ascension Ritual but.....

“Even still Rimuru-sama, I cannot forgive myself.

For me to ascend to the Demon Lordship same as your highness.....

I would gladly take the opportunity to become one, when I have earned it!”

He resisted my offer thus.

It was true that the Labyrinth was our last line of defence, and its defensive strength it was important.

At this point, rather than trying to protect the current capital city of Tempest, it was optimal to transfer all the important facilities into deep inside the Labyrinth.

The capital itself would then work as a place to host international dignitaries, becoming in effect, a vacation town.

On that note, the Labyrinth also had its Ten Lords.

And there was no problem with leaving its defence to Demon Lord-class individuals like Zegion or Kumara.

The Labyrinth I had built as a playground had turned into a fortress all of a sudden.

I wanted Adalman to attain Demon Lordship, but I shouldn't ignore his personal wishes.

"I understand.

But I will hold great expectations of you.

When there is another chance, be sure to prove the worth of those expectations!"

"Of course! Your highness will surely observe my worth with your own eyes!!"

"Yes. I shall remember those words of yours.

So leaving aside your ascension to Demon Lord.....

From today onwards, I bestow you with the title ‘Gehenna Lord’.

You shall work hard so as to live up to that name!”

“As you desire your highness!!”

Fu~.

Speaking with all this dignity really tires you out.

Anyway, Adalman was now also considered among my strongest subordinates, having received a ‘-Lord’ title.

From now on, his authority would increase. That is, if he was willing exercise that privilege.

Well then, Adalman wasn’t the only one who had been defeated.

Albert needed to get his get his broken equipment replaced.

He was able to use average weapons and armour with the skills of a master.

Were the Legendary-tier items taken from the Empire more suited to him?

-Was my train of thought.

Who would get to use the only God-tier set?

There was a reason why I didn't give it to Gerudo.

His skills would be suited to Legendary-tier and advancing to God-tier would be a matter of time.

Skill wasn't the only reason, but Gerudo probably wouldn't be able to use the God-tier set to its full potential.

At a glance, Calgurio was not a weak man.

In fact, he even had Skills and was a decent fighter.

Even so, he never could bring out the potential of his God-tier set, and only used it as a high defense armour.

A God-tier armour chose its master.

I knew this sort of secret info after much analysis.

Demonic Steel maturing over many years transforms into God Steel, becoming a '[Tsukumogami](#)', and attains God-tier power.

a living tool, so to say

Equipment crafted from such metals would be extremely underpowered in the hands of the unskilled.

For a short-lived human, gaining a mastery required for such treasures would be but a distant dream.

But even becoming a ghost with an unlimited lifespan, he was a soul who had not lost his talents as a Holy Knight.

Possibly being even better than Hakurou at swordsmanship, was Albert really not worthy of such equipment?

After all, most of the candidates to evolve into Demon Lordship had no need of new armours as they could make them on their own.

For example, Demons like Diablo could make their own clothes through a type of materialization power.

It was a very strong, perhaps even Legendary-tier attire.

But those clothes were only meant to be insurance.

It was a backup if the force field they put up was to be broken.

Honestly, I considered granting the armour to Benimaru or Souei, but that decision might be better considered after they were evolved.

In the first place, 'Nullify Physical Attacks' would cause most armours to be useless.

Furthermore, with time, it may be possible to improve Legendary-tier to God-tier, so it was alright not to worry about their gear right now.

Shion's Ōdachi, the 'Improved • Hercules' Edge', had somehow even turned into a weapon of Legendary-tier destructive power.

Kurobee's armours could be good candidates for evolution.

And there was also a matter of compatibility with the armour.

Anyway, Wisdom Lord Raphael-san had already determined Albert to be worthy.

In that case, Albert's reward would be the God-tier armour confiscated from Calgurio.

It was a Full-plate Armour that came with a Long Sword and Kite Shield in a set.

“Albert, your sword skills are truly masterful.

Continue helping Adalman with those unwavering hands!”

“Roger!!”

Speaking thus, I handed Albert his reward.

Having to receive it directly from my hands left him shaking with tension.

He worried way too much.

“Th-this is!!”

Recognizing the power of what he now held, Albert let out a voice of astonishment.

It was understandable.

These items were legacies from the age of gods, even their existence was debated.

For a knight, having permission to use them was the greatest honor.

“Can you make use of it?”

I won't let him refuse.

Grasping the strength of my intensions,

“Yes sir! I will make the best use of it, to repay you for this honor!!”

Albert replied loudly.

In this way, I safely handed over the set to Albert, and he was easily recognized as the armour’s master.

But I had made one miscalculation.

The true power of the fully released God-tier armour was beyond my imagination.

Hey no one told me this! The analysis didn’t show this!!

Wisdom Lord Raphael, hmm? I finally understood the reason for my overreaction.

She knew didn't she. That was why she advocated for Albert and not Benimaru.

'Turn a body of flesh into that of a Spirit Form for a certain amount of time'

That was the hidden power of God-tier armour.

A Spirit Form, in other words, a God-like Being.

Veldora was like that, and speaking of which, I was too.

I didn't pay much attention, but it was certainly a state close to being immortal.

Eternal youth was guaranteed, along with a strong degree of immortality.

I couldn't die unless there was a Core Break or Energy Roast

successfully performed on me.

Although temporary, to be able to grant an existence of that scale, this armour was fearsome.

But for this reason, it was not suited to half-Spirit Forms like Benimaru, and even less for true Spirit Forms like Demons.

The armour had gone to where it belonged.

Now, that was all of the Ten Lords done with, but we shouldn't forget Adalman's pet dragon.

That's right, the Death Dragon also did well.

I wonder what could be a good reward.

I walked past the 4 Dragon Kings and arrived at Death Dragon's feet.

Sensing my arrival, the Death Dragon bowed its head nervously.

Its fearsome appearance aside, it was pretty cute to be honest.

“I want to give you something too. It is a ‘name’.

From today you are the ‘Gehennic Dragon King’ Wenti!”

I named it thus in front of everyone.

And a dramatic transformation resulted.

The 20m long beast shrunk in front of our eyes and transformed into a beauty garbed in black.

This time I wasn’t so surprised.

With monsters, anything was possible. Having experienced this so many times, I wouldn't get worked up so easily.

I didn't have any complaints this time, its only natural! This was my character now.

I am pretty cool, if I do say so myself.

“Ah, benevolent and cherished God!

To give my lowly self such a blessing, I am ecstatic!”

Ah, yeah.

By blessing she means name.

“Ohh, good for you, Death —— I mean, Wenti!”

“Ah, master, God had not forgotten me ——”

“Indeed, this is also for our growth.”

“Yes!”

Such a nice master-pet love.

Yeah, good for them. I feel a bit like a third wheel.

Well, they seem happy, so it's all good.

Actually, my power didn't drain with this naming.

I had used 5000 souls for the process.

Wisdom Lord Raphael-san's analyses has determined this to be possible, and conversion to Energy was possible with

Gluttony King Beelzebub.

Clearly, there was a risk considering the amount of Energy possibly necessary to name an elite monster of Dragon-class.

I had named the Demon Dukes before using the Energy that Beelzebub had slowly accumulated.

It would be a problem if I went to Sleep Mode, from using up my internal stock.

The total amount of Energy had increased, and it was impossible to know how long it would take to recover if used up.

It was not ok to do get drained like that especially now that we were at war.

I had finally realized why the other Demon Lords didn't go around naming their Devil class subordinates.

At the very least, it was imperative to stop naming things during a war period.

This time, using souls as an alternative, my burden was nil.

Much thanks to Wisdom Lord Raphael.

There were no problems since 9 of them had already ascended to Demon Lordship.

Getting a human form would be surprising, but a dragon changing to human was a well known cliché.

It was not surprising at all.

Anyway, with that, the commendations and rewards for the Labyrinth group had ended.

On a side note, the 4 Dragon Kings were under Ramiris'

command.

So they were excluded from my list, but actually, I had something for them too.

There was a total of 940,000 souls collected, and to revive 700,000 of the Imperial troops, around 10,000 were used.

Well, some of them seemed to require a very high amount of Spirit Energy so, the total cost was a bit higher than expected.

And then I tried to divide up the 930,000 remaining souls between me and Ramiris but,

“Yeah, I don’t have any way to use souls so no thanks, ‘kay?”

She told me.

So then, I resurrected Michelle and Raymond as her

assistants.

It was not a partial revival, but a full-blown resurrection.

With their Nucleic Hearts intact, complete soul revival was possible, and they were still able to use their Skills.

I felt that that wasn't enough to thank Ramiris, so I granted names to the 4 Dragon Kings in a similar way to Wenti.

After all, they were worked to the bone in recent events and even died a few times, rewarding them was a matter of course.

Dragons who were said to be potentially stronger than Arch Demons, but their natural evolution had limits.

With that in mind, I provided each with 5000 souls and had Ramiris name them.

I was again using souls as an alternate to Energy.

The results were splendid and the Dragon Kings had now become true 'Dragon Kings'.

'Fire Hell Dragon King' Zephyrus.

'Ice Hell Dragon King' Boreas.

'Lightning Dragon King' Notos.

'Tremor Dragon King' Euros

They were named according to the floors they governed.

I thought up the names, but had Ramiris do the actual naming.

They all attained beautiful humanoid forms.

Their evolution was a success, and they had gained a huge boost in Energy along with their human forms.

To be precise, it was only a humanoid form, and they hadn't become Dragonoids like Milim.

Dragonoids were actually Spirit Forms who dwelled in flesh, so they were an Irregular existence.

Even if they were powerful Dragon Lords, as they were held in flesh, their power was lower than the 'Dragons', a true Spirit Form species.

The souls used for naming on this occasion was undeniably less than the amount needed to ascend to Demon Lordship.

But, their strength was said to be equivalent.

Demon Lords and Dragon Kings were inherently different, and more importantly, monsters weren't bound by many forms of logic.

If you think too hard, you lose.

And so, the process of evolving the Dragon Kings to give thanks to Ramiris went along smoothly.

By the way, the Ten Lords of the Labyrinth were fairly equal in Energy, but there were large differences in actual fighting power.

So, the 4 Dragon Kings also had equal stores of Energy, but were weaker in fighting prowess.

This was mainly due to overall fighting experience; their levels were just lower.

They seemed to be fairly frustrated with being defeated multiple times recently, so the Dragons had decided to undergo

training.

They had attained humanoid forms, and were also interested in combat styles in their new bodies.

Without relying solely on Elemental attacks or physical attacks using their fangs and talons, they would learn and incorporated Magic.

And by learning to fight as humanoids, they would later prove their might in battle.

This would work so well, that their new found strength would grow tremendously, but that was something I'd get to see a lot later.

Now then, the only ones left are the triad of Demon Dukes.

what I should do, was the question.

Of the 930,000 souls, I had used up a majority on ascending some to Demon Lordship, and on naming some, and in the end the amount remaining was 210,000.

I could ascend 2 more but.....

Was it alright to evolve Carrera as Gerudo suggested?

If I did, then there was still Testa and Ul. Which one of them should I choose?

These 3 were almost equal to Diablo in strength in the first place.

In my view, Diablo was a step ahead, but originally their powers were equivalent.

Diablo had to first beat them, and then scout them as my subordinates, so he had to be stronger.

Therefore, wouldn't there be a problem in creating a power imbalance among them?

Frankly, it was dangerous.

If they were not all treated equally, there would definitely be hurt feelings.

If it was just Carrera, I don't think there would be any complaints, but making the strongest one of them even stronger seemed wrong.

Sort of like, uncontrollable power would lead to her own demise.

After all, if she hadn't stopped her —— Gravity Collapse —— in the nick of time, the resulting mini-supernova tier blast would have decimated Gerudo's troops along with all of the capital.

She was probably aware that she could stop it, but that choice

of magic in that situation and place seemed like a red flag.

I decided to observe whether the ones who had already evolved could control their power before thinking of granting ascension to those girls.

On that note, as if reading my mind, Diablo would always take appropriate measures.

He was able to bring his new power fully under control, and was an all around dependable guy.

“Testarossa, Ultima, Carrera.

You 3 have worked well as Intelligence gatherers in the recent battles.

However, your ascension shall be granted at a more appropriate time.

I have considered Gerudo's thoughts on evolving Carrera, but I believe that doing so now would be a premature action.

You may be dissatisfied, but please understand."

"Rimuru-sama, please do not lower you head! We have not the slightest reason to be dissatisfied!"

"Exactly."

"It is a non-issue. We are already very strong as it is."

The three denied any and all possibility of dissatisfaction.

They were indeed correct in saying that they possessed much strength.

And they were probably stronger than the evolved Gabil even at present.

There was no need to rush their development, or create needless bitterness.

Its probably better to handle these 3 together.

“I am glad to hear that.

I feel like we truly understand each other.

But I cannot let you go without any reward.....

I will have you 3 be part of my executives.

‘Killer Lord’ Testarossa.

‘Pain Lord’ Ultima.

‘Menace Lord’ Carrera.

On this day, I bestow you with these titles.

You are still new to the country of Tempest, but I will entrust its future to you as my loyal confidants!”

“As you desire, my liege!!”

They lowered their heads in unison.

They seemed to like their titles.

With that, I now had 12 ‘-Lords’ under my wing.

They had been called ‘The Four Heavenly Kings’ or ‘The Ten Lords of the Labyrinth’, but my 12 lords would be known as ‘Rimuru’s Twelve Patrons’.

Well, I’m not too finicky about the name, but it should give off a ‘strongest team’ feel.

At this point, Gobuta, being one of them became increasingly bizarre.

My power to reward people was actually quite fun.

As I gazed at the Patrons lined up in front of me, I bemused such thoughts.

With this, the Rewards and Evolution Ceremony had finally come to an end.

Perhaps influenced by today's events, I would later be known as 'Chaos Creator' Rimuru.

Chapter 165: The Out-Of-Control Gears

The news had not arrived into the Empire yet.

However, for the Empire's citizens ignorance was bliss.

The Imperial soldiers who headed out to invade tempest, in other words their beloved families, were slain by some unknown means.

With a force that almost reaches a million strong, they never considered the possibility of defeat.

He would definitely accomplish the empire's earnest wish of conquering the west side; they never doubted the emperor who would one day unite the lands.

To the [unlucky northeast](#) in the Great Jura Forest, the evil dragon Veldora is currently weakened, there's nothing to fear anymore.

鬼門 means northeast, but since the author wants to reference to the fact Northeast is an unlucky direction in Japanese culture,鬼門 was used instead of 東北 .

Under the imperial reign of the great emperor, the greatest imperial army invasion has finally begun.

These were the thoughts of the general citizens. Nobody expected them to have a hard time let alone defeat.

Neither were there any survivor left, nor did they ever reach the western countries, and simply all perished in the Great Jura Forest. There was not a single soul who could imagine this scenario.

Yuuki received the report, and made a wry smile.

If the forces of almost a million strong was used well, they perhaps there's a chance they could eliminate the Demon Lord Rimuru..... but to think it was a complete annihilation.

Literally, the result was every soldier killed without exception.

Demon Lord Rimuru gone and the imperial army suffering heavy casualties, that would be the ideal scenario.

The next most ideal scenario would be Demon Lord Rimuru and the Imperial Army dealing heavy damage to each other.

If both sides ended up suffering major casualties, then he would have earned some time as planned.

He would launch a coup d'état before the wounded Imperial army returns, then he would assimilate the returning armored corps to form a stable foundation.

And while stalling for time as he recovers from the damage dealt by Demon Lord Rimuru, he'll use this time to seize the empire in his grasp.

When he opened the lid and looked inside, not only did the

demon lord hardly suffer any damage, it was practically a one-sided trampling.

Although he didn't lose any of his own corps, game pieces he could have utilized went up in flames.

It was an unexpected scenario.

But what's most startling of all, was how much Demon Lord Rimuru's forces have grown.

"Unbelievable..... to think he razed that large army with ease"

"It truly is unbelievable..... if it's an army of that scale, they would have strength on par with 3 demon lord armies....."

"No, compared to the Ten Great Demon Lords of your era, the calibers of the current Octagram are a bit extraordinary.

Take Leon for example, even when he's hiding his true strength he still has the battle prowess of a magic knight corps.

Even Mirim who was famous for having no subordinates has taken in Karion and Frey, two old demon lord class individuals as her subordinates.

There's also the demon lord who's been gathering territory, and is now the ruler of the Great Jura Forest.

Then of course there's Guy who's the strongest, alongside Dagrue and Ruminas dubbed the largest faction alongside their own forces.

Aren't the only weak ones Ramiris and Dino?"

".....that's true huh."

Although he originally wanted to refute Yuuki, he showed a convinced expression after hearing the explanation.

It's true, the situation's very different compared to when he was a demon lord.

Despite having their battle potential shaved during the battle against the angels, Dagrue and Ruminas displayed some ridiculous power.

But for the other new demon lords, even if they gathered subordinates to a certain degree, survival is still a desperate issue.

This was also a similar case for Kagari, or "Curse Lord" Kazarim.

More importantly, there's also no point in simply increasing the number of subordinates. This was evident from Clayman's failure.

For those whose strength surpasses a certain threshold, an army's strength in numbers is pointless before them.

If there's one question present, there should have been some strong veterans with a certain degree of strength somewhere amidst the armored corps, why didn't they play an active role is inexplicable.

It seems like Demon Lord Rimuru himself didn't take action, it was his subordinates who had devastated the imperial army.

According to the haggard-looking Miranda's explanation, she feared that Demon Lord class majin had also joined under the banner of the Demon Lord.

Bound to naught, they are like the king of demons, the highest level of beings, yet they followed a single demon lord, this was something beyond Kagari's imagination.

Someone who could possibly do such a thing, only "Lord of Darkness" Guy·Crimson came to mind.

"However, things have sure gotten interesting.

Currently, the Imperial army has also started the two-front war against Luminas.

Calgurio's defeat still hasn't been transmitted, and Gladim's demonic beast corps and "Airships" are moving to the north.

The defense of the capital is left to the hybrid corps.

In other words, if I will it, I can grasp the heart of the empire in my hands.

If we don't need to be vigilant about the armored corps' return, let's start our military operation with some swagger."

"So in other words.....let's just cut off the emperor's head in his sleep, something like that?"

"Yeah. That's right! It's a Coup d'etat."

These words put a suspicious smile on Kagari's face.

To bring forth chaos unto this world was Kagari's desire, no matter what the method.

Although things didn't go as Yuuki predicted, this doesn't mean they're in a bad position.

Or rather, this is a chance to seize the empire.

Plans were made; even failure was taken into consideration.

Yuuki was well aware of that. [He will result in profit no matter what the scenario.](#)

“転んでもただでは起きないのだ” basically means finding profit in anything, but it also means a greedy person who is able to do so.

“Understood. Then, I'll go prepare.”

Saying so, Kagari stood up from her seat.

Looks like things are going to get busier, she thought as her smile deepens.

Her face, as if lusting for more bloody and tragedy, was tainted with wickedness.

Watching Kagari exit, Yuuki was deep in thought.

Even though Demon Lord Rimuru's growth was outside of his expectations, but he'll be putting this aside for now.

Just now... he has obtained definitive confirmation of the imperial army's defeat. In addition, he had also confirmed the absurd growth of Rimuru's military might.

If that's the case.....he can only predict what will happen after that.

‘He’ will make a move.

With things as they are, that strongest existence will definitely not overlook this.

The destruction of the imperial army isn’t a problem; rather it was just what he wanted.

If it’s to send Demon Lord Rimuru to his grave, it doesn’t matter who does it.

“Now then, what are you going to do now? Rimuru san.....

I’d like to see how long you’d last. It would be splendid if this could end in mutual destruction.

At least, if Guy could get rid of Rimuru, there’s one less problem to deal with.

If you could also injure Guy in the process that would be great.”

Yes.

If his strength has gotten this strong, then Guy·Crimson would definitely make a move.

And things have already progressed to such a stage.

So far the plan’s still on track, with a few modification and the plan can continue on with no problems.

Yuuki looked at Chloe who didn’t respond to his words and slightly smiled.

2 commands left.

3 enemies to defeat.

If two of them could strike each other down, then his wish could come true without expending his greatest combat asset.

Although things deviated from his expectations, they are still advancing smoothly.

Yuuki deepened his thoughts regarding future plans in high spirits.

However, to interpret every event was a difficult task.

To realign the gears that had spun out of control was no easy task, things have already gotten out of Yuuki's hands, and started to advance in an unforeseen direction.

After finishing her report to Yuuki, Miranda swiftly began making preparations to leave the capital.

As a member of the military, desertion before the enemy is a capital offense.

she obtained this identity as a disguise, and yet it led to this.

It was a position she obtained after many hardships.

And yet they became her very shackles, truly ironic.

As a head of the underground organization Cerberus, she had no qualms about running.

An dark organization that has its roots in each nation like the freedom association, there would definitely be a “Cerberus” member lurking about.

Naturally, there are also similar organizations existing within the empire’s capital, and so her plan was to lay low, and wait for a chance to escape to the west.

She was so close to inveigling Calgurio success was one step away, with her charms as a “woman”, with a bit more effort she would have seized authority over the armored corps.

Even though it was the Demon Lord Damrada feared, if an army of 1 million was used well there isn't really much to fear.....

Expel the demon lord, and conquer the western countries.

And then, by manipulating Calgurio, be basked in the center of glory in the empire.

She should have made a triumph return, with a promising future ahead of her.

Yet now, she's gathering her belongings and escaping under the cover of night, do to something like fleeing this was maximum humiliation.

This was all because of Yuuki for underestimating Demon Lord Rimuru, and Calgurio for being so useless.

Damrada obeyed Yuuki out of fear, but Miranda only did so for she judged he has his uses.

It's just, since Yuuki was the one who founded the organization "Cerberus", that's why there's value in manipulating him.

Since her "womanly" charms, didn't work, she needed to follow orders.

In any case, as of currently the top priority was to get out of here. After finishing her report she had gotten permission to escape.

She should find a save haven first before thinking about pointless things.

Thinking so, she stuffed all her belongings into a bag, and fled from her house into the imperial capital night with darkness as her shroud.

In the dark depths of the capital.

Thanks to the benefits of a scientific civilization, streetlamps

have been implemented substituting lanterns. However they don't illuminate every nook and cranny.

Since the imperial capital is still under development, to dispel all the darkness was a matter in the future.

In the darkness of the capital, Miranda silently moves about.

Albeit inferior to Vega and Damrada, as a head Miranda does possess a certain degree of ability.

Even though she's making a sneaky escape, Miranda thought there's no need to be so anxious.

However that has led to failure.

It wasn't due to Miranda's carelessness, but there was a man standing in Miranda's way.

If Miranda left behind her property and left the capital as quickly as she could, perhaps she could have escaped from that person.

However, her confidence as a head shall become her downfall as Miranda confronted the man.

That man is Tatsuya Kondo.

Someone from the intelligence bureau, he was a mysterious person with an unknown identity who knows everything about the capital's darkness.

“Where do you plan on going at this late hour?”

“Ara? Why isn't that Lieutenant Kondo!”

Suddenly appearing before her, and telling her to halt, Miranda hid her flustered emotions and showed a composed facade.

However, she vigilantly sensed the surrounding for other presences, confirming Tatsuya was alone.

There are neither other figures nor presences in the vicinity. After confirming Kondo came alone, she was relieved in her mind.

To come here alone is like telling Miranda 'kill me please'.

If it's known to the headquarters that she fled before the enemy, it's going to be a problem when they start sending pursuers after her.

If she fled to the west she's just be targeted by spies, she'd rather be spared from living in fear of being assassinated on a daily basis.

In this case Miranda must eliminate anything that knows the truth.

She feared that Krishna may have used a magic item and

conveyed the situation. However it doesn't appear her abandonment was reported Miranda thought.

She concluded that since news of the imperial army's complete annihilation was reported, the empire's defenses must have been strengthened, Miranda understood this.

Consequently, it sucked running into the most troublesome man in the intelligence bureau, but there were no signs of incoming reinforcements.

If she got rid of Kondo now, escaping the capital would become easier.

In an instant, Miranda made her decision.

Miranda doesn't know how Kondo viewed her, but she decided she must uproot the buds of danger.

In other words, she decided to kill Kondo.

“You’re Corps captain Calgurio’s advisor Miranda right?”

Why have you returned to the Imperial capital in the middle of battle?”

In reply to Kondo’s serious inquiry,

“I was so scared, Lieutenant Kondo!

Actually, I’ve received secret orders from Calgurio-[Kakka](#), and returned to the capital——”

(閣下)Kakka is a way to address someone, much like -san or –chan, but for people with a high position.

Miranda approached him whilst replying, and snuggled into Kondo’s bosom.

She made full use of her “womanly” charms, to entice the

man.

With her usual method of charming with 〈Perfume curse〉 and 〈illusion series〉, she would impair her opponent's thinking while dominating them.

She also used this spell on Calgurio several times while he embraced her, and soon she would be able to wrap them around her little finger without doing so.

Even a man who was the Army Corps Leader was no match against Miranda's spells. A mere Lieutenant would never be able to resist.

Miranda was convinced, and placed her hand around Kondo's back.

Pressing her voluptuous breasts against Kondo while appealing her charm, she waited for Kondo to relax.

Once she felt Kondo's presence loosened,

(Fufun, I thought he was a serious man, but that was easy)

She snickered in her mind.

(Alright, embrace me as you please, once you become my captive——)

Those were Miranda's last thoughts.

Without changing his expression, Kondo tucked away a small pistol that he used to shoot Miranda in her temple.

He has already obtained the intelligence.

To read the target's mind through physical contact, this was the unique skill 『reader』 .

Yuuki's intentions, Miranda's objective, and even the fact there were no survivors in the imperial army.

To read all of this took less than a second.

And then, despite reading through all that information, his expression didn't change.

With an uninterested look,

“——A coup d'etat. How foolish.”

He muttered.

He then glanced at the corpse, and left.

Later on, a member of the intelligence bureau had dealt with Miranda's corpse, leaving no trace behind.

The night of the capital is deep and dark, and all that happens stays buried in the dark.

Guy laughed fearlessly without fear, and stood up.

He received an astonishing report.

Dino was sent to spy on Demon Lord Rimuru's movements, but he was unexpectedly useful.

It was rare for the Lazy Dino,

“I got kicked out of Dagrue's place, so I want to crash at Rimuru's place...

Can you help me write a letter of introduction?”

to actually come over and say such a thing.

To think that lazy Dino would move by his own free will, this was something that hasn't happened for thousands of years.

During the battle with the angels, there were several occasions where he'd team up with Dino against troublesome opponents, there were no other recollections aside from that.

“If there's something report about it, okay?”

Being overly chummy with people is how Dino rolls.

For the strongest guy, he doesn't really particularly need any spies, but it's going to be annoying to have him live here.

Putting aside Guy, [Velzado](#) will probably never agree.

Velzado is Veldora's frosty sister, in case anyone forgot.

If handled poorly, Dino might even be killed.

The only one Velzado acknowledges is Leon alone.

It's going to be unexciting to lose a precious pawn, so he chose to write a simple letter of introduction. but.....

There was a report from Dino.

Several Demon lords has joined as his subordinate, and the imperial army consisting of almost a million soldiers massacred, he said.

This was clearly abnormal.

The world has recognized himself and Rudra as the chess players in this domination game, yet there was an irregular that disrupted this balance.

Humans to Rudra, monsters to Guy, each with their own ownership.

Each also had a single "Dragon Kind" as a partner, with the last one Veldora as a free-for-all target to add some thrills into the game.

And yet another balance breaker apart from Veldora has occurred, an irregular.

Fortunately its affiliation is the same as himself, a Demon Lord.

As the strongest after Mirim and himself, the Demon Lord with the ultimate skill 『Gluttonous King』 Beelzebub, Rimuru.

It must be incorporated into his side no matter the cost, there was a need for it to become his pawn.

It appears the waiting time for it to grow is no longer necessary.

If Rudra destroyed it then it'll be left aside, but the situation wasn't so simple.

If it cooperates then all is well. If not, Crush!

Meeting the other part once sounds like a good idea, so he thought, and guy began to take action.

“Ara, doesn’t that sound like fun?”

He nodded and asked Velzado,

“You want to come too?”

he asked in return.

Velzado’s sparkly chilling mysterious diamond blue eyes stared at Guy,

“Yes, indeed. It’s been a long time since I’ve last met up with my “Brother” ”.

A cold smile on her face.

And so it's decided.

The two left the nearby "Shirokori castle" behind with ease, and flew in the land of howling blizzards, and frigid cold.

The tyrant has taken flight, aiming for the country of monsters Tempest.

Chapter 166: A Coup d'État in the Imperial Capital

Having received Yuuki's orders, Kagari had immediately jumped into action.

On that very day, 300 of Yuuki's personal troops had gathered in a mansion in the Imperial Capital.

A mansion was easy to prepare with the funds left over from the Freedom Association days, and with the Damrada's connections.

The ones who gathered had absolute fealty towards Yuuki.

It didn't work when it was unstable children, but when the summoned happened to be adults, they were unknowingly put under the 'Curse of Domination'.

Those summoned through the Unique Skill, 'Summoner' became, in effect, subordinates of Yuuki against their wills.

Yuuki wasn't the only one doing this however. All the summoning done in this world had similar practices.

On a side note, sometimes, there are those who try to summon Devils because they think they can put them under the fealty curse.

Aside from humans, or Angels or Spirits with weak egos, Spirit Forms like Devils, who have strong egos, will often Resist the curse.

There are such arrogant fools who delve into the forbidden summoning arts putting too much confidence in their skills.

Yuuki's coup d'état has been in preparation for quite some time now, so the people gathered were vaguely aware of what was going on.

A majority of them were 'Otherworlders' who had shown talent in the military.

They had climbed up the ranks relying on their own power.

Having no loyalty towards the Empire from the beginning, there were those among them who were excited at the prospect of a revolution.

There were others who were mix-breeds created by mating strong individuals of different races repeatedly, and still others who were slave warriors that Yuuki had procured.

In the Empire, might was right, so given the chance, even a slave could take hold of his freedom.

The Monster slaves gathered by Damrada were also present.

Such a thing would be preposterous in the Western nations, but the Empire simply had a different set of values.

For this reason, Yuuki had ordered the battle-oriented monsters that showed potential to be brought into the Empire.

Breaking it down: 30 'Otherworlders', 50 devils, 100 mix-breed warriors, 100 slave warriors.

In the Mixed-Corps, they were the ones on the stronger side.

With Otherworlders, Devils, and Officer-class individuals, it wasn't an exaggeration to say that they would be members of the Mixed Corps headquarters.

Ascending the stairs from a large open lobby, they arrived at the large room built for conferences on the second floor.

As all of them had sat down, Yuuki and Kagari, and finally Damrada entered the room.

"Hey, everyone.

So today, I think we'll kill the Emperor.

The enemy are 100 Royal Knights

Some of you have already fought with them in hopes of raising your ranks, so you know they're pretty strong.

But we have 100,000 troops on our side, so it's a no brainer.

I just got the report that the Mixed Corps have successfully stationed themselves on the outskirts of the capital.

We'll close off the 4 gates, and erect a force field to prevent escape.

And when that's done, we'll be scorching the place, and broil the Emperor.

Easy right?

So today, you can fight the Knights without holding back at

all.

They will likely have Legendary-tier gear on them, so capturing them alive is probably impossible.

So don't worry and go kill them.

Any questions?"

Yuuki casually talked about killing the Emperor as if discussing the weather.

The ones who gathered now had eyes full of ambition.

Their hopes becoming reality, they were ecstatic with being able to finally take action.

It was now time.

On the outskirts of the capital, Black Knight Claude had secretly gathered the Mixed Corps troops.

They were positioned there over the course of several days so that nothing would seem unnatural.

Just moments ago, Yuuki received report through ‘Telepathy’ that all preparations were complete.

It was proceeding smoothly.

According to the plan, the Mixed Corps would flow in after breaking through the 4 gates, and they would supervise from the mansion.

The Empires strength was the 100 Royal Knights, and 2000 guardsmen.

And around 20,000 from the Military Police Division?

Though, the difference in power between the army and the police was very large.

A difference similar to that of an adult and a child, they would only slightly slow them down.

The real threat was, in fact, the Royal Knights and the 2000 guardsmen.

The Mixed Corps would be pit against them while they watched the movements of the Knights. Then, they would target the ones who are isolated, and slowly wean out their numbers.

In other words, the Mixed Corps would serve as bait and rampage all over the city.

The Royal Knights were a threat to Yuuki, so with luck, he could turn them into pawns using Overwrite.

Their fealty to the Emperor would be then directed at him.

For that reason too, they needed to be reeled in after biting into the bait.

The troops Yuuki had gathered fell short in strength compared to the Royal Knights.

But by cornering them in greater numbers, and Yuuki stepping in from that point, he could increase his number of pawns without much effort.

Like that, they would not only overwhelm the Empire with numbers, but also turn their forces against them.

At that point, it would be check and mate.

There were no reinforcements coming for them, and rather easily, victory would draw closer.

“A coup d’état, I see.

It'll fail, don't you think?"

As if pouring cold water on his head, denying Yuuki's ambitions, Damrada stated.

He was a man who had a big role in building the Freedom Association and 'Cerberus', and had essentially become Yuuki's hands and feet.

He could make calm judgements, and had a strong nose for money.

Having unbelievable skill at determining the success rate of things, this statement of his was not to be dismissed.

"What do you mean, Damrada?"

"Exactly what I said. Just now, they got Miranda."

He took off his necklace as he spoke.

It had a charm shaped like a three headed dragon on it, but one of the heads were broken.

It was a charm that all three Bosses possessed, a Magic Item that allowed them to confirm each others' survival.

“The fact that this piece got broken, means that Miranda was killed.

Which implies that the whole plan was leaked to the Emperor.

And now that failure is all but confirmed, going through with this plan is plain suicide.”

Damrada explained calmly.

He had spoken in his usual tone, but Yuuki sensed something

fundamentally different about it.

Damrada's words stirred doubt into the hearts of those who had gathered.

Their faces that were brimming with confidence and excitement, now showed anxious expressions.

Yuuki looked at them with an unsatisfied expression and,

“Then we can just attack before they're ready right?”

He spat out.

If their plan was leaked just recently, they had the upper hand in acting first.

It would be out of order, but they would have to kill the Emperor first.

And if push came to shove, Yuuki would go personally.

As if denying Yuuki's countermeasures,

"It's too late. You're severely underestimating the Information Bureau, Yuuki-sama.

Your plan is too naïve.

This is not a children's game."

Damrada replied, casting a cold gaze at Yuuki.

"Bastard, you dare show Yuuki-sama such disrespect!"

Infuriated, Kagari thrust a hand towards Damrada's neck.

But Damrada gently gripped her wrist, and, manipulating the

flow of power, directed the force back into her wrist.

The force converged into a singular point, and the bones in Kagari's wrist easily broke.

“Gu!”

Kagari groaned, and took some distance from Damrada, rubbing her wrist.

Yuuki narrowed his eyes in confusion.

Damdada was certainly a master of martial arts, and his offensive strength was high.

But, Kagari was an ex-Demon Lord, and wasn't someone so meager so as normal humans could pose a challenge.

As far as Yuuki was concerned, it was impossible for Damrada

to win against Kagari.

“Damrada, are you betraying me?”

Yuuki asked quietly.

Depending on this answer, Damrada needed to be killed then and there.

“Betray? You say strange things.

I have already been cooperating and have sworn loyalty to you to a certain extent.

But I only did this temporarily.

That would be that case yes?

There's a saying, '[The rich have many friends](#)'.

(Originally, 'The end of money brings the end of the relationship'.)

In my case, I was being useful to the Emperor by being useful to you."

Damrada's cold voice echoed.

The tension in the room was thick, and no one raised a word.

Damrada was looking down on Yuuki's friends in the army who stank of greed.

But that Damrada had brilliantly gave the fearsome Kagari a run for her money.

Their impression of him changed drastically.

“I see.....

You were planning to use me from the beginning.....”

“Can’t deny that. It’s something like a specialty of mine.”

Yuuki now understood everything.

Whether it was the establishment of the Freedom Association, or ‘Cerberus’, everything went according to the Empire’s plans.

The organization known as ‘Cerberus’ was, originally, a base created with people that Damrada had gathered.

It worked as an Intelligence Division in the Western Nations.

It collected secrets, and sorted them by usefulness.

It dealt mainly with Nobles to get a hold of their weaknesses.

When the Empire decided to take over the West, these secrets would become power. Power enough to fell countries solely through blackmail.

Damrada who was entrusted with carrying all this out, had set his sights on Yuuki.

Damrada would stand out too much as himself.

Yuuki thus acted as a beacon that attracted all the attention.

In other words, Yuuki had been used when he wanted to do the using.

A tiny flame of anger was born in Yuuki's heart.

It was a flame called humiliation.

“So you’re the Empires dog.

Good job on deceiving me.

But to reveal it all by yourself right here, wasn’t it a bit premature?”

“Exactly, I’m going to end you here and now, Damrada!!”

Kagari agreed with Yuuki.

And she launched towards Damrada, still in rage.

Being an ex-Demon Lord, her speed surpassed that which humans could follow. Damrada was supposed to have no way of reacting.

“Too slow.”

Easily deflecting both sets of Kagari's sharp Demonic Clawed hands thrust towards him, Damrada closed their distance in a natural movement.

He didn't let down his guard just because he had broken her wrist earlier, and attacked mercilessly.

For monsters, a fracture could be healed in moments.

One had to have that mindset, or else they wouldn't survive long in this world.

Having gotten close enough, he applied his hands softly to the center of Kagari's chest.

“Spiral Penetration Break!!”

He released the power accumulated in his hands into the enemy.

It was a Secret Technique that destroyed the enemy's body with its explosive penetrative power.

Damrada's body glowed thinly, as if emitting a concentrated battle-spirit.

“Gufu!”

Kagari fell into a crouch, vomiting blood.

Her legs lacked the strength to even stand.

Being a ‘Drifting Spirit’, Demon Lord Kazaream didn't have the power to maintain a spiritual body. It was impossible as he wasn't a Spirit Form.

Which is why, he relied on a body of flesh.

To compensate, he transformed the body on the Elven female

he possessed similar to that of a Demon, and trained it to be peerless in strength.

Yet, she was disabled by a single hit from Damrada.

“I-impossible! A mere human can’t possibly-!!”

Kagari cried out while spitting out the blood overflowing from her mouth.

A Demon Lord being surpassed by a human should not be done.

Kagari glared at Damrada with such thoughts.

“Fu, you should think more before you act, lady. This is why you lost against Demon Lord Leon.

And also.....

You, being a yet unawakened Demon Lord, can't even hope to beat me.

Even that old man called Hakurou was much stronger.

I wanted to go all out on the old man, but unfortunately, I missed my chance.

Compared to that, you, lady..... aren't worthy of my full strength.

Sure, demons are unbelievably strong, but humans aren't as stupid as you think.

There are of course fools who rely only of their Skills, but with the right training, one can endlessly get stronger.

Like me.”

Saying so, he looked away from her.

‘Otherworlders’ could be killed by snapping their necks just like anyone else.

Having uneventfully killed quite a number of them, Yuuki was admittedly one of the strong.

Damrada possessed a Unique Skill that hid his presence and muffled his movements, specialized in assassination, it was called ‘Killer’.

Being dedicated to killing, it was an almost invincible Skill.

He was an aberrant who liked killing too much, and with help from Yuuki’s Skill, had returned to a calmer, normal state of mind..... but Damrada could easily revert back.

“See, relying on Skills too much will leave you vulnerable at critical moments.

If you don't train your body more, you guys are all useless.”

The gathered ones, who never faced ridicule from any trainer, were being spoken to as if they were utter weaklings, and couldn't help but get angry.

All of them reddened, and directed their murderous intent at Damrada.

Damrada felt no responsibility for the feelings of those he had betrayed.

Even if he had been a boss they looked up to as if worshiping.

If it was by order of the Emperor, he could even kill his own blood relatives.

Kagurazaka Yuuki was, for Damrada, a fine master.

He had a naïve childlike though process, but also had a cold-blooded outlook.

He had good ability to analyze, which Damrada was fond of.

He was different from the ex-Demon Lord crouching on the floor.

For that very reason!

Royals Knights No.2: Damrada wanted to finish him with his own hands.

That was Damrada's final act of loyalty towards Yuuki.

Chapter 167: The Segregation Point of the Era

On the roads within the forest at the outskirts of the imperial capital, 100,000 individuals have gathered.

Despite the number of people gathered, there was an overwhelming silence in the area.

This is proof that each and every soldier here is very well trained.

In order to relay the situation to Yuuki via “telepathy”, the Black Knight Claude has silently left the area alone.

The vice commander of the mixed corps, he had came here in order to contact Yuuki. That’s why, nobody thought Claude taking action alone was strange.

Due to Yuuki’s “Overwrite” ability, at one point Claude had his allegiance to Leon overwritten. However, thanks to Chloe currently Claude is restored back to normal.

But, after having his heart taken once, Claude has always been troubled about something in his mind.

What is the heart?

As expected, can the heart really be overwritten simply with the use of abilities?

And, can such a thing really be permitted?

Leon is a great man, whom he has taken care of since his youth. He was the strongest man Claude had even known; he was his target of worship and longing.

And towards that Leon, even thought he only betrayed him for an instant, to Claude that was was an unforgivable stain.

However, at this current situation he must continue to act loyal to Yuuki. If he starts to suspects and the fact his heart has been restored has leaked out things are going to take a turn for the worse.

After receiving treatment from Chloe, he has been training his heart with all he has, but he doesn't have any confidence in his training.

Although he sworn to endure the effects next time, it's uncertain whether it would succeed. He feared the chances of having his heart overwritten again seemed higher.

Therefore, he must be careful.

In order not to arouse Yuuki's suspicion, he must pay close attention to his own actions.

Leaving the group, he took a breather.

That Claude had been called out by a voice without a presence.

“Have you finished contacting?”

At first he was shocked within, but after identifying the owner of the voice he understood.

Chloe•O'bell

She was a Bishoujo with mysterious silvery black hair.

It would be hard to imagine from her appearance alone, but she was an existence with horrifying capabilities.

With a single glance, Yuuki had claimed her to be the world's "strongest".

"It's Chloe-dono huh. There are no problems, I was able to contact Yuuki.

But does that guy really intend to initiate a Coup d'etat?

It doesn't feel like there're that many merits in doing so....."

“Un. That’s true.

I can’t ever seem to understand what’s he thinking, it’s probably useless thinking about it.”

“Did he asked Chloe-dono for something too?”

“Un. I seem to be his insurance. Just in case something happens.”

“Is this related to the 3 command chances issue?”

Claude was wondering whether Chloe fell under the category of being bound to the three commands (wishes).

Was the reason Chloe smoothly following Yuuki’s orders due to the wishes?

Claude often pondered.

When he finally asked,

“Un. As long as I don’t reject it from the bottom of my heart, it wouldn’t be considered a wish.

So Yuuki’s first instruction of not bearing hostility towards him was excessive.”

Chloe answered with a wry smile, feeling complicated.

Isn’t she a little too kind? So Claude thought, but this is the one thing he couldn’t say out loud no matter what.

From his perspective, since she tried helping him nullifying the “Dominance curse” by rewinding time, this was something he couldn’t possibly say.

Since someone of Chloe’s caliber couldn’t manage to do so, no matter how much Claude tries it would be impossible for Claude to understand.

Feeling a sense of disgust towards having his heart Dominated, Chloe's probably thinking did he really retain his ego.

"Is Chloe doing not partaking in the Coup d'etat?"

"Yeah. Causing an upheaval in the imperial capital doesn't seem to be the purpose, so the vice commanded has intruded that civilian casualties are lowered to a minimum."

I'll just take this chance and blend into the darkness.

"Does Claude-san think of this as a chance?"

"——Chance?"

"Un. To return to Big brother Leon's side, I believe this is a great chance."

“I see, Claude understood.”

but taking advantage of this opportunity, this was a good opportunity to fake death in the midst of battle.

Under these chaotic circumstances, Yuuki wouldn't have the leisure to investigate a single subordinate too deeply.

After the chaos subsided, even once he realized Claude's death was faked, by then he would have returned to Leon's side.

“Understood. Thank you for the advice. I shall use this method to return to Leon's Side.”

Saying so, Claude used the clone jutsu “Shadow Knight”

A fake clone with an identical appearance, this is the “Shadow Knight”.

>

It's strength is about 30% of the original, and could continuously remain active for 12 hours. Since the consciousness is linked, it's also great ability for spy activates, it's perfect for this situation.

After confirming the "Shadow Knight" has returned to the group, Claude had bowed to Chloe.

Then, he began moving towards Leon immediately.

This incident had actually in turn saved Black Knight Claude's life, but the person in question doesn't know about this until later on.

Following up after Claude has disappeared, Chloe's presence has vanished without a trace.

She has received a request from Yuuki, unable to refuse she could only accept.

But rather than leaving the battlefield that is the Imperial capital, she blended into its darkness.

And so, the curtains of the tragedy that will soon be called the “Crimson Lotus Purge” has raised.

To begin with.

The “Scorching Dragon” Velgurindo had no interest in the game between Guy and Rudra.

Just fight head on and decides who reigns at the top, she thought.

However, if she must give her honest opinion, it would be considerably difficult for Rudra and herself to best the duo of Guy and her sister—— “White Ice Dragon” Velzado.

Guy’s the strongest Demon Lord without a doubt, and her sister’s compatibility with herself isn’t any good.

If sister and Velgurindo fought in battle, worse case scenario they would end in mutual defeat, both annihilated.

The possibility of things going well is very low. Or rather, 0% even.

Heat and frost have contradicting natures. In a word, acceleration and deceleration.

If they battled, rather than one of them surviving in the end, they would both fall. In other words, either they'd both be destroyed, or they're both unable to battle, one of only two results.

If her sister and her are evenly matched, the deciding factor lies between Guy and Rudra's battle.

If that's the case, regardless of the amount of ultimate abilities possessed, Rudra who's a human will always have the disadvantage.

That's why, even though she seriously wants a head on confrontation, she understood that will only lead to a high chance of defeat on this game board.

(Ah, this is so annoying)

That was her true feelings.

For Velgurindo who hated strategizing, elaborate strategizing and preparing for hundreds of years was something she's bad at.

That's why she left it all to Rudra, and she'd simply follow orders.

However, this was hardly interesting, she was dissatisfied with her current situation of being unable to rampage as she pleased.

Meanwhile, she was envious of her trouble-loving brother—"Storm Dragon" Veldora—which has only helped her accumulate more stress.

(That child really likes to act as he pleases.....but this time, unexpectedly he didn't appear)

The other day, Emperor Rudra had received a report from Kirshna, informing him of the complete annihilation of the Imperial Army's forces of almost 1,000,000.

That really isn't anything significant in itself, but what's extraordinary was that the reason had nothing to do with Veldora.

According to Velgurindo's initial predictions, she would have never imagined that her festively violent brother would miss out on this opportunity.

Although she heard he was cooperating with Demon Lord Rimuru, her brother isn't the listening type.

Assuming that, there was something that would have made her brother Veldora complacent, and Demon Lord Rimuru was able to prepare such a thing?

Thinking from that perspective, she tried imagining something that would persuade Veldora.

But, nothing came up.

(This is bullshit. This time, I'll probably just ask him directly)

In the end, she gave up thinking about it.

At that time, Velgurindo had received a request.

Emperor Rudra,

“Velgurindo, you're probably really bored by now too right?

Want to go all out for the first time since forever?”

He asked.

She jumped at the offer immediately.

Her targets, the foolish militants in the empire who dare rebel against the Emperor.

The emperor's target would be the foolish mastermind behind the coup d'etat.

And then, Demon Lord Rimuru.

The one who razed the imperial army, the new Demon Lord.

Banding together with strong individuals as well as her brother Veldora, she would most likely be met with resistance.

“Yeah, alright then.

Even though I don't intend on taking revenge for your pawns, I'll just think of this as cleaning up and getting rid of Demon

Lord Rimuru while I'm at it."

She'll just turn the fools into a bloodbath for warm-up, and then crush the newcomer Demon Lord Rimuru while she's on a roll.

After her rampage, she'll pave the way for Emperor Rudra.

If she did so from the beginning, there wouldn't be any pointless waste, but then the quality of soldiers wouldn't increase.

Allowing them to gain as much experience as possible, procuring holy Knight class individuals, in order to insure such a one-sided trampling never happens again.

If Demon Lord Guy•Crimson is the foe, there's no point having millions of weak soldiers.

But, the army he sent out with so much effort, only to have them reaped was unpleasant.

Even the time when Veldora annihilated them was better than this.

That's because a number of those who returned alive managed to evolve.

Resentment, fear and despair.

However, those who haven't lost hope will be able to break out of their shell and advance toward that step.

Even so, the situation this time is different, there wasn't a single survivor.

Even Krishna who gave the report, contact with him was cut shortly after.

After having a taste of despair, and coming in contact with one of the world's strongest existence, humans would gain the possibility to evolve.

In other words, they really died a pointless death this time.

Other than Krishna, there were also a number of Royal Knights who were mixed in, contact with all of them were lost.

If it's someone like Krishna, when pushed to the limit, he thought they would have used [Myth class](#) equipment, and survived.

Even though ゴツス is simply myth, the kanji 神話級 is separated into myth (神話) and class (級). Hence why I always TLed it as myth class rather than simply myth etc.

So even if things were a letdown it would still be fine.

Not a single person evolved in this expedition, it was a complete failure.

That's why, in regards to Demon Lord Rimuru, Rudra had some speculations.

When his forces of a million sent out after calculating their strength was completely wiped out, and when the report of no survivors came, Rudra became hesitant future developments in an instant.

For the first time, Velgurindo had saw doubt in Emperor Rudra's figure.

Rudra immediately began collecting his thoughts.

“I think we should think of disposing Ruminas first.

With communications between Demon Lords currently sparse, now is a good time.

If Ruminas's ultimate ability awakens any further, she will become a hassle to destroy.

I don't think Guy would mobilize Velzado just to save Ruminas, can I leave this to you?”

He described his plans.

Velgurindo immediately showed she understood, with a convinced look on her face.

Since they've been interacting for such a long time, they could more or less grasp each other's thoughts.

"So, after I deal with those guys initiating a coup it's fine if I kill Ruminas right?"

"Ah, Gradim is currently headed there.

Since there's a transfer magic formation installed on the airship, go join him."

"Ara? So is it ok if I killed Ruminas?

I'd thought you'd definitely want her alive though?"

“Fufufu. That’s because the “Soul refining system” has been developed well.

Using actual war experience as a way to train humans, but I’d never thought of using threats to cultivate.

However, since the procuring method holy knights is unique, as long as we control that place then there’s no problem.”

“Understood. So we let her live to continue cultivating more.

However, she really hid herself well. Who would have thought she would live in seclusion in the divine capital.”

“Indeed.

Thanks to that it took a long time to discover her.

I thought she would have moved into subspace and lived in a

false space.

Well it's probably because your brother (Veldora) previously destroyed Luminas's Night-Rose Castle, causing her to stay vigilant.

That guy's always been quite a thorn to me.

He's seriously annoying.

“Ufufufu. Then, if I run into him this time, I'll give him a good punishment.”

Towards Velgurindo as she was heading out laughing,

“Ah right, I forgot to mention this.

There's no need to kill off the idiotic rebels, just torture them.

When the angels descend, I was thinking about using them as vessels.

Even though angels are spiritual life forms, it might help if they reincarnate with flesh.”

“Ah, I see. So you’re imitating Guy allowing his demons to reincarnate then putting them to work?

It’d be great if it works.

Well, Neither letting them live nor die, we’ll just leave them there unable to escape.

“Leave it to me.”

After being told that evil plot.

she nodded cheerfully as she walked towards the outside

world.

After, after hundreds of years for she once again unleashes her full power.

Yuuki and Damurada are currently in a heated fist fight.

When Damrada was suppressing Yuuki's subordinates, Yuuki declared he'd fight him himself.

There are several reasons for this.

Firstly, he noticed Damrada's abnormal strength.

Arios who had awakened his unique skill 『assassin』 was rather powerful amongst Yuuki's subordinates.

Since he wasn't allowed to kill his opponent within the corp's ranking battles, thus this skill was sealed.

Therefore, even though he wasn't a vanguard, in terms of ability alone he was someone at the higher echelons.

In fact even when compared with the Royal Knights that had blended in with the subordinates, he was even above them.

To be able to kill someone with a single strike, if Damrada makes light of it things will get dangerous.

Another reason.

Not to be over-reliant on his abilities, and to train his own body, he wanted to understand these words.

These words are certainly advice. However, killing intent directed here from Damrada can clearly be felt.

If he's going to kill, he'll kill without giving any advice, this is the kind of man Damrada was.

This paradox is worrying.

That's why, in order to feel Damrada's thoughts, he himself wanted to become his foe.

Yes, Damrada could possibly be.

Their two fists crossed paths.

They've exchanged blows several times.

Carried out with superhuman moves, it looked as if each kumite move was choreographed, like a polished exchanging of martial arts.

with an unchanging face Yuuki warded off the hidden fist aimed for his vitals, he parried with his palms, and retaliated with a hand chop.

As if expecting that chop, Damrada withstood it, started rotating his body and delivered a double kick.

He then lowered his body straight down on the spot and performed a leg sweep, Yuuki sensed this jumped, rotated and aimed a kick straight towards Damrada's head.

However, that kick could only hit air for Damrada has already retreated into the distance.

It was a battle between two skilled experts.

Yuuki's abilities specialized in depriving.

That's why, when they exchanged fist, every time they came in contact Yuuki would steal a bit of energy.

Be it magic power or physical strength, this would be dependent on the target opponent, the stolen energy could be converted for his use.

This was a special effect of the ultimate skill 『Avarice King Mammon』 ; this was the root creating to many advantageous situations for Yuuki.

However, Yuuki's mind harbors frustrations.

One of Avarice King Mammon's abilities, overwrite palm has been walled off.

He thought he could have easily won simply by overwriting the information on the opponent's soul and earn their loyalty, but his thinking was too naïve.

While most would usually be cautious about the effect range of his ultimate skill, he thought he would attack him from a distance, but Damrada ended up engaging him in close combat.

If Yuuki's abilities can't bring about the deciding factors, then this was advantageous to Damrada who was known as the "Fist saint"

While the opponent would have difficulty resisting the life draining life-steal palm and overwrite palm, they weren't suited to dealing finishing blows.

simply draining a bit of energy took everything he got.

An ultimate skill must be defended against with another ultimate skill.

Judging from the perspective of this principle, that would mean Damrada is a person with a hidden ability.

“Yareyare. Could it be, I didn't think Damrada san had an ultimate skill.

Did you have it from the beginning?”

“It's borrowed. Of course, I was already in possession of it when I first met Yuuki-sama.”

“Borrowed? What does that mean?”

“Exactly what it means. A human’s body can’t handle the burdens of an ultimate skill’s energy.

Under normal circumstances, awakening is impossible.

That’s probably why the modified body of an “Otherworlder” is needed.

But, at the end of one’s training people will “Evolve”. Their race aside, there is certainly change.

In other words, from a human to a sage.

The result of evolution rather than natural birth, each sage is connected to the world.

Then, those who have awakened towards becoming a sage are

said to be those who have been selected as qualified by the Emperor.

Emperor Rudra-sama, in order to allow his subordinates to awaken into a sage, had often waged war.

To those who have awakened as a sage, he bestows them the ultimate enchant 『Alternative 』 .”

After his explanation, Damrada looked at the individuals who spectated his battle with Yuuki.

“Therefore, you lot who only rely on your abilities will never be truly strong.”

He said.

Within his gaze, it feels as if he as expecting something.

Looking at Damrada, Yuuki was convinced he had the answer to the question he sought.

and that's Damrada's sworn loyal to Yuuki still persists.

In other words, due to the powers granted by the Emperor, he could no longer turn against the Emperor.

His overwrite palm being walled off was all natural.

Due the dominating effects of the Emperor's Ultimate skill, it comes with absolute soul protection.

And now, this revealing this information means he doesn't plan to keep Yuuki.

At the same time, if you were to further observe, you would realize that leaking this information also serves as proof of Damrada's loyalty to Yuuki.

It should be noted that even though loyalty towards the Emperor has long been ingrained, yet Damrada still chose Yuuki. So it would seem.

If that's the case, you could interpret this as the ultimate skill 『Avarice King Mammon』 being superior to the Emperor's strength.

Yuuki determined.

“I see. Now my question is answered. Then isn't it about time we end this?”

Damrada nodded.

They both took their stances, and prepared to strike.

Aiming for the instant Yuuki gathered his strength.

“What are you playing at, Damrada.

Get rid of that irregular already, have you forgotten his majesty’s orders?”

Hearing this cold voice, Yuuki felt a sharp pain at his chest.

Without a sound.

Blood erupted from a small hole at his back.

It was obviously a fatal wound. That one shot destroyed his heart.

“Ugh, you bastard.....”

“Yuuki-sama!!”

Spitting out from his blood, Yuuki looked back.

and fell.

The crouching Kagari darted forward in an instant, and caught Yuuki.

However, she was aware that activating healing magic had no effect and was shocked.

The bullet shot through Yuuki's back destroyed his heart, causing a miniature explosion. This explosion was mixed with cursed destruction agents, affecting the blood in his entire

This was the effect of the special bullet fired from a small pistol——Necrosis bullet.

Koudo first shot a bullet that destroys magic barriers or curse type defenses——remove Bullet.

The instant the defensive effects were destroyed, the main necrosis bullet was shot.

This was a bullet that even could even kill dragons. Even the undying attributes of the undead would have their magic circuits destroyed by the cursed agents and ultimately result in death-by-destruction.

If it hits, even a spirit light form like a Arc Demon could potentially be slain with one shot.

If you failed to resist you'll definitely die.

Yuuki who was shot from behind wasn't even given the chance to resist and died.

Lieutenant Kodou tucked away the guns on hand and slowly walked over.

He just instantly shot two bullets out of his pistol, however since bullets weren't shot with gunpowder, so there's no need to

pay attention to maintenance.

He's just used to doing so overtime.

"Isn't this.....Lieutenant Kondo, it's been a long time.

However, wouldn't you allow me to do the final honors to Yuuki sama with my own hands....."

"There's no time to play around. His majesty is waiting. Get this over with already."

With cold words, he gave the signal.

Receiving the signal, several soldiers entered the hall that can house 300 individuals.

They were soldiers affiliated with the intelligence bureau.

However, they're in fact actually the emperor's royal knights, they're the strongest 5 no.6~10.

In addition to that, No.1 Royal knight corps leader Lieutenant Kondo and No.2 vice leader Damrada.

They were a ridiculous battle power that could easily massacre even Yuuki's 300 elite subordinates

Damrada seemed like he wanted to say something, but closed his mouth and gave up.

Since he was his majesty the Emperor's loyal, he understood the actions of Lieutenant Kondo.

Fairness doesn't exist in battle, victory is justice.

Damrada understood this, so he isn't qualified to complain about it.

Damrada quickly changes his feelings, and quickly began taking action.

In 3 minutes, all the rebel members within the room have been dealt with.

Kagari and co. who were dyed with anger were easily dealt with like twisting the arms of a baby.

Lieutenant Koudo was strong, abnormal even from Damrada's point of view.

Everyone gathered here are have been bestowed by his majesty the Emperor the ultimate enchantment 『Alternative』.

Therefore, to begin with the only one they needed to be wary of was Yuuki alone.

To be one-sidedly trampled by those who ranked highly in the ranking battles leaves behind an unusual ghastly feel.

However, with his emotions oblivious to the obvious results Kondo ordered the retreat.

“Lieutenant, what should we do with this guy?”

Royal Knight no.06 Miraza points towards Yuuki.

He is regardless an “Otherworlder” who has obtained an ultimate skill with by himself. If they left him lying around it may cause problems. Or so they considered.

Certainly Kondo’s necrosis bullets destroys all curse and magic effects. With the root of power destroyed, and the soul bombarded with destruction agents, it’s unlikely he’ll be revived.

However, isn’t it best if they still didn’t let their guards down? Miraza thought.

Kodou heard the inquiry, and quickly fired another shot at Yuuki.

“Let’s go.”

He walked out without even confirming the results.

The shot bullet——Eraser bullet——activates in accordance to Kodou’s will.

After 3 seconds, Yuuki’s flesh began to crumble, and completely destroyed.

Miraza gave a convinced nod, and left the vicinity following Kodou.

The same goes for the other knights.

Damrada looked towards where Yuuki once was for a moment, but with nothing he could do he turned and followed them out.

With Yuuki now dead, his only master now is his majesty the Emperor alone.

On that day, despite it being midnight, the sky was dyed red as scarlet blood colored rain fell.

Though the subjects in the imperial capital spoke to each other about scary rumors, none held any truth.

But, that was the last they could have the leisure for such rumors.

The era's starting to change in a big way, and the imperial capital will soon be engulfed by its ripples.

Chapter 168: Guy Crimson

The Victory Ceremony ended without a hitch.

There were some who had evolved in unexpected ways, and others whose evolutions were put on hold, but none who had gone berserk.

All in all, a success I'd say.

But we didn't have time to relax. We were still at war after all.

The troops that invaded Tempest were all taken care of, but there were still the Aircrafts coming in from the north by the sea — or rather, air — route.

I've already contacted Ruminas and Hinata.

“Hmph! I'll just turn the tables on them!”

Ruminas had declared.

I didn't think that that she would go to that much trouble just for humans.

But the Council and the Holy City Ruberius were in a cooperation pact with us.

A north western army was stationed around Ruberius acting at the Western Nations' interception force.

In other words, Ruberius, being on the western edge, was the best place to position those troops.

In addition, many Holy Knights were deployed by the Religion HQ, and Ruberius also had their its own forces.

Hinata, who was head of the Committee, and Ruminas didn't show that much hostility towards each other, and in fact, the latter was probably helping out in earnest.

Well, it enough just to be cooperative.

Ruminas may just want to be of help to Hinata, but her reasons didn't matter.

After contacting Hinata, I sent the reserve troops, who had come as out reinforcement back, to Ingracia.

If they were being maintained as an army in Tempest, food and lodging costs would bury a hole in our funds.

They would be swiftly deployed to Ruberius as support in case Ruminas was in a pinch.

Tempest had become the convergence point between the Council and the Committee's activities, so the other countries were busy preparing.

Soon enough, the majority of travelers would also flow through Tempest, but at present, Ingracia held that role.

But of those travelling independently, many took the opportunity to pass through Tempest.

Around a third of the soldiers and adventurers, rather than returning to Ingracia, had opted to lodge in the kingdom of Brumund and surrounding towns to see how things would play out.

They couldn't move to Tempest as the not many trade routes had been established yet, but they expected that this country would become the center of culture and economy in less than 2 years time.

They were wise to observe the situation.

For this reason, only the armies from other countries were sent to Ingracia, as they would be deployed as reinforcements for the north west army when the time came.

Though, if we could expect 300 Aircrafts coming fully equipped, that would mean around 100,000 troops.

Considering logistics, filling them up to maximum capacity was not probable.

Consulting with Calgurio, Aircrafts — or rather Airships, he insisted — could each carry 400 troops.

A minimum of 50 Mages were necessary for a ship to be operable.

The transport of the Beast Corps was left to an individual called Major General Xam'd.

“In all likelihood, the remaining of the Aerial Fighter Legion members would likely be scientist.

Most of the elite Mages were deployed in the Invasion Force in hopes of ousting Veldora-dono.

Therefore, including some extras, the ships should have around 100 Mages each.

30,000 for operations, 30,000 Beast Troops, and 30,000 Beasts.

In total, 90,000 was the likely number of troops approaching.

Also, Xam'd wouldn't put the scientists on the frontlines."

That was what Calgurio predicted.

Their plan was a simultaneous invasion, and the Airships had already been deployed, so they were left in charge of themselves.

Well, the prediction was probably right.

If the rest were scientists, they wouldn't be of any offensive help even though they were brought along.

And there would probably be a number of repairmen.

100,000 will be a piece of cake, Ruminas boasted.

300 Holy Knights, and Ruminas' own 400 Blood Knights.

The Blood Knights were the strongest of the Vampire Knights who were all A ranked themselves; They were an Elite Knight force.

However, as they were Knight-class, the lowest of the Aristocratic classes, their power was on par with the Holy Knights.....

Vampires, similar to Demons, gained higher levels of strength with increasing classes of Aristocracy.

High Nobility were said to have strength comparable to whole armies, they usually never came in large numbers.

Having 700 troops that broke though the ceiling of power known as A rank was, in itself, a great combat force.

Furthermore, there were Ruminas' protégés: the 'Seven Celestial Sages'.

These were apparently human Paladins who had evolved.

They were not Vampires, but their lifespans were greatly increased making them demi Spirit Forms.

Paladins were fostered in the Holy City of Ruberius, and then deployed in combat by the Western Saints Church.

After overcoming many of life-threatening situations, one of them would evolve in rare occasions.

When humans evolved, they became Sages.

Hero's were yet another thing, but Sages would attain strength on par with Arc Demons.

The highest Aristocratic class of Vampires had combat strength comparable to the old Demon Lords, and Ruminas had a decent amount of them too.

With 7 of these High Nobles under her, if Ruminas got serious, she could easily handle this fight.

Well, just in case, I opened up a transfer gate and sent her the Holy Knights, led by Arnaud, who were residing in Tempest, as support.

As of late, Arnaud had been training with Albert, and had been killed many times by Apito without losing heart.

He had gone to take Apito's abuse again and again, so much that one would worry if he went and developed any weird fetishes.....

But thanks to that, couldn't he ascend into that 'Sage' thing now?

His swordsmanship already being good enough to hold its own against Arc Demons, ascending would take him to Albert levels of strength.

By the way, as for Albert himself.

He had died a martyr while on the brink of Sage-hood; But becoming a Death Paladin, he attained monstrous strength.

The method was different, but basically, he got powers comparable to a Sage.

On top of that, his magic power had cultured for over a thousand years.

Along with Adalman, and under the effects of Holy-Demonic Reversal, they could ascend from Sage to Saint-class and attain Sacred Power..... to be honest, it was a rather non-standard power up.

Albert had let Arnaud peer into the ways of true mastery, and

was clearly better than the latter in swordsmanship.

His thousand-year training had resulted in extreme specialization in a single art.

Like that, I received a confident reply from Ruminas, and didn't worry too much about the matter of support.

And with that out of the way, the Victory Ceremony was done under a clear conscience.

The other side weren't done yet, and here we were relaxing, but there was no need to think about 'what ifs'.

Even time-wise, we had a lot of leeway; But anyway, the Ascension Rituals all ended successfully.

Now, it was the time for each of them to work on truly getting a hold of their new powers.

“Kuhahahaha! I’m glad it went well. I’ll head back to the control room now.”

“Yeah me too ~!”

Veldora and Ramiris went back to the control room with jolly faces.

Hey, that’s a place we use during the war, and not a play room you know?

It’s true that we’re at war now, but these guys just wanted to mess with the Large Screen to look for places they wanted to go play in.

The surveillance magic was low cost, and was continuously activated.

It wasn’t much of a problem, so I made it so that anyone could easily use it.

While it didn't show every part of the world, it had quite the range.

Those two had recently been enjoying the scenery from different parts of the world using this magic.

After the war is over, let's go have fun! Is what I had said before, which triggered this behaviour.

They were carefully researching what places to go beforehand.

A good comparison would be, as if doing a field survey before going on a trip?

These two had been living for so long, yet hadn't properly experienced the world. They were looking forward to it much more than I was.

Well, they're having fun, so It's all good.

“Okay. I’ll join you guys later.”

I said as I saw them off.

Jeez, I guess I’m going to have to properly guide their research.

It’s because I feel responsible as their guardian.

It is certainly not me also wanting to have fun.

Veldora and Ramiris went back into the Labyrinth, and the Executives also went back after their salutations.

Some of them were still desperately trying to control the powers gained from evolution, and I asked them not to rush it as I saw them off.

The ones in charge of domestic affairs like Rigrudo or

Myourmilles started the cleanup. I was very grateful.

Myourmilles was even managing the affairs of all the ambassadors visiting from other nations.

And he didn't forget to put in a word about our planned yearly events, or about the specialty products of the Labyrinth.

He was a truly useful investment, and now had become an indispensable person to us.

As I gave them my words of appreciation, they all smiled broadly.

But then it happened.

“Alert. Detecting entity with high density Energy fast approaching. Arrival at this location in 3 seconds.”

Wisdom Lord Raphael issued an emergency alert.

I hurriedly set up a force field to protect everyone here.

Raphael's presence detection range is around 20km.

To arrive only 3 seconds after being detected meant that it was going at an unthinkable speed.

It was coming at more than Mach 20, and it wasn't possible to warn anyone verbally.

Now was not time to be impressed with the insane speed.

Just as I set up an Absolute Barrier with Covenant King Uriel, a single man descended following a shockwave.

The stone floor of the arena, that was 10,000 times stronger than concrete, now had a large gash on it.

What a guy. The destruction was not caused by any Skills or techniques; it was simply from the impact with his body.

For Demon Dukes, it was possible to ignore the laws of physics and travel at super sonic speeds without causing shockwaves but.....

This guy came in without using any law manipulations just because it was cumbersome.

There weren't many who can afford to do something insane like this.

Three to my knowledge.

Veldora, Milim, and Demon Lord Guy Crimson.

Veldora was out.

And Milim was also careful in her own way when she came over.

I realized this later, but even the first time she came, she had tried her best to be careful.

If Milim had flown over with her full strength, it would be enough to blow away any weak monsters.

She may seem like a tyrant, but she had a surprisingly kind side.

Well, now that Milim was also out, we're left with the last option.

Sure enough, when the dust had settled, there stood the Demon Lord with blazing red hair.

Demon Lord Guy • Crimson.

A ruler in this world probably stronger than myself.

The scene was submerged in tension, and civilians like Rigrudo and Myourmilles were being evacuated by Souei's Shadows.

What's up with this guy?

I don't wanna fight right now okay?

"Yo, it's been a while, Rimuru. By the way, what the hell do you think you're doing?"

"What am I doing? What are YOU doing!?"

What can I say, Guy was just casually talking.

He just suddenly came over with no reason I know of.

“Mm? I see, you’re the type who cares for their underlings.

Well, sorry about that. And —— Napalm Burst!”

As he said some words of apology, Guy suddenly shot out a Heat Explosion type magic.

The Infernal flames swelled into the shape of a dragon and weaved into the direction of the ones who were closing in on Guy from behind him.

Testarossa, Ultima, and Carrera.

The dragons split in into three, and entangled the girls.

Unbelievably, the Demon Dukes who had strong resistance to magic could not defend against Guy’s attack.

Eating through multiple layers of Magic Barriers, the Infernal

Dragons dealt decisive damage to all three of them.

Though I myself am also able to do it, casting this strong a magic without any incantations somehow didn't sit well with me.

“Awawa. That's surprising.

The last attack didn't kill them meaning, they're Demon Dukes?

Are there still more of those in the Underworld, or are have they evolved here?

Well, its fine.

Demon Dukes are stronger than unawakened Demon Lords.

But the awakened Demon Lord presences I felt a while ago,

what's up with those?"

Ignoring the three, who lay on the ground having failed to defend against his magic, Guy spoke.

Are you kidding me? He sensed the awakening from that far away?

Is what I was thinking when,

"Solution. If connected to the Voice of the World, an instance awakening can be sensed from any location."

I was reassured with Wisdom Lord Raphael-san's words.

So that also meant that when someone attains an Ultimate Skill.....

"Solution. It is possible. However, sensing may not be possible

when in possession of multiple Ultimate Skills.”

I see.

I had easily sense it when Yuuki got one, so that must be the reason.

I kind of wanted to be informed of these kinds of things, but it seems Wisdom Lord Raphael’s policy was to only answer when asked.

Ruminas also seemed to possess an Ultimate.

However, the type of power couldn’t be determined without collecting information about it or seeing it directly.

I thought that Guy somehow found out about my Ultimate Skills, but hiding them was actually impossible.

So if there was an Ultimate Skill already present, new ones would not be detected.

Which mean that, Guy hasn't realized that I have multiple Ultimates?

“Solution. There is no cause for concern. Gluttony King Beelzebub has been put out as the only one, and the rest are being hidden.”

As expected of sensei.

If we leave it to her, even Guy can be easily fooled.

Though I still can't relax thinking he doesn't know.

The previous conversation with Raphael only took an instant, and it was time to think about handling Guy.

The three who had attacked had sensed his dangerously high power level, quickly moved to eliminate the foe.

Indeed, he had an abnormal amount of high density magic, and the arena had also been damaged.

Considering that he was an unknown in both combat ability and relations, the option to pre-emptively strike was not necessarily unwise.

They were probably thinking of me, and attacked without mercy.

However, their enemy a bad matchup.

The surprise attack of the three Demon Dukes, wasn't even near the level of being a problem for Guy, the strongest Demon Lord.

If it was me, I might have landed a hit.

That aside, it was the matter of magic.

What in the world do you have to do to cause magic damage to Demon Dukes?

“Solution. It is Effect Overlap. It seems that he is overlapping the effects of an Ultimate Skill with that of magic.”

Is that possible? It must be possible.

After all, I saw the result with my own eyes.

Well, if it's possible, I want to try it.

Leaving that matter to Raphael-san, I needed to focus on answering Guys question.

“What's going on? Well, even if you say that.....

Those three felt you were a danger and attacked, please forgive them.

But, suddenly appearing like this, you share the blame too you know?

I'll ignore the broken floor, so no hard feeling alright?"

"Mm? Ah, yeah sorry about that.

I can just teleport to places I've already been to, and its been a while since I went flying.

Put in a bit too much power, and couldn't stop. My bad!

I don't really care about those three, so don't worry.

Demons can't help but fight.

Rather, I need you to explain the ascended ones over there okay?”

I could comfortably work with those conditions.

In any case, I had dodged starting a war with Guy.

Or rather, I’m seriously glad, he didn’t come over to destroy me or something.

Diablo had already sensed that Guy didn’t have an enmity, but the Demon Dukes still needed to work on that.

We didn’t have the option of immediate elimination with everyone. Now they were in Diablo’s care, probably already sitting in his severe lecturing course.

And it’s good that most others were unable to move from his pressure, or were in the Labyrinth undergoing their evolution.

It would be a pain, if the lot of them wanted a fight too.

That being said, Shion who's always looking for a fight, was now close beside me paying attention to Guy.

She had understood the different in power, and decided to at least act as a shield for me.

That was really surprising; She has truly matured.

Anyway, Guy looks to not have any blatant enmity, so everyone should be more relaxed.

With that in mind, I went about guiding Guy to a guest room.

Chapter 169: Negotiations with Guy

Rather than standing around chatting, we decided to head inside.

I guided Guy towards a VIP lounge located in Tempest.

Its furnishings were chosen by Myourmilles, and if he went on a rampage there we would incur heavy losses.

Some expensive pieces of artwork had also been displayed.

It was a special lounge where only the specially selected, or the highest of nobles were accommodated.

Showy things aside, the arrangements also allowed one to experience elegance, simplicity, and a subdued refinement, which truly showed Myourmilles' sensitivity to my own tastes.

To reach this level, Rigurdo and the others still needed much more experience. However, since he had said something like

「This place is very calming.」, our tastes may unexpectedly match.

Returning to the topic, if Guy went on a rampage we'd handle that then.

Since we had no other suitable rooms to accommodate him, we had no choice but to expect a certain level of damage. We couldn't just take the strongest of the Demon Lords to a common guest lounge.

And whilst half-resignedly guiding him,

「Hey, You've got some good taste. I also happen to like this type of furnishings.」

Guy complemented.

That was pretty surprising, as far as surprises go.

I had misunderstood him as this tyrant who wouldn't have any idea of subtle elegance.

No, when you think about it, even Oda Nobunaga may have perhaps had this sort of taste.....

Maybe, the more short tempered and violent ones were more likely to have peaceful hearts.

No well, it might just be my mistaken impression, but it really was the right choice bringing him here.

Sitting on a high-class wooden chair carved from aromatic woods, I faced Guy.

On top of a small table between us, tea was served and its aroma wafted through the room.

It looked simple at first glance, but a surprising amount of attention to details was put in.....

「You're pretty good! Our dimwits wouldn't be able to pull this off at all.

I wonder if should I should send them here for some training?」

Well I'm glad you're pleased.

Or rather, even since I came to this world, I've been doing nothing but what I pleased.

In any case, this was the first time I had to be this careful around the other party.

No, after meeting Veldora, this would be the second time?

Putting aside whether or not I can win against him, I just wanted to avoid conflict as much as possible.

It's too troublesome to deal with. Because it will definitely result in some broken things.

「Oh really? You're actually the first one I've brought here you know.

This is the highest grade parlor we have, we only bring in those who we want to make a good impression on.」

「Ah? So you want to make a good impression on me?」

「Yeah that's right. Or else I couldn't call myself a good Demon Lord now could I.

If I had thrown away my pride, I'd be living a more or less good life snooping around in the shadows.」

I started with a jab.

I'm not gonna be pulled along with your pace, I made my statement with this intention.

Depending on his reaction, I was going to have to adjust my attitude towards Guy.

In any case, I had to, first and foremost, to find out the reason he came here.

I suspected that he must have gotten a report from somebody, when he mentioned the Demon Lords.

Probably, the only one who would do this was Dino. In fact, he confessed so himself.

After all, any spies within the country had been completely cleared out. This I could say with full confidence.

With the surveillance network spread out by Souei, and by using magic to detect malevolence, we could absolutely eliminate any kind of counter-intelligence activity.

In any case, since I put intelligence gathering above all else, not letting the enemy do the same thing to us was just common sense.

I had used any and all means I could come up with to eliminate all spies within my country.

「Ahaha. Are you trying to probe me? Aren't you interesting!

Oh well, let's save ourselves the trouble.

I came today because I heard you're having a fight with the empire.

Ah, and as you might have expected, I heard this from Dino.

He's here right? In this place.

Well, I've gotten a report from that guy, but I heard you've

slain around a million people?

And, you've also got a number of Demon Lord class subordinates under you.

This reminded me about that fellow you brought in during the previous Walpurgis, and that got me interested in any others you've got.]

Saying all that, he drank the black tea with elegant movements.

The way he held himself, It was as if he was the king of some country.

No, Demon Lords were more or less kings anyway.

But, that Guy. Right after declaring that he wouldn't probe, threw a straight ball.

Basically, he wants to see my strength. No, isn't there more?

Isn't he oddly interested in my dealings with the Empire?

「Indeed, I do have several Demon Lord class subordinates.

The 3 you knocked out earlier are also included.

Naturally, there are others. But I have no intention to tell you about all of them.

In the wars of this world, isn't individual strength more important than numbers?

Raising individual strength is naturally important.」

「I see, so there are others.

Or rather, are you an “Otherworlder”?

And a slime, for that matter?」

「Nn? Huh? You didn’t know?

I’m a slime that has retained the heart of an “Otherworlder”,
A “Reincarnator” you know?」

「Seriously?」

「Seriously!」

Guy and I locked eyes with each other.

Or rather, he didn’t know. I thought for sure something like
that was well known.

I had already declared this to the world, and thought it was surely passed along to the kings of each country.

It may have only been my impression that all the information was known by everyone.

I don't think there was any miswording, but it seems I needed to consider them not receiving any information. I'll make sure to consider it next time.

「Ahahahaha! Oh Wow! To think such a thing could happen!

No wonder you like that human form despite being a monster.

You've got an impressive mimicry going, but this explains the reason behind your fixation.

I see, that also explains how you're able to obtain an Ultimate Skill.

Under normal circumstances, it isn't something you can obtain so easily.

But if a soul was able to preserve its ego after "World Crossing", of course that soul would get much stronger.

I was suspicious that Rudra was just performing some self-scripted act, but if that's the case, then I'm convinced.

My bad for doubting you.」

Hm? Self-scripted?

It was curious so I inquired the details.

The story goes, Emperor Rudra and Guy had been at odds for over a thousand years.

And in the midst of that, I had appeared.

I had suddenly awakened as a true Demon Lord, and even obtained an Ultimate Skill.

At first, it seemed that I had something to do with Veldora's resurrection, and they had decided to take a wait-and-see approach, but the recent conflict with the Imperial army raised a bit of suspicion.

According to Dino's report, we escaped unharmed, and the imperial army was massacred.

At this point, Guy was thinking something was up.

Against only a single demon lord, could Rudra—that's the emperor—actually suffer such a crushing defeat?

Despite wanting to wait-and-see, there was no point in suffering that much of a loss.

It seems Rudra's purpose was likely to promote evolution amongst the survivors.

He didn't care even if there were only 10s of survivors.

Once upon a time, when Veldora had rounded-up and killed a lot of them, since some survivors managed to evolve into Sages, Rudra didn't feel it was his loss.

He made up an understandable reason to appease the public, and trained the army by putting them in danger; Then, having the survivors evolve was the Rudra's basic combat strategy.

Guy also approved the Demon Lords fighting each other was also for a similar reason.

To clash, and then rise up as true Demon Lords, was the end result that he expected.

That being the case, both Guy and Rudra were fighting as if playing a long game of chess.

As if killing time, it was a game of patience.

But, the number of survivors this time was 0.

There was the problem.

Guy couldn't leave alone the fact that I had gained multiple Demon Lord class subordinates, and that there was not a single survivor.

The reason was simple.

A meaningless military action was something Rudra would never allow.

He must have acted with some kind of purpose in mind.....

In Dino's report, he hinted that he was of the same opinion. What the hell are you even doing, Dino.

So Guy suspected a self-scripted act.

Causing a grand military campaign, pretending to go to war with Demon Lord Rimuru in order to strengthen Rimuru's forces.

In other words, I had betrayed Guy's Demon Lord faction, and joined Emperor Rudra is it? This was the gist of his doubts.

Or rather, he even thought that I could be a spy sent by Emperor Rudra right from the beginning.

A just recently born monster (Slime) obtaining an Ultimate Skill, normally this would be inconceivable.

Couldn't it be that due to the Emperor's instigation, it was given an Ultimate Skill and evolved? So he thought.

「To give away Ultimate Skills to someone, is that even possible?」

「If it's this kind of ability, then it's not impossible. However, it's limited to only granting an inferior form.

And the receiving target must be someone above a certain strength threshold, it's not to the extent of being a threat.]

I wanted to hear more because I had doubts, but then he just dropped a bombshell of an announcement on me.

Or rather, you're the only one who'd say someone with an Ultimate Skill was not a threat, dammit! I wanted to shout.

Perhaps, Milim's in the same category as Guy.

Their perspective of things tended to be somewhat skewed.

His words and appearance of enjoyably eating cake were in complete contrast.

Wait a minute, he's talking about something important right now.

Undeceived by his appearance, I needed to keep calm and organize this information.

I stabbed the fork into my own cake whilst sorting it all out in my head.

When it comes to thinking, sugar intake is very important.

A self-scripted act. (EN: hypothetical scenario here.)

When the emperor released and dominated Veldora, he bestowed an ability onto a slime he found there.

With the slime under the protection of Veldora, he would bring the Great Jura Forest together, and awaken as a Demon Lord.

Guy predicted that with Veldora's help, awakening as a Demon Lord would be a simple matter.

However, since Veldora's presence couldn't be felt for some unknown reason, he didn't completely trust this prediction.

Up till there, it was fine.

After that, as the slime awakened as a Demon Lord, Veldora had revived simultaneously .

There was definitely some kind of relation between these two events.

The slime, as one of the Demon Lords, would infiltrate Guy's faction.

It would crush and devour Guy's faction from the inside, befitting the name of Gluttonous King Belzebuth.

This time, after getting a report about there being no survivors, he decided to drop by and check on the situation himself.

As Emperor Rudra and Guy were at constant war, if I really were on the emperor's side, he would simply get rid of me.

Being a simple guy, he believed my words and our misunderstanding cleared, but one wrong step would have resulted in a catastrophe.

Let's kill this guy off because his strength is a pain, was something he could have considered. I guess I got lucky he decided to talk first.

Thanks to many little strokes of luck, the misunderstanding was cleared in the end.

「Now then, my story ends here.

Next, shall we hear yours?

Now tell me. Why are there so many of awakened Demon Lords here?"

There it is.

The origin of the misunderstanding: Demon Lords awakening en-mass.

This had prompted Guy into thinking I was Rudra's pawn.

For that reason, he decided to abruptly visit and ask「What's going on here?」.

Suspecting a self-scripted act, He came to find several Demon Lord in the making.

Certainly it's a bit suspicious. Or rather, we got lucky he didn't decide to just wipe us out without hearing anything.

In case I was a traitor, since he had confidence to take us all on and come out on top, I guess that's why he had room for interrogation.

If Guy wasn't this strong I would easily beat him, but because he was too strong, we could resolve this through words alone.

Now I just had a complicated feeling.

Well, in the end we didn't need to fight, that's good.

Now with that misunderstanding cleared, I needed to explain the matter of the Demon Lord awakenings.

《Solution. There is no problem with saying it's all through the ability of Gluttonous King Belzebuth》

The heavens hath spoken——!!

Alright, let's go with this. I've got nothing else to rely on.

As expected of Raphael Sensei, a skillful dodge.

「Actually, I did it with my Gluttonous King Belzebuth's ability.」

「Huh. How does that work?」

(Wisdom Lord Raphael sensei, how does this work?)

《Solution. By reducing the Soul's power into Energy, it is possible to forcefully evolve those with the qualifications.》

「Gluttonous King Belzebuth has the ability to reduce the Soul's power into Magical Energy.

Naturally, those qualified are limited to Demon Lord class individuals.」

「What did you say? Is that true?」

(Is this true, Wisdom Lord Raphael-sensei?)

《Solution. (I have trouble comprehending why I am being called sensei, but) it is true.》

「Of course it's true.」

「Huh.....Then, is it also possible to do it with my servants?」

《Solution. It is possible.》

Ah, she answered me before I could even mentally ask that question.

For some reason, I feel a little lonely.

Like a, It's getting annoying to deal with you, kind of intention.

《Solution. I have no such intention.》

This time, I felt minute traces of anger.

Fanning the flames anymore will be bad. I should just let it go here.

「There's probably no problem. I can't tell for sure without trying, but it's probably possible.」

「Huh, so all I need to do is prepare the souls right?

When there weren't signs of awakening even after using 10,000 souls, I thought it was pointless.....」

「You talking about your subordinate?

The one during Walpurgis, the maid-san called Misery?」

「Ah, her and someone else, a Demon Duke called Hillary.

Since they're both Demon Lord class, I think they're both sufficiently qualified.

They're at the same level as the trio I went against earlier.....

But right now they're so weak, they're not very helpful at all.....」

Hey now.

You're saying they're at the same level as those girls, and they're worthless?

This guy's judging criterion seems a little strange.

「So you gave 10,000 human souls to each of them?」

「Ah that's right. But since there were no signs of evolution, I've got a lot more lying around.

I tried it on myself, but that was also pointless.

So, how much do I prepare for them to evolve?」

《Solution. 500,000 will do.》

「It'll be fine with 500,000.」

Ay, hold up!

You, 500,000 you said, are you thinking of.....

《Solution. Individuals named: Gerudo ▪ Adalman ▪ Testarossa
▪ Ultima ▪ Carrera

I have counted the amount necessary for those individuals in addition.》

That's just reckless!!

Does she not know fear?!

You're totally trying to and lead the Guy · Crimson by the nose, aren't you!

No, wait a second..... This means the one he'll be after when he finds out, is me isn't it!

《Solution. There are no problems.》

No, it's full of problems!

Just now, I actually thought you were scary you know?!

This is exactly why I'm scared of fearless people.

「Ah? So 500,000 will do?

Then, even if I didn't go destroy any more towns, I probably have enough in my reserves」

「Ah, is that so? That's wonderful.」

At this point, I can only emit a dry laugh.

It's more terrifying than trying to swindle a Yakuza.

If I'm caught, I guess I can't complain even if I get destroyed.

I didn't have any sweat to wipe off, nor did any turbulence show on my face. It's been a while since I last thought it's great to be a slime.

Guy was now cheerfully eating cake.

That was his third one now.

It seemed he really liked it.

Since negotiations had ended, I wanted to have him leave soon, but apparently someone else was coming so we were waiting for them.

Honestly, this was annoying.

Just earlier, he created a Gate was created and summoned Hillary and Misery from his domain.

Once you had been to a certain location once, a Gate could be easily created there. If I could do it, Guy couldn't possibly not do it.

And, in order to grant the 2 summoned individuals the souls, 500,000 souls were handed over.

Wisdom Lord Raphael said that we could use these without problem.

I wanted to bestow it to them immediately but,

「Wait. First, teach these two how to make this cake.」

He said.

Just come and buy it! I replied.

We had been glaring at each other for a while, but it didn't look like he'd give up.

It can't be helped. It was against the rules, but I'll teach them the recipe.

If I wanted them to go back quickly, I can't afford to be stingy.

I'd make these two be able to at least make a cake.

it's probably impossible to replicate it just by taste, so I'd give them the recipe too, and having them taste it once would probably make replicating it easier.

Leaving aside Shion's catastrophic sense of taste, as maids these two seemed to be perfect.

The tea from earlier was also good.

And as they took a bite of the cake,

「Splendid!」

「As expected of Demon Lord Rimuru sama!」

They simultaneously gave me high praises.

If you're this happy by such things, there's not need to play a boring game putting the fate of the world on the line.

Though I think the world's full of even more surprises if you care to look.

And in the midst of this, Ramiris suddenly burst into the room.

「I-it's terrible! Master(Veldora) went over to Ruminas' place!」

She shouted coming in.

One trouble after another.

It looks like I won't be able to rest easy anytime soon.

Chapter 170: A Pleasant Tea Party

Ramiris had suddenly flown into the room shouting that Veldora had gone off to Ruminas' place.

What the? I questioned internally , and asked for details but.....

「H-hey! What in the world is Guy doing here!!」

Ramiris noticed Guy and started making noise.

「Ah? What are you doing here?

As I recall, weren't you living in the 『Dwelling of the Spirit』 located in the Ulgracia Republic?」

「Fufun! Don't go thinking I'll always be an unemployed shut-in, 'kay?

Even I can get a job, and happen to have one right now!

I'm earning a lot, and can even hire people now!」

「Say what!?!」

Guy made a perplexed face at Ramiris' boasting.

To make the calm and composed Guy get worked up like that, Ramiris, you're pretty good.

Guy then looked at me, and I lightly explained how Ramiris was now working here.

「So basically, I'm having her help me out in a lot of ways.」

「See! Just like I said right?!」

Ramiris proudly made some shadow-boxing poses like woosh woosh! towards guy from behind my head.

Well it's fine, but please stop using me like a shield.

「Hah! Getting all cheery after getting a simple job.

A loner like you actually hiring people?

I see you've learned some good jokes!」

Lead on by Guy's provocation,

「Why you!!」

Ramiris unleashed her Killer Dropkick on him.

But her fierce attack missed, and she had been easily captured.

A pleasant debacle, but there were more important matters to tend to.

「Wait wait, you can do that later, but about Veldora.

What's this about him going to Ruminas' place?」

Recovering a hung-upside-down-and-struggling Ramiris from Guy, I asked.

Ramiris can only concentrate on one thing at a time, so I needed to ask about the important things first.

「Ah right!

Me and Master (Veldora) were looking at different places, but suddenly, he changed the screen, and got really nervous..... and flew out shouting 「I'm worried about Ruminas, so I'll go help!」

I didn't see Ruminas on the screen though..... wonder why?」

As expected, Ramiris' explanation was useless, and the situation remained just as vague.

The only certainty was the fact that Veldora headed towards Ruminas.

Jeez, what a pain, I thought when,

「My? Has the boy run away?

And I finally came over to see him too.....」

It was a chilling voice.

Without leaving so much as a speck of her presence, a single woman opened the door.

Snow white skin. Cold, bewitching Blue Diamond eyes.

She was a dazzling beauty.

However, she didn't feel alive, her beauty was like that of a doll.

「It is a pleasure, Demon Lord Rimuru-sama.

My name is Velzard.

Or, would you be more familiar with 'Ice Dragon' Velzard?

I am Veldora's elder sister.」

She said with a graceful bow.

Veldora's sister? In other words, this beautiful lady is another

‘True Dragon’!?

Since very recently, Veldora finally managed to fully control his magic leakage, but this person was controlling hers as if it was the most natural thing in the world.

The fact that I couldn’t sense as much as a hint of her presence itself proved her might.

If not told, I would have never guessed she was a ‘True Dragon’.

However, her overflowing spirit (TN: Haki) didn’t leave any room to consider her a weakling.

「Ah, Hello, I’m Rimuru.

Despite this form, I’m an active Demon Lord.」

I also introduced myself, and asked Shuna, who had guided her in, to ready another serving of tea.

Shuna worked with expertise, never losing her composure.

No, not just her, everyone who worked in serving duty did their job with the same diligence no matter who the guest was.

They had become professionals.

「You're terrible, Guy. Leaving me behind like that.」

「Ah haha. Sorry. I forgot you were sort of bad at flying.」

「I'm not that bad; Aren't you just too fast?」

「Hmm. Well, no biggie right? You knew where I was headed right?」

「Well, since you were going to call Misery and Hillary anyway, you could've just waited for me too.」

「You are right and all. But you had some good exercise after so long, so it's a win-win.」

「Yes yes, whatever.」

Velzard sighed as if giving up, and gracefully placed herself on a chair.

The smell of trees pleased her nose.

Though there was a soft sofa, the wooden chairs were also quite comfortable.

Surrounded by the forest, it felt as if you were one with mother nature.

After a sip of the tea brought by Shuna,

「Honestly, that Veldora, he didn't have to run away」

She complained.

I wouldn't think Veldora ran away, but in retrospect, he never did want to go to the continent of demons.

He made excuses like it was too cold there or something, and I always thought it was strange since cold didn't affect him.

「Hey Guy, are you perhaps living in the cold northern continent? 」

「Mm? Yeah it's a frigid place known as the 'Continent of Eternal Ice', why?」

「Because I don't suppress my magic there.....

that unbearably cold place has now become an environment completely hostile to life.」

I see.

I'm convinced now.

I'm positive that Veldora can't handle his sister Velzard.

He happened to notice Velzard through the Surveillance Magic, and made a straight line for elsewhere.

It was not like him, but I had a friend once who felt similarly about his own big sister.

「She's too evil.....」

My friend had complained.

Even a 'True Dragon' like Veldora must have the same feelings.

By the way, some others also boasted misfortune with their younger sisters, but I, who only had an elder brother, honestly couldn't relate.

Both sides had their share of troubles, was my impression.

「Velzard-san, could it be that Veldora isn't that fond of you?」

I casually asked.

「Oh my? I have been taking care of him so well since he started rampaging as a baby.

I even held him down, and stopped him whenever he was being rowdy.

He was useless and couldn't even maintain humanoid form, and I even took the trouble of punishing him after too many of his little disasters.....」

Velzard recounted episodes from the past, describing the kind things she had done for him.

The reason became clear now.

Judging from the story, against Veldora's 'action oriented' powers, Velzard's 'binding oriented' powers were extremely effective.

In other words, natural enemies.

Yeah, I had to agree to his wanting to run away, even if she wouldn't do anything.

That ever confident and fearless Veldora having a weakness —— Or rather, sister. Not exactly blood related though —— like that was unexpected.

Afterwards, we spent the time listening to Velzard's stories, and chatting with Guy.

Ramiris happily ate cake, and got along well with Velzard.

Velzard also became fond of the cake.

When the topic of teaching the baking techniques to the maids came up,

「Goodness. Guy can occasionally do good things too I see.

Thank you very much for undertaking our maids' education.」

She requested cheerfully.

Now, there was no way I could refuse.

If I did, I could end up awakening something even more fearsome than Guy.

Listening to Ramiris bragging to Guy, and correcting her exaggerations, I spent the time quite peacefully.

After a decent amount of conversation, I took the time to ascend Hillary and Misery before forgetting.

Since I had claimed that only Gluttony King Belzébuth could do it, the fact that I took quite a bit more souls than required will be my little secret.

Following Raphael-sensei's footsteps, I decided to be a bit bold myself.

Giving each of them 90,000 souls at a steady pace soon resulted in evolution.

It was exactly as Wisdom Lord Raphael had said.

And with that, I had another 520,000 souls remaining.

I could now reward the ones who I couldn't evolve in the ceremony.

I was worried what would happen when Guy came over, but the event concluded well with us on friendly terms.

「Hope I wasn't a bother.

Now these two can be of a little use too.

Well, you can call me if anything happens.

I'll help you out a bit, alright?」

「Yeah, thanks. You can call me on you end too. I'll do what I can.」

We said our goodbyes with promises of cooperation.

Or rather, the Gate was connected and travelling to and fro took zero time.

Just to confirm, I had a quick visit and came back.

Now, it became possible to Teleport to Guy's domain.

This Skill was only possible for places already visited.

A steady effort like this was necessary in hopes of making our plans to travel the world come into fruition.

Teleportation was not possible for those not strong enough.

But someday, I hoped to set up Transit Gates to move important facilities.

And so, we saw Guy and his bunch off.

It's an unnecessary detail, but Guy ended up eating 5 pieces of cake.

At this rate, I felt like he was going to visit again very soon.

Next time, I could prepare sweets, I thought amusingly.

Now then, after Guy left, I went to see the three Demon Dukes.

They looked like dried husks of their former selves.

「Our sincerest apologies!」

All three of them bowed profusely, and their injuries seemed to be fine.

I was relieved.

I wanted to grant them the souls to evolve immediately.

Gerudo and Adalman had refused the offer, and I was to wait for the next opportunity in their case.

I wouldn't want to force a reward on them, if they didn't think they deserved it.

On that note, the three Demon Dukes already showed very promising results. I was making them wait for my own convenience, so now was a good time.

And it was better that I personally saw to their growth.

With that, their evolutions resulted in them becoming 'Devil Lords'.

The same result as Misery and Hillary.

It's a bit troubling, but they had attained the highest rank in the Demon Aristocratic classes.

Their status as Lord proved their new found strength.

Anyway, the three of them successfully ascended to the highest rank of elites.

They understood that overlapping the effects of Skills and Magic could break through multi layered barriers.

These three girls had picked a fight with the strongest known as Guy, and had fortunately survived.

This birthed a desire to at least act as a shield for their Rimuru-sama the next time they faced Guy.

Diablo's education may have made them gradually stronger, but their defeat in the recent events had lead them to aspire for even greater heights of strength.

Fighting strong opponents, sparked passion in not only a human's, but even a Demon's soul.

The effects of their evolution propagated to the Arch Demons, and evolved them to Demon Dukes.

As for their level of nobility,

Duke class: Moss

Marquis grade: Veyron

Earl class: Venom

Viscount class: Agera and Esprit

Baron class: Shien and Zonda

Well, these may seem like complicated titles, but it's just to show the difference in the classes of Demon Dukes.

Among the rest of the 600 demons, some became Arch Demons which were on par with Knight class, but the rest remained Greater Demons.

They weren't named, so too much of a power up was not expected.

But as their bodies were that of Culture Capsule Automatons, their strength increased much more than normal.

They'll probably prove useful one of these days.

At present, they were doing miscellaneous work like security or labour, but since they could teleport, I could have them go collect information from various parts of the world.

Anyway, all of them safely attained greater strength.

Tomorrow, the Imperial Airships would cross Ruminas' domain.

I had already planned to go support her if need be.

Demons may actually have a good affinity for evolution, since all of them easily completed their Harvest Festivals.

The link with the Culture Capsules were also improved, and from tomorrow, Demons stronger than Greater Demons would be born.

The souls I received(stole) from Guy promoted my forces to much greater heights, so looking at the results only, it was a truly beneficial encounter.

I told the three girls to rest up, and after confirming that they were doing so, I went back to the control room.

The Imperial Aerial Fighter Legion was on schedule, arriving tomorrow afternoon at the earliest.

And as I was thinking about contacting Ruminas about Veldora ——

The scene was displayed clearly in one of the Surveillance Screens.

A Veldora flying at ultra high speeds on a crash course with the Imperial fleet.

It was an overhead image from a high altitude, so I could easily make out his route.

At this rate, he would cause war to break out in less than an hour.

「Seriously, what is he even doing..... that Veldora.....」

My lone words echoed in the control room.

Veldora was soaring in the open skies at speeds tens of times higher than that of sound.

He was having a lot of fun after returning from the cramped humanoid form to his original Dragon form after so long.

Though, his present feelings aside, the reason he needed to become like this was not fun at all.

He had run away from his elder sister.

His sister, Velzard, could be called his single natural enemy.

Ability-wise, their match up was quite bad for him.

Furthermore, she was born before him, and overpowered him in power, Energy and everything else.

In an honest fight, he wasn't confident he could win.

It happened many times after Veldora came into the world.

He challenged her, but was beaten instead every time.

Velzard's 'Eternal World' was an impregnable defence that also served to seal all of Veldora's movements.

Storm, Destruction, Corrosion, Doom.

All of them were nullified against the her absolute bind.

At present, he may have had a chance at beating her, but it was still too soon.

After all, only after learning to restrain his power did he realize that his big sister Velzard was always able to do it perfectly.

The nature of her power, she claimed, was specialized in ‘cessation of all energy for activity’, but she likely possessed an unmatched strength to complement that.

Veldora was cautious because he knew that his sister was not to some small fry.

「Kuhahahaha! Our battle yet awaits!」

Leaving behind large distances and cool lines, He continued his high speed flight.

His imminent clash with the Imperials, whether it was fate or coincidence, was unclear.

But as if playing a tasteless joke, fate had it that one of those Airships was carrying the ‘Scorch Dragon’ Velgrynd.

After thousands of years, a fierce battle would result from the encounter of these two 'True Dragons'.

Chapter 171: Clash! Storm Dragon Vs Scorch Dragon -First Half-

That battle had affected the surrounding topology, and caused great change to the ecosystem.

A ‘calamity’ which was later named ‘The Scorching Tempest’ had occurred.

No matter the conclusion, it was definitely a battle that surpassed human understanding.

The only silver lining was that the it had taken place over the ocean.

The heat had caused the seawater to evaporate, which formed clouds that brought forth heavy rain to the surrounding areas, but there was no major impact on land.

If it had been over land, or worse, in close vicinity of a country, the scale of damage would have been catastrophic.

But, there definitely was some damage.

The marine life which inhabited that ocean region had been significantly affected, and as a result, the already huge sea creatures ended up evolving into even bigger, more terrifying sea monsters.

With the creation of these sea monsters, this ocean region had become an untraversable region.

As a result, the sea route was closed off, and even the airspace above that ocean region was deemed unsafe.

This was the reality of the great damage that 'The Scorching Tempest' had brought about.

Among the central islands of the 'Continent of Eternal Ice', was an area of sea that lay in permafrost.

The surrounding skies were controlled by aerial demons that had become more savage due to being bathed in Demon Lord Guy

Crimson's magic.

Because of that, and because one of the sea routes had ended up being closed off because of the 'calamity', there was a need to accelerate the establishment of a railway network and of Transit Gates for travel over the main land.

As this was part of Demon Lord Rimuru's motives, it was debated whether the events were part of the Demon Lord's strategy;

Whether he wanted to gain total control of the land transport routes.

It was a fact that the transport network prepared by the Demon Lord contributed to the advance of human technology.

But was the 'calamity' purposefully caused by the Demon Lord?

This would become a hot topic of debate for historians of the

future.

But that this calamity was simply an amusing twist of fate; no historian could have predicted this culmination of events.

The phrase “reality is often stranger than fiction”, couldn’t have suited these string of events better.

Putting the debate aside, the cause of this ‘calamity’ being a battle among ‘True Dragons’ would be made an undeniable fact by future historians.

Veldora, comfortably soaring through the skies, tried increasing his speed slightly.

Compared to when he was sealed, having better control of his magic now, his flying speed has increased.

「Kuahahahaha! Superb. This is a superb speed!」

He said, getting carried away.

It felt comfortable.

With the knowledge attained from the scriptures (manga) that Rimuru possessed, Veldora tweaked around with the logic here and there and produced good results.

His magic circulated within his body, with no leakages.

It was now possible to utilize magic of a much higher quality.

Better results, with less work.

Learning beside Rimuru, there were many things he wanted to try out.

Doing as he pleased in his true form was prohibited, so he played around with Rimuru's followers while in his human form.

It was a pretty interesting experience, being taught the logic of skills... from the old man called Hakurou.

Power, was not to be simply released.

Molding it, increase the concentration through focus, and then explosively releasing it on a single point.

The true nature of Veldora's power was 'Chaos'.

It was to release that near limitless magic into the surroundings, and attack with all his might.

Even at just this level, it was possible to destroy just about anything; it was also possible to do almost anything.

But, just that wasn't good enough.

As it stands, there was a limit to how much power that could be released; it became impossible to accomplish more whilst wielding limited amounts of power.

Which was why, suppressing power and living in human form, was the most effective form of training.

And through that, Veldora learned how to use his power efficiently.

Similar to the logic in moving arms and legs while in human form, there was also a set flow to control power while in dragon form, thus proficiency increased with better concentration.
(TN: THIS was hard to make sense of)

For Veldora, whose total energy levels are actually much higher than either of his 2 elder sisters, not needing to be conscious of the fact was impossible.

And that, was the gist of putting effort into combat styles, the reason to search for the efficient use of power.

It wouldn't be something to be conscious of for beings that wield great power.

Unconsciously learning how to control magic while playing around in human form, this resulted in Veldora gaining combat power incomparable to his past self.

Veldora himself only felt lighter somewhat, being unaware of the difference.

Concentrating, Veldora attempted to fly at full power.

At that moment, his body started to adopt a form that was more suitable, and he easily surpasses the speed of sound.

The fastest among the 4 existing 'True Dragons', was 'Scorch Dragon' Velgrynd.

But at present, Veldora could attain speed which could rival the fastest.

Due to reaching this speed that he had never reached before, unknowingly, he was fast approaching the Empire's Aerial Fleet.

(Hey, Veldora! The Empire's straight ahead. You're gonna run right into them if you keep going like that!)

He was already within one hour away from contact, when he received Rimuru's message through Telepathy.

Seeing the slightly panicking Rimuru, Veldora's thoughts became composed.

Wait a sec. The Empire was headed for Ruminas but, Couldn't this be his time to shine?

Having finally gotten something of a powerup, wouldn't this be fitting opportunity to test things out?

Even if I defeated all the enemies here without working together with Ruminas, it wouldn't be a problem right?

Such thoughts went through his mind.

「Kuahahaha! Be at ease, Rimuru.

Leave it to me. I'll repel that Imperial army!」

(Wha-! Will that be alright!?)

“Yeah, no problem! This is a long awaited chance to go all out. Don't worry, just watch!”

Saying that, he ended the Telepathy message with Rimuru.

From Veldora's perspective, Rimuru was always cautious.

Even if he had a definite chance of victory, he always only started a fight when he was certain that there was no chance of defeat.

That itself wasn't a bad thing, but it was also important to have more confidence in himself.

Yes, he should be like his Ultimate Skill, Raphael.

With the resolve to fight, now it was only a matter of time till the battle.

To Veldora, the Imperial troops were nothing to be afraid of.

Aiming to end the battle instantly, he increased his flight speed even more.

The Empire's Aerial Legion came into view ahead.

They numbered 300 ships. Not much of a problem.

Maintaining his current speed, it felt like he could win just by ramming into the opposition while cloaked in Hyper Energy.

But, it's probably better to tell them to surrender first, so he stopped right before contact.

Just the aftershock of him stopping mid flight caused the Airships at the front of the fleet to jolt immensely. Destroying the fleet seemed to be an easy task.

「Kuahahahaha! Fools of the empire!

I am Veldora! 'Storm Dragon' Veldora!

If you stop your invasion now, I will let you retreat peacefully.

You may respond now!」

Veldora loudly proclaimed to the Empire through Telepathy.

This act of warning was something that would have never crossed Veldora's mind in the past.

Living alongside Rimuru, not only his power but even his concept of thinking had changed.

Well, the scriptures (manga) knowledge probably had more of an influence.

On the other hand, the circumstances for the Empire differed significantly.

The higher ranking officers had already been informed of the fact that the entire army that was sent to subjugate the Great Jura Forest had been wiped out.

As for the regular soldiers, they couldn't contain their restlessness after seeing Veldora who wasn't supposed to be there.

Despite that, none of them left their designated posts, set the defense barriers to the highest output, and awaited further orders from their superiors; it was a show of great discipline.

As for their superiors, the Beast Corps commander, Gradim, and major-general Xam'd were located on the same Airship in the middle of the fleet.

This ship had a more luxurious build compared to the others, and had 300 of the remaining elite mages on board, which meant their defense barriers were of a higher quality.

This much was expected for the ship of the leaders of the expeditionary forces.

In addition, Velgrynd was on board as well.

As proxy for the emperor, she was highest in the chain of command.

To Gradim who had no idea who she was, it wasn't an

amusing proposition, but he nonetheless could feel that she was not to be underestimated.

Xam'd spoke up in place of Gradim.

The woman who called herself Grynd — Velgrynd took on that pseudonym — was the person of highest authority right now.

Although slightly displeasing, it was necessary to inquire about her opinion.

「Grynd-dono, what shall be our course of action?」

Velgrynd smiled wryly, and answered with another question.

「Xam'd, are we able to fire the Magic Cancellor currently?

Also, it doesn't seem enough, but how much of a fight can we

put up with the forces currently on hand?」

「Let's see....

We didn't think there would be an air battle, we don't have enough mages for this.

Our opponent is that Veldora, so our current forces just won't be enough.

We would be able to perform better if we had say, 100 ships with 400 elites on each....」

「Hmm. Transport ships aren't gonna do much against Veldora huh.

Very well.

Not much choice, I will go then. You all should hurry and

withdraw from the battle zone.」

「What? You intend to go alone?」

Gradim was shocked at Velgryind's words.

She glanced back and,

「Yes. It's good that I came along with the expedition.

Even Rudra couldn't have foreseen these turn of events.....

Assemble those who can use the Magic Cancellers and reform our composition.

Do this swiftly while I buy time!

Make sure to be able to fire anytime, and aim for the moment

I create an opportunity.

Fire the moment I give the signal. Understood?

This should already be obvious, get in contact with Rudra.

If you understand then hurry and get to work! I'll be heading out!]

Orders came in like a volley of arrows.

Gradim was stunned, and couldn't compute the orders, but Velgrynd paid him no heed, and opened the bridge doors.

She opened the doors with no hesitation and flew out toward the skies.

(That's suicide!)

As Gradim thought of that, he lost all words at the the scene before his eyes.

Grynd —— Velgrynd —— flew out to the skies, and, after a brief flash of red light, transformed into her Dragon Mode in a dazzling display of Cardinal Aura.

「Wha-! Could it be —— “Cardinal” Velgrynd!? The Guardian Deity of the Empire, Velgrynd-sama!」

Gradim came back to his senses after Xam’d’s surprised outburst.

And immediately said,

「I shall contact the emperor.

Hurry up and reform the ranks! You all heard what Velgrynd-sama said!

Assemble the Mages, land the remaining ships down to the ocean!!」

The orders were given.

The voice brought the soldiers back to their senses.

Their hearts were momentarily stolen by the otherworldly beauty of the shining scarlet dragon.

To face the despair brought by the appearance of Veldora, the legendary Guardian of the Empire had taken form, so it couldn't be helped that the soldiers got caught up in the moment.

But, Gradim's stern rally was more than enough to bring them back.

For the soldiers who were mesmerized by the advent of "Scorch Dragon" Velgrynd, it brought them back to reality.

「That's right! Our Guardian Dragon is with us. There's nothing to be afraid of!」

「With Velgrynd-sama on our side, there's no way we can lose!!」

Morale rose instantly for the empire soldiers.

And they quickly began moving as per their orders.

Having been a long time since returning to her true form, Velgrynd looked around her.

At expected it feels comforting to be in her original form.

Using 『Magic Perception』 as naturally as breathing, she analysed the movements within the fleet.

She felt no hesitation in the soldiers, so no problems there.

As she looked ahead, Veldora seemed to be surprised and had gotten stiff.

The reason was obvious.

He probably thought he could do a full sweep of the fleet with a single blast of his Breath.

A reunion of siblings since time immemorial.

Before he was sealed, during the times where Veldora was out rampaging around, Velgrynd was already Emperor Rudra's partner, and had laid dormant in the Empire.

Being frozen by their elder sister Velzard every so often, it had been 2000 years since his last meeting with Velgrynd.

It was around the southern area of the empire, where they last met.

Their meeting had caused the emergence of a volcanic region, as the powers of the “True Dragons” clashed.

Though at that time both of them weren’t serious at all, Veldora had caught a glimpse of the pinnacle of Velgrynd’s powers, and escaped with his tail between his legs.

Despite having massive amounts of energy, Veldora was unable to efficiently use his power. That was why Velgrynd didn’t see him as much of a threat.

It meant nothing by just having great amounts of energy if he couldn’t use it properly.

But this power was capable of overpowering her own, if it was properly trained it could become an ace in this game.

She would take her time to slowly teach him how to use his powers, after getting him on to their side.

Now, anything could happen.

Velgrynd would pin Veldora down.

Then, with the right opportunity, make full use of the Magic Cancellers and restrain Veldora.

After that, they would turn Veldora into one of their own with Emperor Rudra's "Regalia Dominion".

It would have taken a lot of effort to lure him out from under Demon Lord Rimuru, but the current circumstances were much more convenient.

Though unexpected, this had become the perfect chance to bring Veldora to their side.

The goal of defeating Ruminas to obtain the method of bringing up holy knights, the "Soul Rending System", would probably end up unneeded.

It was possible to grasp victory in their game against Guy if they had Veldora, which removes the need to increase the

number of Sages as underlings.

(With this the board is going to change drastically.)

The end to their eternally drawn out game felt within reach. A victory for Velgrynd and Emperor Rudra drew closer.

Back to the problem at hand, first was to capture Veldora.

Making the best use of this chance, his capture was imperative in making their victory a reality.

Velgrynd slowly flew towards Veldora, with these thoughts.

Veldora was perplexed.

Despite successfully running away from his elder sister Velzard, he now ran into his other elder sister.

What's up with that? He felt.

Due to how shocked he was, many of his movements were stiff.

It was time to get serious.

It would be difficult to escape. The reason was simple, Velgrynd was the fastest among the "True Dragons".

With a polished battle style, one could feel she was fast just from her appearance. Well appearance didn't really matter.....

Competing in speed was a moot action, and for fighting, the current location was good.

If he ended up destroying Ruminas' country again, he felt like he was definitely going to be chased around till his last breath.

Ruminas wasn't the kind to joke around; and after watching what Rimuru did to build up his country, it was kind of obvious she would get angry.

Even if it wasn't Ruminas, if Tempest was destroyed, Rimuru would utterly decimate the culprit.

With that in mind, there was no need to relocate the battlefield to somewhere populated.

Although it was kind of a pain, the opposition also seems to be getting ready for battle, to arms then.

But, seeing his elder sister Velgrynd ally with the Empire was a little unexpected.

It would have been possible to clean up this fleet of dinky airships with a single blast of breath, Veldora thought.

And earning a favor from Ruminas in the process, he wanted to get her to forget about the past destruction of her country.

It would have been a great opportunity, but life was never that easy.

Oh well, it seemed Velgrynd was all gung-ho about this, so he would follow suit.

Although they had never duked it out in earnest before, he felt that Velgrynd slightly had the upper hand. But that was all in the past now.

Veldora had obtained new powers, with help from Rimuru.

(Kuahahahaha! How about I see what I'm capable of, with this elder sister of mine as the opponent!)

With such thoughts, Veldora felt more motivated.

Veldora put his focus on Velgrynd, and entered his battle stance.

And so, a battle of the current century between “True Dragons” erupts.

Chapter 172: Clash! Storm Dragon Vs Scorch Dragon -Last Half-

The battle quietly began.

Velgrynd waited until she had confirmed that the airship fleet behind her retreated to safety.

As soon as she confirmed their retreat, she would move.

「It's been too long, Veldora. I'll ask just in case, will you not come to our side?

If you do, I'll teach you how to properly use your strength, you can even rampage to your heart's content you know?

Naturally, the location will be left up to us though. 」

「Kuhahahaha! Dearest sister, the old me is no more.

I have already perfected my strength control.

Besides, simply raging about isn't fun anymore.

I'm an adult now, my sister! 」

「Those are some cheeky words you say.....

Very well then. If that's the case, then I'll be testing how much you have grown! 」

The words they exchanged were few.

After all, Velgrynd knew that Veldora would not heed to any negotiations, so she prepared for battle without hard feelings.

Originally, the plan was for Rudra to Dominate and control Veldora, so persuasion was pointless.

As such, she needed to quickly weaken Veldora, and suppress him until Rudra arrived.

Thinking so, Velgrynd made a preemptive strike by releasing her Burning Breath.

It was a single thin beam of concentrated light, a super high speed Breath Attack that assaulted Veldora.

Normally, due to the effects of Veldora's heat nullification, he would not take heat damage. However, without hesitating, Veldora avoided Velgrynd's Breath.

「Oh? I didn't think you'd dodge that.

This just might be my personal opinion, but have your skills improved a little perhaps? 」

「Kuahahahaha! Your breath attack probably has Accelerated Destruction effects.

If I received a direct hit, my magic would go wild, and I would weaken trying to regain control over it.

Of course I'd avoid that. 」

At that moment, Veldora's intuition felt that the Breath Attack had an Ultimate Skill's effect added onto it.

The analysis from Veldora's Ultimate Skill 『Investigation King Faust』 had also confirmed this.

While Veldora was surprised at being able to understand his own attack so well, Velgrynd fired her next attack.

And simultaneously moving at instantaneous speed, she occupied a position above Veldora.

While evading the multiple simultaneous Breath attacks, at some point, Veldora noticed that he was now confronting Velgrynd from below.

She's quick as always, thought Veldora. If it were the Veldora from before, he would have failed to notice her.

On the other hand, Velgrynd had already skillfully gained enough distance to deliver her knockout blow.

At this distance, she could perfectly deal with Veldora, and was confident she could maintain her advantage.

「Let's end this, Veldora.

In the end, you weren't able to escape from my clutches! 」

Declaring this, multiple Burning Breaths were released simultaneously from above.

Multiple columns of flame bound the heaven and earth. This was known as a Flame Cage.

But, Veldora was able to see through the attacks, and splendidly evade them.

Despite being ensnared in a Flame Cage, let alone a direct hit, he didn't suffer a single scratch.

「Kuhahaha! If it doesn't hit, nothing happens, and that's how it is! 」

Veldora gleefully shouted the words he had memorized by heart.

Tch! An irritated Velgrynd clicked her tongue.

Certainly, to not be able to land a single strike at this stage was unpredicted. It was not as if she was underestimating Veldora.

However.....

(I was just warming up!)

She still possessed the absolute advantage.

Velgrynd decided to stop holding anything back, and end this in one go.

「Is that so? But you know.....you've already fallen into my trap.

I shall seal your movements with this, Burning Embrace!! 」

There was a reason Velgrynd positioned herself above Veldora.

Below them was the ocean, the Burning Breaths Veldora had dodged would naturally come into contact with the seawater and cause a steam explosion.

Even with the force of the explosion, Veldora would never take damage.

However, the evaporated sea water would become water vapor, and surround Veldora.

Those would, infused with Velgrynd's ability, become tiny red droplets of rain... and pour upwards.

The Cardinal Cage used for capturing Veldora was, at that very moment, complete.

The blessing of the Ultimate Skill 『Charity King Raguel』

It could exponentially increase the thermal energy within the target, in other words, it was an ability that forcefully increased kinetic momentum.

To a certain extent, it could boost physical capabilities, but going too far, would push bodily energy consumption over the limits.

And, when the ability is at its greatest, it could accelerate heat production within the body, causing the body to burn into nothingness.

In other words, it was an ability that could freely manipulate the energy composition of the target's body.

As if to embrace Veldora who's trapped in a cage, the scarlet rain gently generated a membrane around him.

For those held within the Burning Embrace, their right to survival lied in the hands of Velgrynd.

The result was the same even for Veldora who was "True Dragon" similar to herself.

Velgrynd, who was certain of her victory, was about to order Major General Xam'd to fire the Magic Cancellor—but stopped.

The imprisoned Veldora's presence had disappeared.

(What just happened?!)

Velgrynd felt perplexed at the rare feeling of losing her composure.

Towards that Velgrynd,

「Kuhahahaha! I told you earlier didn't I?

If it doesn't hit, nothing happens, and that's how it is!」

From behind, she heard the sound of Veldora's victorious laughter

In reality, Veldora didn't actually have much breathing room for him to be boasting that much.

Right when the Cardinal Cage was on the verge of completion, the Ultimate Skill 『Investigation King Faust』's Danger

Precognition ability was sending a maximum danger warning.

It wasn't something he could deal with in the spur of the moment by blowing it off with "Storm of Ruination", that much was obvious.

(Crap!)

The instant he thought so, Investigation King Faust's "Investigation of Truth" had derived the optimal solution.

To only use "Storm of Ruination" as it is, the chances of escape were less than 1%.

However, by focusing the emission of "Storm of Ruination", the result was "Storm Blast (Roar of Ruination)". As a result, it was derived that the odds of escape would greatly increase.

But even so, the odds of escape via "Storm Blast" was merely 50%.

This was where “Probability Manipulation” was activated.

Against an enemy of the same rank, the probability would double on one’s own favor.

This escape act which was supposed to have a 50-50 chance of success, now rolled in favor to Veldora thanks to Investigation King Faust.

In this fashion, Veldora escaped from danger.

Velgrynd was awe-struck in the truest sense of the word.

Her little brother (Veldora) who she had viewed as inferior to herself, who she had looked down upon for his reliance on brute strength..... in an absolutely unescapable situation, he had splendidly made his escape.

She had no choice but to admit it.

Veldora had reached her level.

Velgrynd acknowledged Veldora as an enemy of equal standing whom she would be confronting.

This was the instant she decided to get serious.

On the large screen, a decisive Kaijuu battle was being projected.

No, this was no joke, this was the only way to describe it.

If it were only the Empire's Airship fleet, then Veldora's victory was nothing to be worried about, but it was quite the surprise when the Crimson Dragon suddenly appeared.

That was one of Veldora's elder sisters, probably "Scorch

Dragon” Velgrynd.

However, despite the large clash of energy, the level of control was excellent, and it had become a very complicated battle.

When Velgrynd used a bold move, and it seemed the match was about to be immediately decided, I was worried that Veldora may have lost.

Although, as it was possible to revive him even if he died, I was not that worried.....

It was only to the point where I ordered Wisdom Lord Raphael to map out their spatial coordinates.

I was about to go save him with teleport, but then I remembered Veldora could be retrieved using my Skill.

Due to this recollection, I was able to spectate the battle in a relaxed manner.

The battle had reached a stalemate.

They were equal in speed.

Veldora had a high level of control, allowing him to move at high speed.

Even when against the fastest of the “True Dragons”, Velgrynd, he didn’t lag behind a single step.

The results of secretly training himself had surfaced.

I couldn’t determine this since sounds couldn’t be reproduced, but I seriously wish he didn’t start saying cool, boastful lines, and ended up in a pinch.

That said, limited to what I saw, all in all Veldora had been starting to get the advantage.

If you looked at strength alone, Veldora had the superiority.

Although he was greatly weakened at one point due to being sealed, at present, he appeared to have completely recovered.

Veldora's magic Energy was above Velgrynd, but it felt like his magic control was inferior.

However, his Skill, Investigation King Faust, seemed to have higher performance compared to that of Velgrynd's.

Well, it did seem like a well-rounded all purpose skill.

Frankly speaking, "Probability Manipulation", "Investigation of the Truth" and sorts, aren't those hard-to-understand Skills pretty broken?

To be honest, once he masters those skills, could anyone even beat him? I thought it was at that level.

Veldora's newly created move, the converged storm attack (Storm Blast), appeared to have inflicted damage on Velgrynd.

Traveling at an unavoidable speed using waves, the effect only manifested after a delay.

In a word, they were "Invisible waves" such as electromagnetic waves, and travelling at hypersonic speeds — estimating to be over Mach 100 — if the evasion timing was even slightly off, it was practically impossible to prevent the effects from the Storm.

After all, since you've already received the blow, it's impossible to dodge or defend.

For goodness' sake, he developed quite an unreasonable Skill.

As expected of Veldora, I thought with a bit of reverence.

If this kept up, it'd be Veldora's victory, just as I was confident about this——

The situation quickly took a turn.

——Towards the worst direction.

Suddenly, the retreating Imperial Airship fleet of 100 had begun to move.

Overlooking them was a big blunder.

Several individuals donning shining armor appeared on the bridge.

With a barrier that completely defended against the effects of the storm, they leisurely walked forward.

(Hm? What's with those guys?)

As I was pondering this, it happened.

The only man without armor, a man wearing a former Japanese Empire military uniform, fired his small handgun.

Huh? For an instant I was at a loss for words.

A bullet shouldn't have affected the strongest known as "True Dragons"

However, I stiffened at that bullet's speed.

It reached speeds on par with Veldora's Roar—— In other words, above Mach 100——and penetrated Veldora's body.

Penetrating his body, the bullet released some kind of magic inside.

Veldora stopped moving, and began to lash out in pain.

Immediately after, the Cardinal Cage engulfed Veldora once

more, and the 100 Airships of the Aerial Fighter Legion activated Magic Cancellor at maximum strength.

All it took was a moment, for them to successfully seal Veldora's movements.

The man donning a shining armor held up both hands towards Veldora.

Right then, sharp pain assaulted my soul.

As if they were ripping my soul out ——

《Alert. Master (Rimuru) and Individual: Veldora's "Soul Corridor" has been destroyed. Ultimate Skill 『Storm King Veldora』's Storm Dragon Summoning • Storm Dragon Release is now unusable. 》

——Suddenly, I was notified the reason for my pain.

What did you say?

Are you saying they took Veldora from me?

Veldora.....from me?

(TN: Veldora x Rimuru anyone? He sounded like an NTRed girlfriend here 😊.)

DON'T FUCK WITH ME DAMN IT!!

A feeling of vehement loss, and one of intense rage simultaneously welled up inside me.

Shion and Diablo who were by my side tried to hold me back in a rush.

「Please wait, Rimuru sama! It's dangerous to go now!! 」

Shion's words didn't enter my ears.

I'LL FUCKING KILL EM!

With enraged thoughts, I shook off from their grasp, and stood up.

There did not exist a single existence within Tempest who could restrain my strength unbounded by anger.

Now you(The empire)'ve made me mad.

As you wished, I shall grant it.

The blessing named annihilation.

They had triggered my wrath.

I, in my rage, teleported to Veldora.

Chapter 173: Rage

As soon as Rimuru had left, Shion and Diablo immediately went into action.

Now was not the time to be surprised about seeing an outraged Rimuru for the first time.

They promptly informed all the Executives to proceed to emergency countermeasures by thought transmission.

For those that were still in the process of evolution, the message to “complete the process as quickly as possible” was left, but the wills of all involved were already in union.

For the glory of Rimuru-sama!

They would finish their evolutions at top speed.

They reconstructed their bodies at tremendous speeds, and attained new power.....

And with the use of 『Food Chain』 , they became strength for Rimuru.

They evolved, while resonating with Rimuru's anger.

But this wasn't your typical evolution or ascension, the resonance caused the development of aggressive and combat oriented abilities.

More potent, more efficient.

And so, preparations began for the orders that would arrive soon, if any of them were ever called upon by Rimuru.

In my anger, I had teleported to the location where Veldora's fight had first started.

Wisdom Lord Raphael had proved useful in following my order of figuring out the coordinates.

I had teleported here without any hesitation, but I was presently at a state of anger unimaginable from my usual self.

It could even be the first time I lost my reason due to rage.

That time when Shion was killed, I was in a mix of anger and regret, but then the prospects of hope had calmed my state of mind.

Thanks to that, I maintained my reason even in the anger, and could work skillfully.

But this time was not the same.

Remembering the pain as if my soul was torn apart, just imagining losing Veldora had thrown any reason out the window.

Chance of success? Who gives a fuck.

I'll crush the enemy.

Nothing more, nothing less.

Looking at the enemy's forces, Wisdom Lord Raphael had advised that it was dangerous, but I shut her up and ordered 「Do something!」.

《Solution. Understood. Commencing implementation of optimal strategy.》

I think I heard something like that, but at the moment, I didn't care at all.

I just needed to rescue Veldora, and kill those fuckfaces.

In my rage, I had resolved to confront two of the “True

Dragons”, and appeared in front of the enemy.

Now, I only needed to avenge.

Demon Lord Rimuru had appeared.

Having lost his calm, his mind focused only on attack.

Seeing him,

「Oh ho? So you came here noticing your owner was stolen?

Fool. With the your source of power, your master Veldora, gone, even for a Demon Lord, you’re now just a simple monster.

Coming here without a single underling, it seems you don’t possess a shred of intelligence.

Make haste, and rid me of this fool!」

Emperor Rudra uninterestedly ridiculed him, but his words did not reach Rimuru.

For Rimuru, the Emperor was only one of the many targets for extermination.

The tactical conditions for victory.

In this situation, they were:

1. Recover Veldora.
2. Eliminate the threat.
3. Massacre every one of the Imperials.

That was all.

For him, whose mind was wrapped in bloodlust, there was no need for warnings.

All self-preservation conditions were deemed unnecessary.

Currently, only success mattered.

Recovering Veldora was the absolute condition, and took the highest priority.

There were very few who were cautious of Rimuru's sudden appearance.

They were, Velgrynd, first lieutenant Kondo, and Damrada, only these 3.

Currently, with the capture of Veldora, the Empire had a great

advantage.

The Emperor's historic battle with Guy would come to an end, they were only one step away.

Therefore, a single Demon Lord coming out was nothing in comparison to the threat from the recent appearance of a "True Dragon".

After all, "True Dragons" were normally considered the strongest in the world, and on a completely different level from a mere Demon Lord.

A Demon Lord who had only come after they had captured one of the strongest, a "True Dragon", and in addition, the fact that they now controlled 2 of those "True Dragons" naturally lead to the assumption that they were not in any danger.

Among them, Damrada made a tense face.

Donned in his exclusive Legendary armour, his face was

covered with a helmet, and there was no worry of anyone seeing his expression.

But still, he suspected if anyone noticed his anxiety.

10 of Emperor Rudra's Royal Knights stood at attention on the bridge.

The strongest force of the Empire was gathered there.

With defensive barriers at maximum output, their position could be considered the safest.

As a result, The Royal Knights didn't feel any tension.

However, Damrada recognized Rimuru's appearance as a danger.

It wasn't based on logic.

This Demon Lord, from the first time they met, had triggered a bizarre feeling.

Him, and also Yuuki.

They had an aura akin to charisma that fascinated Damrada.

Wasn't there a better way to live, other than a life in sworn fealty to the Emperor? They had something that evoked such a feeling.

Thus, from Damrada's perspective, Rimuru was not an enemy to be underestimated. Ever calm, he was an absolute existence whose thoughts couldn't be read by others.

That Rimuru had lost his calm in a pit of anger, something was bound to happen.

Damrada remained vigilant, and focused on the Emperor's protection in case that something did happen.

First Lieutenant Kondo witnessed Demon Lord Rimuru for the first time.

And had the thought, that he had made a grave mistake.

That it was a mistake to prioritize the capture of Veldora.

He understood that Demon Lord Rimuru could not be dealt with in negligence. That was why he was not a target for capture, and was left for later.

The plan was to use reconnaissance to gather ways to trap him.

But then, reports came about the encounter with Veldora, and his engagement with Velgrynd.

This was a great stroke of luck, Emperor Rudra thought so, and ordered an immediate sortie; but Kondo had a bad premonition. Logically speaking, there was no doubt this was a good opportunity, and he didn't have a clear reason to oppose

those orders.

It was only to the level of: since the information was still vague, wasn't it premature to act now?

But, the clarity of the information was negligence on the part of Reconnaissance, and wasn't reason enough to let go of this chance.

After all, Kondo's bad feeling was hardly a reason to stop the sortie.

And now.

When Kondo had used his power, —— Not the one granted by the Emperor, but one he had attained on his own —— Ultimate Skill 『Sandalphon the Executioner』 to seal Veldora's movements, his premonition worsened.

He shot Veldora with Remove and Necrosis bullets at their highest potency, but felt like Necrosis' effects were nullified in

the middle.

He also felt that his eyes had met those of the Storm Dragon Veldora at that moment.

—— Not only me, but to lay your hands on my sworn friend Rimuru. You shall not be forgiven, human!!——

He seemed to hear a disembodied voice say.

Necrosis' curse, which caused the destruction of the target's Magic Circuits, was also effective against Spirit Forms.

Even the strongest beings, the “True Dragons” couldn't escape its effects.

To resist it in the first place was to prevent being hit, but that wasn't possible for Veldora who was caught in a complete surprise attack.

It was at a single gap between the time when Veldora's power rivalled Velgrynd's.

With perfect timing, just as Veldora was overpowering the Empire's Guardian Deity, Kondo had succeeded in stopping the Storm Dragon's movements.

But still.....

At the very end, Veldora had managed to resist Necrosis.

Kondo recognized Veldora's impressive feat, and at the same time, felt the strongest sense of uneasiness.

Killing a "True Dragon" was difficult even with multiple shots of Necrosis.

Kondo had fired multiple times to gradually slow him down, and stop his movements. Even if he fell unconscious, a "True Dragon" wouldn't die.

But, even though Veldora should have known that, ignoring the seal binding his body, he focussed on resisting the destruction of Magic Circuits.

No..... perhaps he was resisting Necrosis' curse to protect something much more important than his Magic Circuits?

Veldora's disembodied words supported that line of reasoning.

Yes, Veldora had put the utmost priority in ensuring the safety of his sworn friend, Demon Lord Rimuru.

In that case, the Demon Lord in front of their eyes at that moment, should not be dealt with half-heartedly.

This was the Demon Lord who had become powerless due to Veldora, the source of his power, being stolen?

Ridiculous.

In fact, this was the outraged state he had come to having his sworn friend captured.

That was more likely the case.

Instead of putting one before the other, shouldn't they have chosen to try capturing both of them together?

He had arrived at that conclusion, but it was now too late.

At this point, they could only act according to how the situation played out.

Similar to Damrada, Kondo also braced himself to be able to react accordingly to anything that might happen.

“Scorch Dragon” Velgrynd was also on guard following Rimuru's appearance.

No, not only that, she may have been the one on highest alert, judging the danger Rimuru represented.

A surge of anger not unlike that of her younger brother Veldora could be felt from her.

A Demon Lord, or rather, a lowly slime was releasing an aura similar to themselves, the “True Dragons”.

Normally, a matter impossible to the point of laughable.

Regardless, the Demon Lord with the appearance of a young girl before them was relentlessly releasing an intense aura of rage.

That aura could be called a sign of the danger she represented.

A normal human would instantly die faced with such a fierce aura.

No, it wouldn't stop at humans, anything that didn't possess superior strength would die without the slightest of resistance.

Veldora had recognized the overwhelming prowess of that aura.

(This one's pretty bad. I see why Veldora was interested in her.)

Veldora's growth had greatly exceeded her expectations.

The growth was probably caused by this Demon Lord.

In that case, it was absolutely necessary to face her head on, and beat her into submission.

Or else, she would definitely become a menace. This was what Velgrynd predicted.

And she, once again, calmly returned to a battle-ready state.

The three of them were admirable for not underestimating the Demon Lord Rimuru who had appeared before them.

However, that was not enough.

The correct decision was to take all their forces and gang up on him at full power the moment he appeared.

History is not concerned with what-ifs.

The conclusion was a result of them not taking that correct decision.

The Demon Lord in front of them had already become a being they wouldn't be able to deal with.

He could be called their greatest threat ever.

The battle erupted.

Wisdom Lord Raphael had begun the analysis of the enemy forces immediately after Rimuru had arrived.

And as announced, she had taken the optimum course of action.

Rimuru first launched a Tornado Blade towards the Airship fleet.

It was the same attack used by his Ghost Avatar in the Labyrinth.

It was at a lower level, but the output force was like in another dimension.

Cutting down any enemy within range, it was a magic that manifested itself as many blades of wind.

This was an attack launched by overlapping the effects of Ultimate Skill 『Storm King Veldora's』 “Death Heralding Winds”.

Several atrociously large Wind Blades that ripped through the atmosphere, cut down several Airships.

The immense power was far beyond expectations, but to me, who was blinded by pure anger, it only seems more convenient.

Compared to the Energy used, the power of the Tornado Blade was unbelievable.

With both quality and quantity of Energy being abundant, the magic output would naturally be larger. On top of that, with the effects of an Ultimate Skill overlapping it, the power would reach unprecedented heights.

Moreover, Rimuru's current circumstances were important to consider.

The evolutions of his subordinates were now proceeding much faster. Every one of them who were bonded to Rimuru by the soul, was granting power to him through 『Food Chain』 .

As more time passed, Rimuru's power only kept growing larger.

Wisdom Lord Raphael, who maintained and ensured optimum usage of power, was now acting a support system for an all out assault.

Accordingly, he converted all the abilities received from the subordinates into Energy, and provided it to Rimuru.

And towards that same Rimuru, several energy balls and sword attacks were unleashed.

By Emperor Rudra's orders, the Royal Knights began their

attacks all at once.

They were the few who were granted the Ultimate Gift 『Alternative』 . (TN: Enchant -> Gift, note later.)

A torrent of attacks with power equaling that of Ultimate Skills rushed towards Rimuru.

Rimuru observed the attacks with an unchanging expression.

Compared to his thoughts that had been accelerated 1,000,000 fold, the enemies' movements were far too slow.

《Solution. Analysis complete. All attacks have been determined to be of similar output. It is hypothesized that the outputs are degraded. However, the outputs are equivalent to that of Ultimate Skills.》

(Guard.)

《Solution. Understood.》

All attacks reaching for Rimuru were easily nullified by the Absolute Barrier made by Ultimate Skill 『Covenant King Uriel』.

《Alert. Anti-Barrier countermeasures detected..... successfully nullified.

Furthermore, soul and Magic Circuit destruction attacks detected.

It is hypothesised to belong to Ultimate Skill 『Sandalphon the Executioner』

Successfully guarded.》

Rimuru slightly shifted his gaze towards the Emperor who hadn't moved, and the guards by his side.

(Is that all? I don't need to be careful at all then.

I'll leave you for later. Do try and wallow in despair.

And don't get killed before I come for you.)

And then, to remove the hindrances between him and Veldora, Rimuru played his next hand.

(Diablo, Testarossa, Ultima, Carrera! Are you ready?)

(At any moment, my liege!)

((There are no problems, master Rimuru!!))

To his summons, the three forcefully evolved Demon Dukes, or rather, the three Devil Lords, along with Diablo, swiftly answered.

This summons was their blessing, they were highly anticipating the voice that had called them out.

「Come forth, my Demons! Call Demon • Create Summon Gate!!」

Answering his summons, the 4 Devil Lords manifested.

Bringing along their minions.

The 7 Demon Dukes.

And in addition, the 100 Demon Chevaliers, and the 600 Greater Demons.

One after another, Rimuru's servants assembled after passing through the Summon Gate.

To showcase their fearsome destructive might.

To prove the true depth of Rimuru's rage.

Rimuru delivered his orders to the Demons.

「You are allowed to rampage all you want.

However, death is forbidden.

Letting them get in my way is also forbidden.

While I go free Veldora, keep those mosquitoes busy!」

「How shall we handle Veldora-sama's elder sister?」

「Ah? I'll deal with her. Now go. Grind them to dust!」

Truly simple.

Receiving those words filled the Demons with absolute joy.

The Demons were already provided with all the results of analysis through Thought Linkage.

It was only natural, as, excluding Kondo, any and all skills that the Royal Knights possessed had been exposed to Wisdom Lord Raphael.

「As per your wishes, our lord!!」

These Demons who knew not fear, cast their bodies into battle, solely to be of service to their master.

Gleefully.

The Black Corps of Doom were, just now, released into the world.

It was the maiden battle of Tempest's strongest corps, the Black Numbers.

And so, Rimuru faced Veldora.

He faced his sworn friend who had become the Emperor's puppet.

He also the red dragon, the 'Scorch Dragon' Velgrynd at the same time.

(Just you wait Veldora. I'll definitely free you!)

And the true battle had finally started.

Chapter 174: Rimuru Vs Storm Dragon & Scorch Dragon

Velgrynd readied herself calmly, while looking down at Demon Lord Rimuru.

Having successfully dominated Veldora, Rudra was in his own world, merry about his chances of victory in his game against Guy.

But that carelessness was what had brought about the current state of affairs. If they had swiftly dealt with the situation, there wouldn't be any demon army being summoned; only then would it be proper to think about the battle with Guy.

The present situation was grim.

There were individuals among the summoned demons that even Velgrynd would have problems dealing with.

It was imperative to finish this as quickly as possible.

Alongside Veldora, she would finish off the Demon Lord before them.

With this decision, Velgrynd swiftly took action.

Velgrynd's style was to abide by her intuition, instead of thinking too much.

「Rudra, get Veldora out to battle at full power! It'll be dangerous if we don't eliminate her quick!」

「Hmm. Though I don't see much to be wary of.....

Alright then. Since you are saying that much, let us start off with the leader of these demons. Regalia Dominion!!」

Velgrynd asked Rudra for Veldora's assistance in an exchange via Telepathy.

Rudra still didn't lose any composure, and happily accepted the request to make use of Veldora.

Velgrynd felt slightly anxious at how unconcerned Rudra was. But there didn't seem like there was much of a chance of victory for the Demon Lord, seeing as she had chosen to take on both Veldora and herself.

They were the strongest beings, the "True Dragons", after all.

With a roar, Veldora began to take action.

Velgrynd also roared in an effort of cast off her own uneasiness, and began the assault to destroy the Demon Lord.

Veldora made the first move, against Rimuru who declared he was going to take on two "True Dragons" at the same time.

The first attack against Rimuru was a full power Storm Blast.

《Alert. Incoming Storm Blast.

Deploying 『Covenant King Uriel's』 Barrier—— 》

(Dodge that you idiot!!!)

Rimuru canceled Wisdom Lord Raphael's optimum choice, and took evasive action forcefully.

Shortly after, the defense field that was set up was pierced, and the destructive force from the Storm Blast spread out at that point.

It would have been a direct hit if evasive actions were a moment slower.

——Calculation miss? Unexpected situation? Unable to compute——

《Error. Calculations showed it was 100% probability—— 》

(Now isn't the time to space out! Veldora has Faust's probability manipulation.

It has the capability to bypass your perfectly calculated scenarios. Or should I say control the result? Calculation-based actions won't work against Veldora.

Don't think, feel! Worrying doesn't suit you!

I'll deal with him, so you deal with Velgrynd!)

《—— Under-. I understand. 》

(There's two opponents, but there's also two of us. I'm counting on you, you know?

Wall Velgrynd off with 『Covenant King Uriel』 .

Do what is necessary to hold on until I can get Veldora back.

Or just seal the red fella up! I'm depending on you, partner!)

With those words, a certain feeling fills up Wisdom Lord Raphael's confused and hollow thought processes.

Depending on me?

Even though I was mistaken?

Ah.... This person, says he needs me, I who am simply processing power.

It was, happiness.

It was, blessing.

It was——, the birth of emotion.

Wisdom Lord Raphael was confused at the unprocessable elements which were sprouting out from within.

But, felt at the same time, a sense of fulfillment——

——Ah, I am now, in the midst of eternal bliss——

—— That, was what she processed.

There was nothing to fear now.

Despite the current situation, no danger could be felt.

As Rimuru commanded, Velgrynd's Burning Breath was blocked easily with Covenant King Uriel.

《As you command, my Master!!》

Wisdom Lord Raphael awakened, and with thoughts of answering to Rimuru's wishes, brought forth ever more precision.

Velgrynd was annoyed at the fact that her breath attack was blocked like it was nothing.

As it was an attack on an alert opponent, it was obvious normal attacks weren't going to be enough.

The quality of the opponent's abilities were obviously better despite Velgrynd having more Energy overall.

The opponent has absolute defenses against heat, this wasn't amusing at all.

As a test, she released tens of Heat Blasters in a continuous attack.

Even such an attack didn't have any effect, as everything just bounced off the shield that appeared.

(Tsk! Everything gets blocked, as though perfectly calculated! How annoying.)

This isn't amusing at all.

Demon Lord Rimuru wasn't using the shield against Veldora, but was either dodging or repelling the attacks with a similar attack.

On the other hand, she wasn't even looking at Velgrynd, as all her attacks are fully guarded against.

Even if it was possible to be conscious of everything around oneself with 『Magic Perception』, Velgrynd was absolutely appalled, as it obviously looked like she was being totally ignored.

(I'll make you utterly regret looking down on me!!)

The prideful Velgrynd, decided to unleash the most powerful attack in her entire arsenal.

Like an engine starting up, Velgrynd began releasing immense amounts of magic energy.

Ultimate Skill 『Charity King Raguel』 , her power of manipulating and accelerating heat.

If the ability to forcefully increase momentum was used on herself, the fastest being in this world would undoubtedly be herself.

If so, what if it was used on something other than herself?

With the body being accelerated non-stop, no matter what kind of living being, the body would be unable to withstand the heat and eventually crumble from thermal decay.

「Die! This shall be your end, there will be no remains! Cardinal Acceleration!!」

In addition to her Ultimate Skill, with the essence of heat, her power of acceleration added on.

Waves of destruction were released towards Rimuru, riding the roar of the crimson dragon.

This was, Velgrynd's ultimate attack.

The undulating waves of this ability, easily outsped any form of evasion, it demonstrated Velgrynd's pride as the fastest.

Which meant, evasion was impossible.

For the Demon Lord who was focused on repelling the attacking Veldora, she was in no position to either defend or evade.

If she mistook this to be the same as previous attacks, any number of layers of defense fields would be swallowed whole, and she would die with no time for regrets.

Velgrynd confirmed the effects of her attack with absolute confidence.

But, she was stupefied as she saw the unharmed Rimuru.

(What the! That's not possible!!)

It was an unavoidable, absolute attack, there shouldn't have been anyone who was able to survive such an attack with no injuries at all.

Even if it was Demon Lord Guy・Crimson or her Elder Sister "Frost Dragon" Velzard.

Unless it was repelled by some sort of ability or attack, it wasn't supposed to be an attack that could be stopped by defense field type abilities.

「That's impossible! That attack was supposed to pierce through force fields and defensive abilities.... You, what did you do!!」

「Hmph. That was definitely dangerous.... But It's simple to “eat” such an overly impulsive attack, you know?」

(Well, with Wisdom Lord Raphael's calculations, your attack was baited though.)

For Rimuru to better focus on Veldora, Wisdom Lord Raphael was given free reign to deal with Velgrynd and was inciting all of her attacks.

And, for attacks that looked to be unblockable, Rimuru would briefly deal with such attacks.

Using Gluttony King Belzebuth, the effects of the attack would be consumed. Then, isolated.

This previous attack was definitely capable of dealing fatal damage to Rimuru, an unblockable attack.

But, by consuming and isolating it with Gluttony King Belzebuth, there were no problems.

All that was left is to analyze the energy that had been isolated in the stomach(storage space), and finally neutralize it.

The isolation space of Gluttony King Belzebuth's 『Stomach』 , had become a warped space that has even more power than Absolute Defense, was now capable of neutralizing any attack.

Also, with Wisdom Lord Raphael's baiting of Velgrynd wasn't over just yet.

「Even though you are shocked that nothing happened with your best attack, you do know we are still in the middle of a battle right?」

By the time she recognized and understood what Rimuru said, it was already too late.

《Alert. Analysis of attack concluded. Energy measurement, complete.

Calculations confirm possibility to seal for a limited amount

of time. Activating 『Insulated Prison』 ! 》

That, was an ability synthesized using Covenant King Uriel's Endless Prison fused with an insulated space.

With the surrounding area under control with Spatial Domination silently spread all around, Velgrynd was unaware she had been lured into a multi-layered magic formation.

As Wisdom Lord Raphael announced, a shining 『Insulated Prison』 was formed instantly.

Letting the opponent unleash a finishing move, then aiming for the opportunity right after when the opponent had expended their Energy, such was Wisdom Lord Raphael's perfect strategy.

「Stay there quietly for a while! I'll play with you after I free Veldora.」

Said Rimuru as Raphael activated the hidden prison, while he

was still dealing with Veldora.

It was a restraining technique with the opponent's special traits taken into account, made a reality with the fusion of abilities.

It would be called Calculation Prison, if it were to be given a name.

A total victory for Wisdom Lord Raphael.

Rimuru confirmed that Velgrynd was properly sealed, and gave a satisfied nod to Wisdom Lord Raphael for faithfully completing the objective.

《Alert. 『Insulated Prison』 activation confirmed. Target movements sealed, for roughly 3 minutes.》

(Got it! Now then, to put all our effort into dealing with Veldora. Gimme a hand, Raphael!!)

《As you wish!》

Rimuru, no, the both of them who sealed “Scorch Dragon” Velgrynd up for the time being... now turned their attention to “Storm Dragon” Veldora, their real goal.

To clinch the victory, within the 3 minutes of time bought by Raphael.

To use this short yet seemingly infinite amount of time the best he could, Rimuru charged towards Veldora.

As expected of Wisdom Lord Raphael.

To perfectly answer my expectations, no, much more than that, within such a short period of time.

Managing to seal Velgrynd, one of the “True Dragons”, for several minutes even.

Hmph.

I can't lose to that now.

Gotta free Veldora quickly, and take down the Emperor.

I couldn't let more people be controlled against their own will, like Chloe.

Then, to swiftly crush the empire, and corner Yuuki.

There's a whole mountain load of things I had to do, and things that need to be done.

Can't be stumbling now.

(Sorry for the wait, Veldora. The real deal starts now!)

Time to finish this quickly.

During the time Wisdom Lord Raphael was dealing with Velgrynd, Rimuru was finding difficulty in doing anything decisive against Veldora.

As the Storm series abilities had been left behind, it was possible to repel Veldora's attacks. But to repel such large scale attacks, it resulted in a similar level of energy consumption.

It wasn't a direct source of damage, but stamina is definitely being shaved off.

The energy recovery from 『Food Chain』 seemed to help a lot, as the evolution of his subordinates had an influence on it.

There weren't many attacks from this side that have direct effect.

Weapon attacks were pointless.

Storm series abilities were also pointless.

It was confirmed that Covenant King Uriel wasn't going to be of much help, so its usage was passed over to Wisdom Lord Raphael.

Only Gluttony King Belzebuth could be relied on.

It was the highest point of evolution, from the base Slime ability 『Predation』.

Now that Gluttony King Belzebuth had been mastered, it could be activated from any part of this Demon Slime body.

That's right, even with the entire body.

It was decided.

To not just neutralize the Storm attacks with Gluttony King

Belzebuth, but to straight up totally devour Veldora.

「Making me do all this work, Veldora! Stop causing all this trouble dammit! 」

——Kuahahahaha! It's just a small failure. Forgive me! ——

At the moment of contact with Veldora, I thought I hear a carefree voice.

(Hey.... You conscious in there?)

——Yeah. Actually, I fully seperated my Nucleic Heart, so my ego is completely intact! ——

(Then hurry up and get your body back!)

——I would if I could. Oh, look out, “Black Lightning” is coming up! ——

At the moment he heard Veldora say that, the powerful slicing ability of the “Death Heralding Winds” assaulted Rimuru.

Frantically evading, Rimuru got Wisdom Lord Raphael to balance out his surroundings.

(The hell man, that ain’t what you said! What lightning, those were wind blades!?)

——Mmm!? Sorry bout that. Looks like I can only tell when a skill is going to be activated but not identify which skill——

(Got it.... Stop saying such irresponsible things. Mistakes like that can cause failure.

It won’t be a laughing matter if I died after trusting you.)

——Roger that. I was hoping I could help a little though——

(Well, it's all good enough if you're fine.)

——Kuahahahaha! Of course I'm fine. I **am** the most powerful dragon right!?!—

(Ah, yeah. I'll get you out in a bit, so wait?)

——No problem. I wasn't worried at all. For that purpose, I suppressed the worst of it——

(The worst?)

——Ah. I took a shot of a “curse” that destroys magic circuits. So I hurriedly cut the Soul Corridor. As the effect travels through the magic circuits, it would have affected you too——

(Huh? So it wasn't destroyed by the enemy's ability?)

——Yeah. It was a powerful ability, and since I wasn't going to

make it with defense, that was the only way to minimize collateral damage. Because of that, my Resist magic circuits were destroyed and I wasn't able to resist the "Domination effect", which resulted in the present situation! ——

(Stop boasting about that. Geez, just what were you thinking.

weren't I telling you not to let your guard down every other day!?)

——Kuahahahaha! Who would've thought I would get chewed out by you in this situation! ——

(Alright that's enough, what matters is you're alright. You *are* alright right?)

——Technically speaking, I'm fine. While destroying the Soul Corridor, I protected my Heart which served as the core. But because of that, I lost all control over my body, and had no means of recovering that control——

So that's why.

But as long as the core is intact, we have options available.

(Wisdom Lord Raphael, is it possible to recover Ultimate Skill 『Storm King Veldora』?)

《Alert. As long as the Nucleic Heart is intact, re-establishing the Soul Corridor is possible. There are no problems with the recovery of Ultimate Skill 『Storm King Veldora』.》

Alright, problem solved.

The remaining task would be to defeat Veldora's "body". It's all good as long as we can recover the core.

(Sit tight. I'll free you soon.)

——Kuahahahaha! How reliable. You have my faith, Rimuru

my friend! ——

Yea, I'm gonna free you real quick.

The problem had been solved.

The direction to go about getting Veldora back was confirmed.

All that was left was to actually do it.

Alrighty, let's beat him then.

One of the strongest, "Storm Dragon" Veldora!!

Chapter 175: Veldora Released

Now then, as soon as I saw a ray of hope, I regained my calm.

Entrusting my anger to the situation would endanger Veldora's main body, the "Storm Dragon (energy)".

It's not that my anger had disappeared, but rather I had to calmly deal with the situation.

This anger was something I needed to vent out on the Emperor later.

I had to first prioritize my objectives.

In order to free Veldora, defeating the main body before me would suffice.

However that alone wouldn't be enough, and I had to first retrieve Veldora's Nucleic Heart, and reconstruct the "Soul Corridor".

Well, I should manage somehow.

Wisdom Lord Raphael had already bought some time.

So we could focus on dealing with the “Storm Dragon”.

However, Investigation King Faust’s “Probability Manipulation” seemed troublesome.

Rather than worrying about which attacks were manipulated, thinking of every attack as something with additional uncertainties was sufficient.

After all, the “Storm Dragon’s” Energy was immense.

I still felt an energy supplementation from it, but compared to the flow of “power” from Veldora when the “Soul Corridor” was intact, this was nothing.

However, there was no need for worry.

I had Gluttony King Belzebuth, as well as Wisdom Lord Raphael with me after all.

I would have “Storm Dragon’s” “Storm Blast” predated on by Gluttony King Beelzebub.

Then, disassembled.

This wasn’t going to be easy. Because, if the predation failed, and I took a direct hit, my body would be destroyed with that one shot.

I feared that the destruction speed would be quicker than my ability to escape via clone.

Having a clone ready from the start, similar to my first battle against Hinata, would be pointless.

After all, if I couldn't grant Ultimate Abilities onto the clone, it would be immediately destroyed.

In the end, the seemingly all-powerful clone couldn't be used for anything other than as a decoy against weaker foes.

Well it depended on the opponent, and, with retreat being a priority, if victory wasn't necessary, then there were several uses for it.

Under circumstances where defeat wasn't an option, it would be useless.

Therefore, I had to defeat the "Storm Dragon" head-on.

Attacks other than "Storm Blast" would be dodged if possible, and otherwise offset with another attack.

With Raphael's calculations assisting my instincts, it had gotten much easier since a while ago.

However, it was true that the abilities of the Ultimate Skill 『Storm King Veldora』 were left behind really helped.

If they weren't there, there were high chances of defeat due to the not being able to offset the oncoming attacks.

The fact that the abilities were able to remain was probably due to Veldora's timing.

You've done all this, so I've got to answer to those expectations.

And so I attempted to find the timing.

Since I didn't know the location of Veldora's Nucleic Heart, I couldn't initiate any attacks.

Or rather, there were ways for me to attack, however it would be difficult to inflict any fatal damage.

Using various Nuclear Strike magics overlapped by Ultimate Skills would definitely inflict some damage.

I could also use 『Holy Demonic Inversion』, and release a holy attribute Ultimate Magic “Disintegration”.

However, this kind of magic wouldn’t be fatal with just one or two shots.

This was, without a doubt, due to the greatest trait of the “True Dragons” that even surpassed that of Demon Lords, their heightened durability.

Even so, if I wanted to take down the Heart-less “Storm Dragon”, I’d only have to assemble a multi-layered magic formation, and strike with the compressed synergetic magic.

After all, without the Heart, its attacks had become patterned, and through her calculations, Wisdom Lord Raphael could perceive the next attack.

Having analyzed many attack patterns, she used the knowledge to make her predictions.

This was something I didn't understand, but analyzing algorithms was indeed very useful.

Though I thought it was enough to just randomize our attacks since their results would get their "probability manipulated".....

After all, it was at a Heart-less, rampaging state.

One could call this the sorrow of the dominated.

Frankly speaking, the reason I could also evade was thanks to this.

And now, with Wisdom Lord Raphael, it was like having a child as an opponent.

Wisdom Lord Raphael-san who was brimming with confidence for some reason could easily come up with a plan to kill.

And thus, simply defeating it was not an issue.

There were two problems.

The time limit, and the location of the Nucleic Heart.

If by chance, the Heart got destroyed then it was all over.

Complete operation failure.

The main body of the “Storm Dragon” would be under the complete dominion of the Emperor, and the “Soul Corridor” needed for Veldora’s resurrection would no longer be reconstructible.

Then it would all be meaningless.

That's why I had to be careful.

I was looking for the right timing since a while ago.

The reason I got close to the rampaging "Storm Dragon", and initiated a close combat, was for this timing.

The clock was ticking, but I didn't worry.

There were 2 minutes remaining, but rather than rushing I evaded the attacks, slyly creeping in, and shortening our distance.

The more our distances shortened , the harder it became to evade the attacks..... however Raphael's attack prediction increased dodging precision.

With my intuition and 『Future Attack Prediction』 used simultaneously, we could somehow manage to evade.

Carefully, without flustering, indifferently handling the attacks ——

—— Now!

Without overlooking the opening for an instant immediately right after the “Storm Dragon” attacked, I activated Gluttony King Belzebuth, and devoured the “Storm Dragon’s” main body.

My body changed from human to fluid form, its viscous property strongly emphasizing the irregular shape.

In accordance to my intentions to attack and devour, it changed into a shape suitable to entangle the opponent.

To bind, and devour the “Storm Dragon”.

However, naturally, the opponent was too large. Even if I stretched my body, I couldn't pass a certain point.

However, there was no need to worry, as Gluttony King Belzebuth's erosion had begun.

Simultaneously, the "Storm Dragon's" destruction aura that resisted hostile existences had begun to break down my body.

Towards I who was trying to devour it, the "Storm Dragon" in turn attempted to exhaust me.

A violent attrition battle had begun.

It hurt, it burned, it was excruciating.

I was not supposed to feel pain, yet now, intense pain surged throughout my body.

Me feeling heat didn't make any sense either, yet I felt like I was melting.

This was the first time I felt like this in this world, this intense pain.

My intuition detecting the destruction of my very existence may have stimulated my senses.

However, I will never slow down the predation.

I will win.

At this rate the "Storm Dragon (Energy)" will be devoured and absorbed.

And then, Veldora's Heart will be separated, and the "curse" that destroyed the magic circuit will be analyzed and nullified.

For that, this amount of pain was nothing.

(Raphael, are there any problems?)

《Solution. There are absolutely no problems.》

Everything's alright.

Obtaining the absolute answer, I further accelerated the erosion.

As as I converted what I devoured into energy, the equivalent amount of flesh was destroyed.

My flesh was reconstructed once more, and the erosion continued.

This repeatedly repeated.

Time was running out, and with the target being so large, I feared that I would not make it.

However, I believed in Wisdom Lord Raphael.

I will make it in time.

《Alert. Reporting results of Parallel Analysis.

Analysis of “Cardinal Acceleration” has concluded.

Reproduction of ability has failed.

Analysis of “Storm Blast” has concluded.

Reproduction of ability successful.....it is now possible to use it.

Analysis of “Storm Dragon Energy” has concluded.

It is now possible to reconfigure the bodily composition into the same type as “Storm Dragon”.

Would you like to execute? YES/NO »

What?

Didn't you just say something weird?

Even though the analysis of “Cardinal Acceleration” was a success, it's natural I wouldn't be able to use it.

Since I didn't take “Scorch Dragon” Velgrynd's abilities, replicating her Ultimate Skill merely by seeing it would be impossible.

The fact I was able to use “Storm Blast” after analyzing made

sense.

My Ultimate Skill 『Storm King Veldora』 remained, and the power's basis had already been analyzed.

Although it's amazing I could use a powerful ability and I'm happy about it, it's something that fell within the range of my understanding.

If it was Wisdom Lord Raphael-san, this wasn't unusual, I got used to it.

However, that last line.

It was possible to reconfigure my body into the same type as a “Storm Dragon”?

I didn't quite get the meaning of this.

If my understanding is correct, that would mean I would become the same as a “True Dragon” but.....

《Answer. That inference is correct. 》

The wha-!?

Correct, err, hey you!?

——Are you serious?

《Inquiry. Would you like to begin reconstructing your body into a “True Dragon? YES/NO 》

Fufufu, Fuhaha, Fuhahahahaha !

Certainly, I executed a 3 part laugh, and thus commanded.

In that instant, the pain I felt vanished.

The pain, the heat, the agony.

Due to my new body, the corrosive anti-threat aura the “Storm Dragon” released was nullified.

In other words, I now simply kept on devouring, and converted everything into my energy.

Rapidly, my magic Energy replenished, and began to rise.

That was done at an accelerated pace, because if I slowed down against the “Storm Dragon”, it would be fatal.

If this was Veldora, he probably would have been able to immediately respond.

But, since the dominated being was only the “Storm Dragon”,

it didn't have the corresponding reaction speed.

In the first place, if Veldora was the opponent, I wouldn't even be able to even get a hold of him.

This being was only able to act in accordance to its programming.

Once I understood this, it was no longer a threat.

(Now then, let's end this!

I wouldn't forgive you (Bastard) for calling yourself my cherished "Storm Dragon".

Devour, Gluttony King Belzebuth!!)

In accordance to my order, Gluttony King Belzebuth gleefully restarted devouring "Storm Dragon (Energy)". And that, at a

terrifying speed.

Unlike previously, the power-balance was now one-sided.

The hunter, and the hunted. It was the very essence of the law of the Jungle.

And so, my body had been reconstructed into a “True Dragon”, my Energy broke through the limit, and continued to increase.

An evolution and rebirth had occurred, and blinding light flooded the surroundings.

My old body couldn't withstand the energy used for the reconstruction into a “True Dragon”, and it was released in an explosion of light.

When the light faded, the “Storm Dragon’s” figure had disappeared.

In its place was an unknown life form.

Devouring the “Storm Dragon” which could be called its parent, its body was reborn as the 5th “True Dragon”, the Ultimate Slime (Viscous Dragonoid Demon God).

That figure soon took the form of a human.

It looked around the age of 15~16, with a lustrous silver hair with a visible hint of violet mixed into it.

With golden eyes that looked as if it could see all, they were sharp and beautiful.

Albeit genderless, one could call her features cute rather than beautiful.

However, clad in a divine aura (presence), her beauty was sublime.

A single sword in her hand, she lacked clothing.

With dazzling white skin, one could see the black and gold aura (magic) coated around her.

As if whispering something in dissatisfaction, light enveloped her whole body, and a set of divine jet-black clothes appeared.

It was different from matter creation, a part of her body was modified and turned into armor.

By using the Energy that overflowed from her body, she created that set of clothing.

Just like that, all the excessive energy was released, and suppressed.

Visibly satisfied, a grin appeared on her face.

Velgrynd saw all that whilst trapped in her prison.

One more strike was all that was needed to break out of the prison.

However, she completely forgot about that one strike as she gawked at the spectacle.

Her own brother, the “Storm Dragon” Veldora ,against the “Demon Lord” Rimuru; “Storm Dragon” Veldora should have had the overwhelming advantage.

According to investigations, Rimuru was born from the congregation of magic essence from Veldora’s leaked Aura.

Since it could be considered an inferior copy of a “True Dragon”, it would naturally be a strong monster more or less.

It would naturally be a Unique Monster.

However, it was definitely impossible for it to surpass its creator, the “True Dragon”. If it could, that would imply that it was a being of equal rank to begin with.

(A coincidence? It can't be.....by chance, and she was born just like that?!)

Concluding her thoughts, and shocked at the answer she came up with, Velgrynd needed some time to take it in.

A monster that was born near a “True Dragon” out of pure coincidence, and was born with a soul that was compatible with a dragon's essence, something like that.

Above all it was a non-elemental, absorbing the elements it took in, she couldn't possibly accept this so easily.

Then it could possibly even be called the 5th, another younger brother(?), but strictly speaking it wasn't a “True Dragon”.

And if it was to be classified, it's something with the ability of a "Dragon".

She didn't want to recognize this, nor would she do so.

That thing had to be eliminated immediately.

That for sure, would also to serve as vengeance for her brother.

Although things happened, he was still her cute little brother.

Although she intended to control him as a pawn, for a dragon it would only be for a few insignificant years.

She did not have the intention to kill him or the sort at all.

And so, when she finally accepted that he was devoured before her very eyes, Velgrynd's anger blew away all reasoning.

「My brother (Veldora) you..... HOW DARE YOU!!」

Breaking out her prison as she roared in anger, the “Scorch Dragon” Velgrynd rushed towards and assaulted Rimuru.

The same time as I finished devouring the “Storm Dragon”, my evolution had completed, and it appeared that I was born anew as a unique species.

Although it had the fancy name ‘Ultimate Slime (Viscous Dragonoid Demon God)’, it’s not a slime at all, I thought in secret.

This late into it, if I think too much about it I lose.

Now to check out the new body.

This body that was born without consuming Energy had a greatly increased capacity.

Thanks to that, the body that once looked around 12 years old, now looked around the age of 16.

This feeling of growth felt interesting, but for me who could freely modify my age this wasn't anything of significance.

Well, in regard to Energy usage, as long as I'm able to move about in my relaxed state then there were no problems.

My slime form probably had an increase in mass. I might even have a diameter of 70~80cm now.

I should confirm that later.

And so, I was currently not wearing anything. In other words, I'm naked.

That's no good.

A strange aura has leaked out, covering my body——Even though I didn't have any reproductive organs as usual——however, from my own ethical point of view this was something unfavorable.

(aka, there's neither hole or pole down there...god this sounds so wrong....)

And so, I produced some clothes.

Using the matter creation ability from Diablo and the other demons, I used my Aura, and created clothes.

This also had some defensive capabilities to a certain extent. If the creator's own body is used, it would have a complementary performance.

In an instant, my body felt like it was garbed in clothing. It felt very pleasant; it was a set of cool black garbs.

The performance was.....God tier.

God tier? God tier was it ~ I see.....wait, Huh?!

This was what it meant to be shocked stupid.

In other words, the part of my body ——the flesh of my main body——had this kind of ridiculous defensive capability.

I felt like I had evolved, I see, indeed.

One reason may be that several of my subordinates were awakening into Demon Lords, and their abilities were gather via 『Food Chain』 .

Coming here, I felt like I had awakened a whole lot more.

Well, since my body was rebuilt into a “True Dragon”, it was only natural I would have this kind of defensive capability.

This was all the result of a successful operation.

In short this was all thanks to Wisdom Lord Raphael-san. This was really well done, truly befitting of Sensei.

《Alert. Not at all.》

She may have said, but I ignored it.

Well, I've got clothes now, but I haven't forgotten my original objective.

(Veldora, you alright?)

(Kuahahahaha!

How many times have I told you.

Of course I'm safe.

Or rather look at you, well done defeating my main body safely.

(It was really intense though.

But, this is wonderful, it truly is!)

Veldora and I were both glad the other was all right.

And so, as proof of Veldora's release, I heard the voice of Wisdom Lord Raphael.

《Report. "Soul Corridor" with individual: Veldora successfully re-established.》

Wisdom Lord Raphael was always constantly working.

This time too, it was flawless work as usual.

《Report, there have been modifications to the ultimate skill 『Storm King Veldora』.

Storm Dragon Summon: Summon Veldora in his original dragon form.

※Energy required would vary corresponding to summoning delay.

Storm Dragon Release: Individual: Veldora would be granted a clone to take free action.

※Upon death, memories could be restored, and releasing once again is possible.

Storm series magic: “Death Heralding Winds” “Black Lightning” “Storm of Ruins” “Storm lightning”

※ Chantless, instant activation possible.

Bladed Storm: Crystallization, Transforming into a Blade Core.

That is all. 》

Alright.

The first tactical victory condition has been cleared.

Next came the second and third.

Eliminating the threat, slaughtering the Imperial soldiers.

Now that my anger had settled, I started to think like.....it's fine not to kill them all right~

but with the Black Numbers rampaging about, it was probably too late.

Oh well, it was necessary to eliminate the threat anyway.

Let's maintain our momentum up until the end.

Steeling my determination, I faced the "Scorch dragon" Velgrynd who would attack me shortly.

Chapter 176: Sword of Tempest

I succeeded in freeing Veldora.

But the danger still loomed.

Basically, these were “Scorch Dragon” Velgrynd, the Emperor, and finally, the army uniform guy who had shot at Veldora.

There were several others who could also be placed under the label of “danger”, and I wanted to get rid of them all at once.

But really, other than those first three, the others didn’t feel like a “danger” at all.

My body, having transformed into that of a “True Dragon” with its Energy reaching the greatest heights, had yet again drastically exceeded in power in both quality and quantity.

So much that, now, I could probably pack a punch against even Milim or Guy.

But, I shouldn't get conceited, or something bad might happen; truly, negligence is sin.

I will finish off all of them, leaving behind not a single drop of blood.

That being said, the Black Numbers had already done quite a number on them, and it seemed like only the strongest of them remained.

Well, as long as there weren't any casualties.....

Were they following my order to not die?

I'll worry about that later.

As there was an enraged Velgrynd approaching as we speak.

First, I think I should let Veldora come out using Storm

Dragon Release.

My Energy wasn't always at full capacity probably because, I let Veldora roam freely.

But because Veldora's power was overflowing into me, the circulation had caused a revitalization effect on my body.

Before attaining the nature of a "True Dragon", I had been using a large portion of energy to maintain releasing Veldora—— but that neither caused me inconvenience nor did I particularly feel anything from it —— but now, I only needed to allocate around 30% of my energy for the upkeep.

Well, there weren't any problems using large scale magic despite that, so I didn't think too deeply about it.

Thinking that, as I was about to perform Storm Dragon Release,

(Wait. I requested that Wisdom Lord to enhance my Skills.)

《Alert. Currently in the process of synchronization of Master and individual: Veldora's abilities.

Currently engaged in evolving 『Investigation King Faust』 into 『Chaos Lord Nyarlathotep』 .

Please delay usage of Storm Dragon Release until completion.》

Both of them stopped me.

Apparently it was Veldora's request.

She hadn't informed me, so that must have been the case.

I wanted to tell them to do it some other time, but it's probably something that can't be done after Releasing.

I guess it couldn't be helped, and would be harder to do later, but then,

《Solution. From the analysis of individual: Veldora's Skills, ability to evolve Ultimate Skill 『Storm King Veldora』 confirmed.

Consequently, Ultimate Skill 『Covenant King Uriel』 will be erased.

Would you like to synthesize Ultimate Skill 『Stellar-Wind Lord Hastur』 ? YES/ NO 》

Wisdom Lord Raphael informs me almost as a side note.

Good lord..... this Raphael-san doesn't intend to slow down at all.

To think of reconstructing Skills mid-fight, just how relaxed was she?

As if “Scorch Dragon” Velgrynd didn't matter at all.

For now, it's a NO.

Really, I did still have Gluttony King Belzebuth, but that didn't mean we should let our guard down.

Rather, to fight a "True Dragon" with only Belzebuth?

Aren't you overestimating me a bit too much? I kept thinking.

After this battle, along with my subordinates getting their Demon Lord ascensions done with, I guess I'll also undergo a massive Skill overhaul.

Just what was I going to be made to become, I decided to think about it later.

Now then, what to do about this "Scorch Dragon".

The quality and quantity of my Energy had increased, and so

had my strength.

I was thinking of testing out these powers, and wanted to dive into battle, but as Wisdom Lord Raphael was in the process of refining Veldora's Skills, close-quarters combat seemed like a bad idea.

I guess it wasn't too bad to fight head on, but getting damaged on top of using up Energy for attacks could make things troublesome.

I didn't want any weird effects from damage.

Therefore, I wanted to maintain some distance, and finish this with ranged attacks.

This was strategy, not cowardice.

If I could win easily, I shouldn't hesitate and just do it.

Though I say that, I didn't really have many ranged attack options.

Covenant King Uriel's Severance Series abilities were powerful, but their effective range was rather small.

It was a fearsome power like Dimension Severance, so obviously it was restricted to a certain range.

So that leaves, Magic?

Among the Nuclear Magics, there was one emission type attack more suited to ranged combat.

"Nuclear Cannon", a type of laser cannon.

It was relatively easy to control, so human Great Mages seemed to prefer it.

That is to say, it was the easiest to control of the Nuclear Magics.

Furthermore, the cost-performance was pretty good too. Right now, my mana recovery rate was higher than its usage cost, so I could fire all I wanted without worrying about depletion.

That catch was, it definitely wouldn't have any effect on Velgrynd.

This was an emission attack that used concentrated mana particles, but at the end of the day, it was a heat based attack.

Against Velgrynd, who governed "Heat", it would be useless. Even if it was overlapped with the effects of Ultimate Skills, she could probably easily Resist it.

It was the most powerful of the Emission type attacks, but it was useless if there was no effect.

Really, what to do.....

It suddenly came to me.

There was a new ability added to “Storm King Veldora”.

Reconstructed from “Storm Blast”, it was an ability called “Storm Lightning”.

At present, it was in fact the strongest long range attack in my possession.

This may just work on Velgrynd from a distance.

I wanted to try out this “Storm Lightning” right away but ——

—— I happened to notice another thing I just had to try.

Bladed Storm: Crystallization, Transforming into a Blade Core..... ?

It'd been re~ally bothering me for a while now, what was this thing?

That said, I couldn't let my guard down around Raphael-san.

What in the world do you have to do, to evolve this overpowered Storm King Veldora into an Stellar-Wind Lord Hastur; I had not Idea at all.

Apparently it would integrate with Covenant King Uriel, but what about the usability?

Well whatever.

The Bladed Storm did seem interesting, but it looked like it was a non ranged power.

I'll ignore it for now. I don't even know what I'm supposed to crystallize in the first place.

《Solution. Ranged attacks possible with “Bladed Storm”.

Condensing the full spirit strength of Storm King Veldora, it is possible to launch a vectorized Energy blast.

Unlike Storm Dragon Release, which is being withheld to reconnect the Soul Corridor, it is possible to use this at present.》

So crystallization means, the power from releasing Veldora, is directly injected into a sword?

Which would mean that this sword represented all of Veldora's power.....

《Solution. That inference can be considered correct.》

Ok.

It's probably like Veldora and me attacking at once, so it's the most powerful attack I have right now.

Since I decided not to relax, I'll go for it.

I timidly attempted to perform the Bladed Storm.

《Alert. Individual: Veldora's consent affirmed. Initializing Crystallization.》

Right then, the handle of my sword crystallized with a purple glow.

I felt my hand connected to Veldora through the sword.

It seemed that the sword had become part of my body.

As expected, my Energy levels dropped by 30%.

As I thought, it wasn't the Summoning, but the Release that drained the 30%.

And the crystallization seemed to cause the same effect.

In other words, this sword was like the manifestation of all of Veldora's Energy.

Along with the Bladed Storm, as if right on time, Velgrynd started to move.

It was a good time as any, so as a little test, I made a swing at Velgrynd.

Well, it was more a thoughtless flick of the wrist really.

And seeing that move, Velgrynd attempted a dodge.

It was likely a normal reaction for her.

Or maybe, it was her instincts doing the work.

But as a result, that very act of evasion saved her life.

A single swing of that sword had pierced the heavens, and split the seas.

Literally.

The deadly shockwave had no resemblance to the action of a sword, and cut down Velgrynd's wings mid-evasion.

It's strength still not waning, it split multiple Imperial Airships in two along its path.

And It didn't end there either.

The Energy of the swing even cut apart the ocean.

The waters divided.

I couldn't represent what unfolded below me in any other words.

Something like an electric field coating the split ocean, was keeping the waters apart.

The released Energy seemed to be further increasing the gap.

What kind of joke is this.....

I think I had the right to think that.

I didn't mean to do this at all, it was only a simple swing.

Et Voila the result, I also felt a large quantity of my energy being used up.

《Report. Failure occurred in controlling “Sword of Tempest”. Energy usage was higher than predicted.》

Failure, huh.... That aint the problem!

No one cares about the Energy usage!

Well, it’s certainly not good, but back to the point.

The point was: the output.

We literally broke the ocean dammit! Normal environmental destruction looks like a joke in comparison.....

Plus, the range was super long, and the damage was unreal too.

It was so big, I probably needed to blacklist it.

(Kuahahahaha! My bad, my bad. Put a little too much umph into it.)

So he was the cause....

I was really glad we were in over water.

If this was in the middle of a city, it wouldn't just be a town disappearing, there was enough power to endanger an entire country.

It seemed that control was divided between the wills of both me and Veldora, and it seemed like the output this time was caused by Veldora.

Does that mean, if i also wanted to attack, the output would be even higher?

That's too scary!

This sword is too dangerous, it felt like a cheat item.

(Hey, that was way overboard you know?

Look, even your big sis looks like she doesn't understand what just happened, and is totally out of it.)

(Heh, that's fine. If it's my elder sister, she wouldn't die even if she took a direct hit.)

(That isn't the point..... But enough, I'll be controlling the output from now on.)

(Yeah, got it. No problem!)

Geez Louise.

If this happened every time, sooner or later places would become uninhabitable.

Veldora had given the green light too, gotta keep the power down.

「B-bastard! What, was that? What the hell was that!!」

Velgrynd who came back to her senses, screamed at me, in a mix of anger and fear.

Really, someone needs to tell me.

But, if i had to answer,

「Uh, Veldora Sword?」

I answered so.

With that single attack, it looked as if the battle was decided.

That one attack which pierced the heavens and split the seas was enough to utterly crush the spirits of the Imperial soldiers.

Multi-layered barriers were sliced through like a hot knife through butter, there was also nowhere to escape being out at sea.

Even if they managed to move beyond the speed of sound, it meant nothing if they couldn't outrun the attack.

The hearts of the Imperial soldiers filled despair, and those feelings became the most delectable "food source" for the demons.

And then....

「No way, why?

Why, did the effect of my Regalia Dominion.... my “Sovereign Rule” disappear?

Why, was Veldora defeated?!

Impossible, that’s just impossible!

It was just a lowly Demon Lord, a puny slime!

It should have become powerless, after the source of its powers, Veldora, was taken away....

How, could it consume it’s master, and take that power for itself!!

I was this close to finally achieving victory against Guy!!

To get in the way of my plans.... Unforgivable, you lowly Demon Lord!!」(

Emperor Rudra, was furious.

He was so angry that he wasn't conscious of what was happening around him.

He had been ecstatic when he saw he could finally emerge victorious against Guy in their never ending game.

The moment right before victory is when one should be the most wary.

The cost of forgetting this ironclad rule, and being so careless, had now come back to bite him.

The ones who defended the Emperor, had no cards to play to deal with the situation at hand.

Everything was happening too fast.

With no means to turn the tide in the present situation, the act now moved towards the finale.

Now for something off topic, but not totally unrelated.

The cause of the 『Calamity』 being a battle between “True Dragons” would be verified by scholars in the future.

But, the real cause was something else.

The emergence of the sea monsters in the 『Calamity』 stricken seas, was caused by that one swing of the Veldora Sword.

The Energy overflowing from that attack, pressured and pushed aside the seawater.

That phenomenon lasted a fairly long amount of time, which resulted in noxious amounts of Demonic Energy settling into the depths of the ocean.

Thereafter great amounts of that Energy gradually spread throughout the ocean, causing ludicrous changes to the ecosystem.

Although the 『Calamity』 was named the “Scorching Tempest”, the massive downpour from the evaporated seawater couldn’t have caused such an impact on the ecosystem.

In truth, the clash between Veldora and Velgrynd couldn’t have caused this much damage.

Of course, the location was obviously amazingly lucky, but there was no way it was planned by the perpetrators.....

The point was, the resulting aftereffects of that single attack, would be the cause of headaches for future historians; but the truth of what transpired would never be known to the world.

Chapter 177: The Black Numbers

When the demons were summoned on Rimuru's command, even the upper echelons of the Imperial army recognized the bizarreness of the situation.

Major General Xam'd was one of them.

As the demon Summoning Gate manifested,

「U- Unbelievable.... For the Summon Gate to be that huge....」

He couldn't help but hear such things muttered by a subordinates Mage.

Energy analysis began immediately, and they finally understood the predicament they were in.

The demons that had been summoned, each and every one of them were demonic beings that surpassed the rank of Greater Demons.

「Th-That's just.... Just how much war potential does he have....」

Words of trying not to face the reality before them start leaking out.

Gradim, who clearly heard those words, turned his attention onto Major General Xam'd.

There wasn't much point in hiding it. Xam'd had simply spoken the facts for what they were.

Which was, that an army of demons with the strength to overpower their own Imperial army had appeared.

Even if they outnumber them, there wasn't much that could be done to cover the difference in quality.

They would be slaughtered if they didn't try and do something about it.

Even if the brass, including himself, could survive, all the regular soldiers would get massacred.

Gradim didn't want to believe it, but Major General Xam'd wasn't the type of guy who joked around.

(Tsk. We underestimated him because it was only a Demon Lord....)

It was too late for regrets now.

Now was time to do whatever possible.

As the emperor was also there, they couldn't take any disgraceful actions.

Gradim made his decision, activated the teleportation magic circle, went to where his forces were standing by, and took direct command.

The members of the Beast Corps were the cream of the crop, hand picked and trained by Beast King Gradim himself.

It was a gathering of strong individuals, with rumors saying they are descendents of ancient heroes.

And their Demon Beasts partners, were said to be A- rank in terms of power.

Battle Chimeras: Demon Beasts which were born from selective breeding after DNA analysis. They were seen as a type of weapon, having combat oriented abilities.

And it was obvious that the Corps members who had tamed them, were also ranked above A- in terms of capability.

Their strength when battling together on land, were said to be second to none.

But currently they were above the sea, which put them at a disadvantage.

That was exactly why, the hastily returned Beast King Gradim issued one specific order.

「Listen up, ladies!! From this point on, i will be issuing the Secret Command.

The analysis team has concluded that the demons are all above A rank in capability.

It is predicted that we will suffer massive losses if nothing is done.

Which is why, we shall oppose them with our last resort.

Permission to use Medical Skill 『Beast Fusion』 is hereby granted.

Make haste. The enemy isn't going to wait for us!!」

The forbidden order was issued.

Medical Skill 『Beast Fusion』 , was a skill that was developed by the team responsible for the analysis of Demon Beast DNA.

This skill, fused the Demon Beast and it's handler together.
(TN: duh)

Letting a human attain the power of a Demon Beast; a forbidden power.

The reason it was called a forbidden skill, was because it became impossible for the individual who activated it to cancel the effects.

The drug used for the skill, had to be surgically removed in a facility with the appropriate tools.

Through the fusion of the handler and his partner, a warrior that surpassed the original concept would be born.

The drug was distributed and kept on hand, so it was possible to activate whenever necessary. But, usage is prohibited without the Secret Command from the corps leader.

There was another reason why it was “secret”.

Risk of death: 10%

Risk of compatibility failure and completely turning into a Demon Beast: 20%

Risk of losing control (applies for both Beastman and Demon Beast): 30%

Risk of side effects resulting from the fusion: 20%

There were many underlying problems.

There is only a 20% chance for “complete” success of the

fusion. (TN: I don't like doing math but the percentages don't add up lol)

But like Gradim, there were corps members who successfully fused and completed the process.

These members consequently attained new powers, and became stronger.

These perfectly compatible individuals, made up less than 1% among the entire corps.

They were called Chimera Knights, and were the aides of Beast King Gradim.

The order that Gradim calmly issued, was akin to a death sentence for the Beast Corps troops.

If there were unable to attain power now, they will simply end up as fodder for the demons.

It was a cold, but pragmatic order.

And the troops swiftly followed it.

They had prior knowledge to the risks, and knew of the high mortality rate.

But because they had absolute faith in Beast King Gradim, they followed the order without hesitation.

The result: out of 30,000 members of the Demon Beast squad....

7,700 turned into berserk Demon Beasts, 5,800 into complete Demon Beasts.

4,500 turned into berserk Beastman, 7,400 into Demon Beastman soldiers.

550 turned into Chimera Knights.

It resulted in a fairly large loss in numbers.

The ones who went berserk had already been let out, and were rampaging on the decks. An ejection type magic circle was prepared beforehand, to deal with those individuals.

That was the job of the Mages, who were standing by around the squad members. This was to prevent being attacked by their former comrades.

Those who were still sane and combat ready numbered 13,750, which was less than half of the squad.

The members who turned into Demon Beasts but were still conscious are also counted in, so the drop in numbers was fairly significant.

But Gradim nodded with satisfaction.

The number of Chimaera Knights born was higher than expected.

There was roughly 100 of them who were his aides already.

Through strict selection, only individuals with high chances of successfully fusing were chosen, but it was difficult to increase their numbers.

But because of the current emergency, it was fortunate that 450 Chimaera Knights of good quality were born.

(We can win with this!)

Beast King Gradim was confident, and began reforming the ranks to prepare for battle.

—— grind them to dust!

The Black Numbers released their restraints in elation as they received their orders.

And were about to head straight for the Airships that had evacuated to the ocean.

The 100 airships still in the air, were to be food for their masters.

The remaining 200 or so that had descended to the ocean were their own.

The subordinates of the 3 pillars Testarossa, Ultima and Carrera numbered 600 in total. All of them were beings that easily surpassed Greater Demons.

They were all over A rank, beings who could rival high tier Majin (EN: note at the end).

They now eyed their pitiful prey, with their powers now unconstrained.

But then,

「Wait!」

All of their movements stopped, with that one word from Diablo.

Now their attention was on Diablo.

Diablo raised one of his hands, signalling to the demons to be at ease,

「Kufufufufu. Do all of you understand?

The order from Rimuru-sama, is that none are allowed to die.

If even one of you were to die, it would be a sin so grave that even if us executives offered our heads to atone, it wouldn't nearly be enough.」

His smile, instilled fear upon his underlings rather than it's original purpose.

And none refuted his words.

The demons quietly paid heed to Diablo's orders.

「First, Testarossa. Would you be so kind as to clean up the trash below us?」

「Oh, why not? That much is easy by myself.」

「Wait a sec! I wanna do that! I can do that much easily too, you know!?!」

Ultima barged in as Diablo was giving the order to Testarossa.

To that, with no displeasure, Diablo answers,

「Kufufufufu. Of course it is possible for you too.

But, since those are floating down there undamaged, shouldn't we try and capture them?

All of those ships, I am thinking of offering them to Rimuru-sama.

Ultima, aren't you bad at controlling your power output?

For that, Testarossa is the one most suited for this job.」

Unexpectedly, he explained his reasoning.

This showed Diablo was in an amazingly good mood.

If there was an interruption while his mood was foul, the life of whoever interrupted would speed towards zero.

Ultima, sounding satisfied,

「Che~. —— can't help that I guess. True, it isn't what I'm good at.」

She seems to have given up her selfish thoughts.

「Ufufu. Well then, I'll be of—— 」

「A moment. Take Venom with you.」

「Hm, what for?」

「We've been given the order to wipe them out. Have I not said?

None are allowed to escape.

We shall put the Demon Chevalier to use, for that purpose.」

「—— understood. They will be of use, as Bloodhounds. I shall borrow them.

Moss, you are next in terms of capability behind us 4 pillars.

As long as you heed the order to not die, you can do as you please.

Cien, you shall take control of the remainder, and sweep up any who intend to escape!」

Testarossa gave out the orders for her minions, and swiftly took action towards her prey.

Venom looked at Diablo, and looked like he wanted to say something for a split second, but only gave a bow seeming like he had given up, and left following behind Testarossa.

「So, are you going to go after the Emperor, Diablo?」

「No, that unfortunately looks impossible.」

「Hmm? Why's that?」

Unexpectedly, Carrera replied with interest to what Diablo just said.

Carrera was known to show no interest, and totally ignore anything others said.

「Kufufufufu. The Emperor, has an Absolute Barrier.」

Just as he was saying that, Diablo suddenly shot out a Nuclear Cannon.

The ultra-long-distance blast Nuclear Cannon, maintaining speeds at over 10 times the speed of sound, pierced the defense

barriers of the Airship.

And without losing any momentum, made direct contact with the Emperor.

But, the Emperor was uninjured. The Knights protecting the emperor didn't even move, as if they knew the result.

「Did you see that? The Royal Knights protecting the emperor didn't even move.

That shows they have confidence that the defense field will not be penetrated.

It would seem that the Emperor wields an Ultimate Skill.

One of the “Angel Series”.

The “Angel Series” is known to have high defensive

properties, the defenses that the Emperor has are probably the highest of them all.

Analysis showed it to be “Castle Guard”.

Using the “loyalty” of the subordinates around him as energy, he is invincible as long as he has loyal retainers nearby.

To put it simply, if we do not clean out the Imperial soldiers, we have no means to kill the emperor.」

「Hmmm. Surprising you could tell that much.」(Ultima)

「Color me impressed as well. There was no way to tell, just from looking at them.」(Carrera)

「Kufufufufu. That much was obvious (with the help of a certain someone)!」

Bragged Diablo, while the other two looked at him dubiously.

Clearing his throat to divert their attention, Diablo pushed to finish the conversation.

「Well that's the gist of it, I would like for you all to clear out the flies around the Emperor.

Carrera, you take the man in uniform.

Ultima, you deal with any remaining distinct individuals.

All other remaining demon nobles besides Moss and Cien are to support Ultima!」

『As you wish!!』

Accepting their orders, the demons flew off.

But right before Ultima and Carrera took off,

「Huh? What are you going to do, Diablo?」

Ultima asked, having finally noticed.

Diablo looked like he shuddered.

But calmly,

「I have something important to do.」

said Diablo.

The two felt even more suspicious now.

「Wait a minute, Diablo. What are you being so secretive about?」

He reluctantly answers Carrera,

「My role is to watch over our majestic Rimuru-sama!

This is a role so important, that it isn't something I could task others with!!」

He declared in a fit.

「Wa-wait a sec! What's with that?

I wanna see Rimuru-sama's greatness too!!」(Ultima)

「Huh? Are you gonna hog all that fun for yourself?

Even if you're our superior, that's power abuse you know?」
(Carrera)

The two Devil Lords voiced their objections.

But at the same time, they now understood why he so quickly dispatched the haughty Testarossa.

Diablo was their direct superior, if all three of them were together they could have “appealed”, but there was only two of them now so the odds are not in their favor.

In the end they could only accept it, all the while griping about it.

「Hey! I can do whatever the hell I want right?」(Ultima)

「Yes, of course.」(Diablo)

「I can destroy everything that's floating in the sky right?」

「Definitely.」

Diablo was conceding as much as possible, to improve the moods of Ultima and Carrera.

Them being this easy to convince was quite a bargain.

「Alright then. There seems to be some who look very tasty, so I shall give in this time.」(Carrera)

「Yep. I want to rampage around too, to vent off some of this frustration.」(Ultima)

Sounding like they conceded, the two of them flew off.

They also gave orders to the remaining demons who were standing by around them, as though an afterthought,

「You guys, spread out!

Get under Cien's command, and show no mercy to anyone

who tries to leave this airspace!!」

Carrera shrieked ventingly, and the demons moved out in unison.

—— grind them to dust!

Intending to follow their orders to the letter, the demons set up a full perimeter surrounding the Imperial fleet.

Soon, the decisive battles in the air, and on sea level would begin.

Diablo smirked, pleased that everything was going just as planned.

Through observing his beloved master's battle nearby, he would improve himself.

And with this battle, to give the remaining demons the opportunity to experience battle in the truest sense, that was the main objective.

Surviving the odds, and attaining strength.

The abilities of their corporeal bodies, were the best they could hope to attain.

What remained, would be the skills within those bodies.

This applied to Testarossa, Ultima and Carrera too.

Power that was simply given to them, could never compare to the shine of one that was mastered, obtained by themselves.

Providing them with an “enemy”, and having them break through that obstacle.

Demons were one of the most powerful races.

While they were weak in their inferior stages when compared to Angels and Spirits, that position was switched the moment they reach the upper classes.

As growth is slow, many would fall and perish in the process, but those who managed to reach the higher tiers would become unchallenged.

That was why, the brute force approach of the Devil Lords besides himself, was all too understandable.

It will be good experience for them to be thrown into a tough battle.

(Now, for them to survive the ordeal. Hopefully they make it out in one piece. Kufufufufufufu——)

Diablo's smile widened, as he snickered in anticipation.

Chapter 178: The Black Numbers Vs The Empire -First Half-

There existed within the Beast Corps, those that excelled in aerial combat.

However, that was only possible provided stable foothold.

For the Demonic Beasts who were inferior in continuous flight ability, combat in the skies put them at a disadvantage. After all, their landing spots were easily predictable, they would be sniped, and that would be the end of them.

In spite of that, the 7,700 Berserk Demonic Beast, and the 4,500 berserk Beastman all faced themselves towards the sky.

Up until now they weren't able to recognize friend from foe, and simply attacked each other——

They had been ejected out at the surface deck of the 200 Airships, a spot you could hardly call spacious.

It wasn't narrow, but nor was it wide enough to move freely around in.

That was why, they had followed their instincts and began to show off their strength.

——but, all turned towards the skies.

The reason was simple and clear.

Their instincts flared, something like the fundamental root of terror, a “Danger”, they noticed it coming closer.

Testarossa simply scowled at them with an uninterested look.

What she witnessed was a group of idiots thrashing about aboard the Airship she planned to present to Demon Lord Rimuru.

Then, she was fed up with the group of visibly insane beasts flying towards her.

(Ah? So gross. If I don't clean this up soon, I'll be covered in filth.

And.....despite being beasts, to misjudge bravery for such suicidal stupidity, how foolish.

But then——If you've gone mad, I guess it can't be helped.

At the very least, accept my merciful blessing!)

Thinking so, with neither hesitation nor inaccuracy she released “Death Streak” at a location where the Airships were densely packed.

All Airships within the range of a perfect sphere were stricken with death.

The “Death Ray” also affected the oceans, and all exposed sea life perished.

「Can't you hold back a little!? We can't get a turn this way can we? 」

Venom asked Testarossa bewildered,

「You're still no good.

Please take a good look. There are some survivors see?」

She said, ridiculing the shallowness of Venom's experience.

Testarossa's 『Magic Perception』 had certainly grasped the presence of several survivors.

Demonic Beasts held the properties of both monster and beast, the flesh they were bound to was a big factor. In other

words, they couldn't endure "Death Streak".

Even if they were to take on a demonic beast's strength with a human base, in the end, the flesh it was bound to would be destroyed by the "Death Ray".

In other words, those who survived under the effects of this spell were either Spirit Forms, or those who had perfect compatibility with demonic elements.

No, they could perhaps also be Sages who had acquired perfect control over their bodies.

In any case, only those who had surpassed a certain threshold could endure it.

「Survivors, is it? Interesting, it looks like we too can have some fun.」

Venom's eyes thinned as he grinned, and he transferred over to his subordinates who were poised for combat.

One could say that Beast King Gradim, on that very moment, had understood the true meaning of terror and danger.

In the middle of organizing his formation, his subordinates started spewing blood as they began to fall.

The survivors numbered less than 100.

To begin with, Gradim's subordinates were only composed of his countrymen who had been fighting alongside him for several decades.

This time, those who had successfully evolved into a Chimera Knight, due the shortage of Demonic Beasts to consume, had been terribly weakened.

They obtained the Unique skill 『Bodily Manipulation』 , and without ever being to use it, had passed on.

Since it was at a level where even a Chimera knight would die, it was unnecessary to inquire what happened to the others.

Enraged, mortified, and terrified.

Those emotions stirred in Gradim's heart.

With a single spell cast, and the majority of his forces had been lost.

It was an spell so almighty that Magic Barriers were pointless before it.

To begin with, the elite Mages had been transferred over to the Airships high above, and thus this blunder caused the defensive barriers of the 200 airships at sea level to weaken.

In other words, this was Gradim's blunder.

If the enemy was a high-class Demon, it was necessary to assume they would use wide scale attack magic.

In any case, even though the use of such a powerful spell was beyond expectations, the number of survivors was above what was expected.

「You'll pay, you Daemons!!」

The Beast King roared, and a God-tier armament wrapped around his body with the power of a Demonic Beast housed within.

Different from a beastman tribe, it was an ability that was uniformly enhanced to specialize in combat, and Gradim's body began to change.

Roaring in synchrony, his subordinates the 100 Chimera Knights each released their powers.

Then, the upper hatch of the ship opened, and they leapt out onto the deck.

Thus, the Demon and the Beast king clashed.

Looking down from above was “Killer Lord” Testarossa, facing, confronting, and accepting the stare of “Beast King” Gradim who glared at her from the upper deck.

Behind Testarossa were 100 Demon Chevaliers, and similarly, Gradim had 100 of his subordinates, the Chimera Knights.

The (seemingly) rivalling forces, awaiting the final showdown.

「Rejoice, Venom! It's your turn. I'll be enjoying this meal.

As for your lackeys, it's perfect, there's one for each of you.

You will be killing those who attempt to escape from this airspace

After that, that's right...

Abide to Rimuru-sama's words, and make sure that not one of you gets killed.

「Who do you think my comrades are? We're not that stupid.....」

(Yeah, you tell 'er boss!)

They wanted to agree with Venom's words, but Testarossa was scary and the Demon Chevaliers only muttered in a low voice.

Shutting up the idiots with her glare, Testarossa narrowed her eyes.

「Silence you fools! If even one of us gets killed, we're all done for. If you understand, then scram! 」

Eh, wasn't I in charge? Ignoring Venom who wanted to say this, under Testarossa's command the Demon Chevaliers began making their move.

Following them, Testarossa, as well as Gradim.

They changed location another ship deck, and began their confrontation.

「I am Imperial army Beast Corps General, “Beast King” Gradim! 」

「I am Demon Lord Rimuru-sama’s lowly and faithful servant, “Killer Lord” Testarossa」

To Gradim’s battle cry, Testarossa replied gracefully.

And so, the match began, and then ended in an instant.

「Die, you filthy Demon!! Ultimate Gift 『Alternative』 Activate!

Take this, the Beast King’s Rage!!

Beast King——」

「Shut it. Your attack name is too long. 」

Beast King Gradim's body, clad in a shining god class armor, was unable to resist the Black Greatsword 'Death Blade' Testarossa wielded, and was sliced to ribbons.

It was a sword of death, formed by condensed black flames that became the key to activate "Death Streak".

The annihilation effect of the Ultimate Skill Testarossa obtained as soon as she ascended 『Hell King Berial』 granted an instant death.

The 『Hell King Berial』 was similar to Ruminas's Skill, both governing "Life and Death". However in contrast, it was more focused on the "Death" aspect. Based off of that, it could be considered inferior to Ruminas's Ultimate Skill 『Lustful King Asmodeus』, but if one were to only consider combat potential, then there was no inferiority to point out——

Even if a fatal blow were avoided, Testarossa wasn't serious at all.

she swung her sword merely with the intention to shut him up, and yet it ended up dealing a deadly blow.....

In any case, as for Beast King Gradim, his opponent was simply too strong.

If this happened before her Demon Lord Ascension, it would definitely have been a slightly better fight, but the ascended Testarossa was one of the strongest in Tempest.

But against a certain red haired demon, she still had nothing.

「Gu, wa..... ri, ridiculous..... y-you're too strong. But, my subordinates, t-they'll..... 」

Gradim uttered with the last of his strength, however his hopes had already been shattered.

Not a single one of his men were able to triumph against the Demon Chevaliers, and had been defeated.

It was a reasonably well fought battle, but in the end they only ended up as experience points for the demons.

「.....How,how could this. Y-your majesty, my apologi.....」

And so, an elite, even by the Empire's standards, Beast King Gradim faced a sorrowful end.

And thus, the Beast Corps was annihilated, and wiped off the face of the earth.

Making a quick glance with 『Magic Perception』 to make sure there were no signs of life, Testarossa took off from the vessel.

Even though she deemed it unnecessary, she headed off to assist the others.

The Demon Chevaliers followed behind her.

「A～a.....As expected, I didn't get a turn.....」

Venom complained, but nobody was there anymore.

.....

.....

...

After Testarossa had gone, a single man walked out of the flagship.

He surveilled the sky, after confirming the Demons have left,

「Oh boy. Even someone as awesome as me can't win against a

monster like that ...yet.

But yeah, perfect timing.

I wanted to kill Gradim, but it looks like he's been cooked already; I'll dig in then.」

And so, he greedily guzzled the cleanly halved corpse of Gradim.

Crunch, crunch, he ate.

Energy began pouring into his body, as great power amassed.

「Fumu. It was so-so. But that's hardly enough.

I guess I can only stay silent for now.....」

He murmured, holding the torn-up God-tier armor Gradim once wore in his hand, and poured energy in.

The armor flickered as if acknowledging the man as new master, and began repairing itself good as new.

The man clad the armor onto himself with a natural look on his face.

His body was completely covered, a helmet hid his face concealing his identity.

The man nodded and left the scene, heading towards the transfer magic formation within the ship.

Ultima and Carrera, as per Diablo's instruction headed towards the Emperor.

Either way, there's was a need to clean up some fussy garbage.

In order to vent out the frustration of being unable to witness their beloved master in action, they needed clear out the trash.

If you examined them, each Airship had a defensive barrier shrouding it.

Various barriers formed a multiple-layered defense system, and even Nuclear Magics proved mostly useless.

Just as Diablo had previously shown, if you concentrated the spell, it was possible to destroy a part of the barrier but.....

That's a hassle, was the common understanding that Ultima and Carrera had reached.

Well, the main battle forces seemed to be gathered on the flagship of the emperor.

That being the case, they would simply strike there first.

7 Demon Dukes in total.

Diablo's lieutenant, Earl class Venom.

Testarossa's lieutenants, Duke class Moss and Baron class Cien

Ultima's lieutenants, Marquis class Veyron and Baron class Zonda

Carrera's lieutenants, Viscount class Agera and Esprit.

Each of them held great strength, they were beings that could even be called Kings of the underworld.

However even so, the differences in class reflected the differences in strength.

In this military operation, the supreme command forbade even one death, thus they couldn't afford to be careless.

Therefore,

「Zonda, you go eliminate everyone else other than the flagship.

If possible, join up with Moss and support him!

I don't detect anyone that strong, but don't be careless okay? 」

「Certainly, Ultima-sama! This Zonda will take swift action in accordance to your command.」

Ultima handed down the extermination order to Zonda.

600 Greater Demons spread out into the surroundings, creating a barrier to stop any escapees.

As a result, it became difficult to escape from a battle in the skies.

Ultima also had the ulterior motive of quickly eliminating the enemy and go witness the splendor of her master alongside Diablo.

While she was worried about Zonda, her personal interests took priority.

That defined Ultima.

Thus they moved on to the cleaning up of small fry. In order to bring down their respective prey, they invaded the upper deck of the flagship where the Emperor was.

And so the two sides faced each other.

“Pain Lord” Ultima and “Menace Lord” Carrera.

As well as Veyron, Agera and Esperit.

Facing them on the Empire's side, Emperor Rudra.

The 10 strongest of the Royal Knights, the Imperial Guardian No.1~10, led by First Lieutenant Kondo.

The decisive battle was about to unfold.

Emperor Rudra was protected in an Absolute Barrier.

Its defenses were absolute, nobody could possibly destroy it.

However, there are conditions.

Its energy for its use originated from the loyalty of those around the Emperor, a loyal subordinate had to be within the vicinity of the Emperor.

And then the other condition.

This defense was a continuously active perfect barrier, however during activation all forms of attacks and actions were forbidden.

This ability is the Ultimate Skill 『Justice King Michael』's "Castle Guard".

That It was the main reason why Guy didn't directly aim for the Emperor was an established fact.

Of course, that's also the reason he had turned into a husk after several millennia but.....

Therefore, the Emperor didn't move.

The moment he started taking aggressive action would also signify the disappearance of the absolute defense.

「You insects..... Do not you interfere with the realization of my ambitions!

Royal Knights, eliminate these miscreants! 」

The Emperor gave his imperial decree.

『By your will!!』

The Emperor's loyal knights promptly began taking action to execute the command.

Oh the other hand,

「Hey, Carrera. By insects, is he referring to us perchance?」

「Ahaha. There's no way right? But if he is.....」

Carrera denied Ultima's inquiry with a laugh.

However, her eyes weren't laughing.

It glinted with a dangerous light, that looked as if it could blow at any moment.

「The Emperor has decreed. Make short work of those nuisances (worms).」

Those words were the trigger.

「You're all fucking dead!!」

「worms? Did you just say worms!? Foolish human!! Kill you. I'll shatter that your very soul!!」

Ultima raged..

Carrera looked calm, but vowed never to forgive these enemies.

If mercy was to die a painless death, then unforgiveness was to waste away whilst suffering.

Either way, the fact they would be killed didn't change, but for these girls there was probably a difference.

The demons who followed them were trembling in fear from their aura.

「H-hey Agera. Isn't this getting dangerous for us too?」

「please give it up.

That aside, considering our master was insulted, I believe we should grant them a fitting punishment!」

「Urk! You're losing it too.」

Realizing she couldn't stop the usually calm Agera from unleashing her fury, Esprit sighed.

At this point it was impossible to stop them.

Giving up was, in all seriousness, the right answer.

Veyron looked at the exchange between the two viscounts, he looked carefree at the outside, but in his mind he was at his wits end.

His superiors, the Devil Lords, were existences that must never be angered at all cost.

(Foolish humans. The price you pay for your stupidity, are your “deaths”!)

The terror of his superiors was something Veyron was very familiar with.

And then, just as Veyron had anticipated, the Devil Lord pair, unleashed their horror.

Chapter 179: The Black Numbers Vs The Empire -Last Half-

In her fit of rage, Ultima summoned several of the Black Orbs.

With a sinister smile, she propelled the orbs towards each of the Royal Knights.

The uniformed man —— First Lieutenant Kondo —— sensed the danger from those orbs and,

「Brace yourselves! Those are Abyss Cores!」

Shouting out, he equipped his gun, and, destroyed one of the Abyss Cores using Dispel and Eraser bullets in rapid-fire.

He would have shot down the remaining Cores too but,

「Hello? Look, I'm your opponent!」

Carrera stopped Kondo's barrage by herself shooting a full strength Energy Ball at him.

Kondo drew back his gun, and attempted to repel the Energy Ball while dodging.

A tremendous amount of Energy that was as if a manifestation of Carrera's rage. But the real feat was that of Kondo's, who had repelled it all while remaining stoic of face.

He was already analysing his opponent, planning to counter with a Dispel bullet, and if possible, Necrosis too.

But, now he had no room to look after anyone else, and as if being completely isolated with Carrera, their single combat had began.

Abyss Cores.

These were lumps of mana which could be called the essential components of magic.

Pumping them with ridiculous amounts of mana, a genuine death ray, the “Death Streak” would be made.

Releasing them as is would manifest “Nuclear Flame”.

And last but not least, the best usage was to use Mana Manipulation to alter the lumps into a compressed state.

This would result in the strongest magic, “Gravity Collapse”.

It was the essence of Nuclear Magic.

On a similar note, “Nuclear Cannon” was made by exploding a few Abyss Core inside a tubular Magic Barrier, and pointing that energy in some arbitrary direction.

It was easy to do, and was the easiest to control.

Therefore, even at sizes as small as a fists, the Royal Knights

clearly understood the power of a simple Abyss Core.

「I-impossible! How are there so many of these huge Abyss Cores!?!」

「If those things blew up, this whole place will be gone!!」

「The Mages' Barriers won't hold, all hands, eliminate those Cores!!」

And all of them made their moves.

If left as is, and multiple “Nuclear Flames” were blasted, their Emperor, should still be safe.

But the majority of the Airships in the sky would undoubtedly be destroyed by the explosion.

Not to mention, they couldn't allow such explosions near the

Emperor even if he were to be safe.

「What monstrosity!? To summon so many large Abyss Cores without any problem.....」

That was the honest impression of the Royal Knights.

The strongest among them had used their Holy Magic to counter balance, and successfully suppress the Abyss Cores.

But 5 of them were still desperately trying to suppress the mana overflow.

「Bzzt! Sorry, ti~me's up!!」

With an innocent delight.

Came Ultima's sinister announcement.

And at the same time, the Abyss Cores began their transformation.

Squirming Tentacles of Black Fire coiled around the desperate 5 Royal Knights.

This was the Magic Alteration ability of the Ultimate Skill attained by Ultima, 『Poison King Samael』.

The tentacles lined with poison would coil around and kill the target.

Meaning that, as they couldn't eliminate the Abyss Cores with their Holy Magic, resistance was futile.

As a result, they met no end other than death.

The Squirming Tentacles of Black Fire gradually covered up its prey, and engulfed them.

Fearing her end,

「H-help me, lieutenant Kondo!! 」

Knight No. 6, Minaza, desperately sought rescue from Kondo.

However, Kondo didn't have that liberty.

He had his hands full with Carrera, and simply couldn't spare the time to save his subordinates.

So without even facing her,

「I, can't.」

He spoke pragmatically.

「N-no way a——」

Before Minaza could even scream, it was over.

「"Limit End"! Ahahahaha!!

Now, we can go one-on-one!」

Ultima playfully laughed.

She held a Squirming Tentacle of Black Fire in her hand.

Like a Black Flame Whip.

And using that whip, she recovered the Energy from the Knights who just perished.

「Pretty tasty. You're happy to be of some use aren't you?」

She said while slurping up those short-lived feelings of fear

and hopelessness.

While shuddering, Damrada analysed the current situation.

He couldn't imagine that Kondo, their strongest, could have his hands full with a single Demon.

No, he should have been able to imagine it.

He knew about the peculiarity of Demon Lord Rimuru, so judging from the strength of Diablo who he had witnessed at the tournament, it wouldn't completely be out of the question.

Except, that he had taken those factors into consideration and concluded that the Empire was stronger.

At that time, he had believed that that was their full strength, and trusted that the status hadn't changed presently.....

That strength at the tournament was on par with the lower ranked Royal Knights.

They were honestly impressive.

However, they, the Knights, themselves possessed the Ultimate Gift 『Alternative』.

If one of the lower Knights weren't enough, they could team up.

(Did they grow stronger.....? No..... they weren't going all out at the tournament.)

Thinking that the Knights No. 6 ~ 10 would put up evenly with the ones called the Four Heavenly Kings was a complete mistake.

And now.

The cheerful female looking Demon in front of them seemed incomparably stronger than the Four Kings.

Even Arch Demons would be a laughing stock.

Surpassing even Demon Dukes, as if it was like a second coming of Guy • Crimson.....

Minaza had screamed, and then disappeared.

It was sad, but Damrada couldn't save her.

Of course the reason.....

Was that the girl named Ultima was clearly, he noticed, eyeing him.

The girl sneered,

「Heh, I guess this should be fun?」

Her sights set on the target, she began the assault.

And while confronting her, Damrada realized another truth.

(This Bitch..... did she just kill of the weaker one's to even out the numbers.....?)

Indeed.

As of now, the numbers were so that every one of the Demon Dukes could have a go.

You want to break our spirits with that power huh! Thought Damrada, forming his stance.

Very well, we'll be bringing it.

The power of the strongest knights, the Royal Knights.

Ultima observed the Knights wearing a thin smile.

She felt the depth of their strength.

She wouldn't be so sure of victory if she hadn't ascended.

But, after attaining the Ultimate Skill 『Poison King Samael』 ,
losing didn't seem like a concept anymore.

And then,

(Dammit, that Diablo. Making us train with these battles.....

Underestimating much?

If Testa realized this, she'd be flipping out.

Well, it's a good chance..... I guess it's fine to train the underlings.)

She understood Diablo's intentions and decided to act accordingly.

Out of the 10 Royal Knights at the start, only half remained.

The Demons would all find a partner to test their mettle in battle.

To become so strong after gaining control over her power, Ultima never thought it possible.

She had hoped the Royal Knights would be stronger, but they almost weren't utilising the Ultimate Skill granted to them at all.

Those weaklings couldn't even handle her simple Abyss Cores.

They were individuals who had attained great Energy (life force), and wielded a shared Ultimate Skill.

She had expected more of them to survive.

She had playfully used her fire, aiming to kill at most a couple..... but as a result, finished off half.

Of course, the Demon Dukes, who didn't have Ultimate Skills, wouldn't have it so easy against the Royal Knights.

Nevertheless, their base stats being much higher, they shouldn't have too much trouble.

Though, It'd be bad if they did.

If the underlings got killed, she wouldn't have the gall to face their lord, Rimuru-sama.

But the experience gained from this fight would surely bolster their prospects.

Just like Ultima, who had personally experienced Guy's might.....

Only by tasting Guy's fearsome attack overlapped with Ultimate Skills did she truly desire one such Skill for herself.

A simple attack.

Her pre-ascended self couldn't even overcome such a playful, whimsical, non-serious magic.

Humiliation.

Bearing a title of high Nobility among the strongest of Demons, she couldn't even make use of her specialty of magic resistance.

But, she also considered it good luck.

She got to have such an experience only because she was Demon Lord Rimuru's subordinate.

Not just that, she was also blessed with ascension.

Ultima felt that she couldn't even hope for more.

Demons, as opposed to humans, were much higher beings.

Just releasing their intense mana was enough to be considered an attack.

As a result, perfecting their control raised them to even greater heights.

Seeing the way her playful Abyss Cores dominated the Royal Knights, Ultima confirmed exactly where the difference in

power lied.

In the end, the base Spiritual (Holy) Power in humans wasn't much.

In other words, they wouldn't be able to increase their base power no matter how perfect the control was.

And then, I see, she thought.

Why Diablo absolutely loathed relying on raw power.

(It's true that we Demons have high Energy potential. So we tend to rely on that power too much huh.)

She acknowledged.

Excluding Testarossa, Carrera and herself indeed indulged in that bad habit.

She also knew that she was the most inexperienced among the three.

Testarossa was elegant and flawless.

She had the bad habit of looking down on others though.

Carrera was haughty and aloof.

She could do anything if she only tried, but always opted for lazier options.

But herself.....

Evermore inexperienced.

She had neither Testarossa's precision, nor Carrera's abundance.

She, Ultima, was the weakest of the 4 pillars of Devil Lords.

Still.....

(I want to be number 1!)

—— Don't bask in the power you haven't attained yourself
——

She reminded herself of those words from Diablo.

That was the reason why, except when in dire situations, Diablo never made use of the power granted to him by his Demon Lord.

Therefore, she too.

Using this opportunity, she would prove herself by mastering her own Ultimate Skill 『Poison King Samael』.

Ultima swore in her heart.

Not the “power” she had never wished for, but the “Skill” she earnestly desired; she would perfect it.

And now.

She was impressed with Damrada who, utilizing Holy Energy to his utmost, the man had overcome the force of her overwhelming attack.

Ultima honestly found it interesting.

Although it seemed like she was in control, she had been actually simply brute-forcing her way with immense mana.

She already understood the fact, but now, had finally, truly recognized it.

So, being able to enjoy her fight, both took their best stance, and initiated fierce combat.

Carrera's knees hit the earth.

The male human named Kondo was unbelievably strong.

A true master.

Carrera, boasting strength second only to Diablo among the 4 Devil Lords, couldn't but be amazed at the reality of the man before her.

There was no anger.

She knew that underestimating him would only leave her on the floor.....

He was not easy prey.

He would seal (curse) off her magic before it could be used.

Reading the flow of mana required to activate the magic, he would precisely cut off the current.

With the bizarre bullets from the gun in his hand.

Unbeknownst to Carrera, this gun was a God-tier weapon.

At the basest level, it was a gun shaped blunt weapon.

It was cylindrical in shape, and could withstand intensive explosions.

In short, there was no actual firing mechanism.

Kondo would use his Skills to first create a mana explosion, and further, materialize and eject a bullet.

That bullet was created by overlapping his Skills with the “Divine Edge” ability of Ultimate Skill 『Sandalphon the Executioner』.

Kondo would mould the “Divine Edge” into the shape of a bullet, and then coat it with the effects of the Skill before firing.

In a pinch, he could load the gun with a blade, but he had yet to be in such a situation.

Finding the enemy’s weakness, or flow of mana, and precisely striking them down.

Just that.

With unyielding fealty, Kondo had secured his position among the highest in the Empire.

Carrera jittered in the humiliation called reality.

The reality that, she couldn't win like this.

With that mindset,

「FUCKING HUMA~N!!」

She cried, then hit her face with the back of her hand.

Her face received Energy so massive, it was as if her head would blow right off.

But that was fine.

Enough looking down on the enemy.

This was, she acknowledged, a suitable foe. She was no longer the aloof Carrera, but took on an earnestly serious attitude.

After all, she was acting under Demon Lord Rimuru's direct orders.

Unlike the past, she could not allow herself to be selfish.....

「Was that too scary?

My apologies, I needed to cool off a little.

I was making light of you, or rather, humans in general, and ended up holding back you see.

Who knew.

Who could possibly know that I.....

Would actually, truly, seriously face off against a human.」

And she gently rose.

And at that, Kondo, for the first time, changed his expression.

「Oh, so you were hiding that much.....

Very well.

I too shall face you in earnest.」

After having spoken, for the first time, Kondo donned his “Armour”.

Materialized though will power, it was his Former Imperial Army Official Uniform.

It symbolized, for First Lieutenant Kondo, his battledress, and furthermore, this Uniform was a God-tiered armour.

Carrera stood, and released her rich mana.

And,

「Loyal Servant of Demon Lord Rimuru-sama, I am Carrera, “Menace Lord”. In the name of the “Menace Lord”, I vow to kill you.」

She declared.

「Former Imperial Army First Lieutenant, Kondo Tatsuya.

Presently acting as leader of the Emperor’s personal Knights.

I shall rise to that challenge.」

Responded Kondo.

The two sized each other up, and released their power.

Carrera, at the precise moment, awakened to the power manifesting as a result of her determination — Ultimate Skill 『Extinction King Abaddon』 — and grasped for it.

Until now, she had been fighting solely with her seemingly absolute demonic power.

However, that was not enough.

She would never reach the ones called Ultimates.

Whether it be Diablo, or this Kondo fellow. To say nothing of Guy • Crimson, or the Demon Lord brass.

It was not enough to only think of increasing her strength.

If that was the case, just like her defeat against Guy's magic,

she would end up only as fodder for the strong no matter how much she struggled.

This, she would absolutely never allow.

She had always felt a raging power inside her, but finally, she decided to appreciate it.

She would not just control, but liberate it.

—— Mine “Power”, I shall name thee. Becometh mine “Skill (Abaddon)”, and be liberated from thine shackles!!——

And she attained it.

Leaving nothing behind, the absolute “Power”.

—— Ultimate Skill 『Extinction King Abaddon』 ——

This was the fearsome Skill, that, symbolizing Carrera's strength, would bring nothing but annihilation unto any hostiles.

Meeting such a formidable foe sparked in her, for the first time, a deep desire for power.

Facing Kondo, one she desired to kill more than Guy, Carrera focused.

It was at that moment.

An intense flash followed by an immense surge assaulted the Imperial Aerial Fighter Legion.

Rimuru had fired his "Veldora Sword".

The Airships' crews were in a panic.

The Emperor, who was, until now. under the safety of “Castle Guard”, and was focusing on controlling Veldora,

「No way, why?

Why, did the effect of my Regalia Dominion.... my “Sovereign Rule” disappear?

Why, was Veldora defeated?!

Impossible, that’s just impossible!

It was just a lowly Demon Lord, a puny slime!

It should have become powerless, after the source of its powers, Veldora, was taken away....

How, could it consume it’s master, and take that power for itself!!

I was this close to finally achieving victory against Guy!!

To get in the way of my plans.... Unforgivable, you lowly Demon Lord!!」

Shouted out and stood up.

The situation thus further intensified, and shifted into gear.

Chapter 180: Duel on Deck

There were two types of reactions, from those who had heard Emperor Rudra's outburst.

Some were bewildered, while others became enraged.

At the same time as the Imperial army was falling into chaos due to the attack from the Veldora Sword, the battles between the Royal Knights and the demons were also reaching their respective climaxes.

Agera put a hand on the katana on his waist, and cautiously observed her opponent.

She had been on the defensive, never once taking the initiative.

Even if she was furious at the fact his master(Carrera) had been ridiculed, that was a separate matter unrelated to her present battle. That was why she approached her opponent with caution, slowly accumulating damage, and observing her

opponent.

「Hah! What cowardice. All that talk about demons and being above us, utter hogwash; you aren't a match for us, the strongest Knights.

We are before his majesty, the Emperor, and I shall defeat you henceforth.

I shall also wager that your master is far weaker than Kondodono. And you can continue to serve her in hell!」

「Hmph. Words are cheap, you can talk after you've won.

I'm a fairly patient person, while you look to be a hasty one.

Well, Carrera-sama is also the type who has a short fuse, and needs someone to watch over her.」

「Me, hasty? Have you still not felt the difference in our abilities?

That childish looking demon with the purplish ponytail is indeed strong.

But, you are simply garbage! Just give up and die already!」

Showering insults in the midst of clashing blades, was Royal Knight No. 5 Garcia.

A large build overflowing with chakra. And with the effect of ultimate gift 『Alternative』 , “Conquerer of the Hunt”——turning the will to hunt into power——, he hunted down evil existences.

It had a direct effect on his body, creating a sturdy physique.

Plus the protection from his Legend grade armor, he needed not worry about recoil from his own power.

Utilising high level abilities, Garcia, while taunting his opponent, was not being careless.

Demon nobility were threats on a similar level to a Demon Lord. They were not foes to be taken lightly.

But, his taunts bore no fruit. As Spirit Forms, the strength of demons were strongly influenced by their emotions.

He was hoping to create an opening by taunting his opponent, but it didn't seem to work.

「You are indeed vulgar in addition to being hasty.

I do not think all humans are inferior.

But, then.

Souls have their own distinction. No matter what they do to

hide it, a person who has a vulgar soul is unable to hide the fact.」

Garcia was falling for the opponent's taunts instead.

And for the next few exchanges, Agera did not unsheathe her blade, and, while observing Garcia, avoided attacks with a combination of magic and minimal movements.

As long as she didn't take any fatal injuries, Agera would not be defeated.

There was no sign of her current injuries starting to heal. This was most likely caused by the effect of Garcia's Ultimate Skill.

But Agera was a Spirit Form, there were many ways to recover after the battle.

Understanding the difference in abilities, she vividly felt her lack of ability to effectively deal with an opponent who wielded an Ultimate Skill.

But, she knew that her base capabilities vastly overpowered his.

That being the case, like her prey, if she could only grasp the essence of and focus her power.....

And then, hearing Emperor Rudra's outburst, the situation shifted.

「His Majesty has declared his intentions. I'm afraid you all, including your master, must die now!」

Hearing those words from Garcia, something snapped in Agera's head.

(To lower our god, Rimuru-sama..... To the level of a simple demon!?!)

Even stating that we..... must die!?)

Fury.

Agera drew her blade with a naturally flowing movement.

Battoujutsu——Yaezakura——Hakkasen. (EN: Sword Art ——
Double Cherry —— Eight Petal Flash)

「Ha?eh?」

Garcia couldn't see it, nor could he understand.

What in the world, just happened.

While purely on defense——plus, taking damage——his prey,
with him was unable to compute, had counterattacked.

He died before he had the chance to, so it couldn't be helped.

The source of his self-confidence, the “Armor” which had the effects of an Ultimate Skill, was sliced through as though it was paper-thin, there was no way he could have understood.

And he was cut 8 times in a single moment, and lost his life before he had the chance to think about what just happened.

Agera resheathed her blade,

「No bushi (warrior/samurai) would sit idly listening to her master(Rimuru) get insulted, fool!

But, then again. My role is more of a retainer for my master(Carrera).

To think I would be that agitated by the words of such small fry.....I have much to learn.....」

She mumbled.

Agera grasped the intricacies of her skill at that point.

Her Unique Skill 『Perciever』 observed the enemy, and lets her understand the effective ways to use her strength.

Then she recollected.

Of whence, his single ultimate attack, reached the pinnacle of strength.

Of whence, his lived as a human being, along with his “katana (soul)”.

Up till this point Agera, who had been depending on his magic, now understood why she took on the form of a bushi.

In the distant past, before he reincarnated to this world as a Demon, he was once a samurai, she recalled.

「It may be possible that I was a son of man (human) once, on some other world.」

With such fleeting thoughts, she comes back to reality.

All interest was lost on the garbage that she just killed.

Agera turns her heels, and headed towards the subject of her loyalty, Carrera.

Espirit was injured all over, and her face showed her composure was fading away.

But, after hearing what the Emperor said, it contorted in anger.

Espirit was usually half-hearted, and mostly a hedonist.

While she usually only paid heed to Carrera's will, the fact

that Demon Lord Rimuru, who she worshipped as a god, was insulted, simply couldn't be tolerated.

「Ahh— What a pain! That's it, time for you to die!!」

「Hahaha, keep the nonsense to yourself. Those are not words for someone who has only been pathetically running around!」

Said Royal Knight No. 4 Gardner, mocking Espirit's determination.

Holding the overwhelming advantage, it looked like there was no way he could lose.

Indeed, that was what it looked like.

Victory would be surely his if he went for the kill now.

But, he was fond of rubbing salt into the wounds of the weak.

His greatest pleasure was hearing the screams of the “strong”.

That was why, against a strong being that was a Demon Noble like Esprit, who was also a beautiful female, he was holding back to see if he had the chance to hear what he desired.

He would kill her the moment Esprit begged for her life.

That twisted fetish of his, now became his downfall.

「This much should be enough. Echo-reflection!!」

The special ability to replicate damage that she has taken onto her attacker, such was Esprit’s unique skill 『Retaliator』 .

The incredible amount of damage that had been caused onto a demon’s body.

A human’s body would never be able to take that much

punishment.

Flesh was sundered and bones were crushed.

The moment Espirit activated her special ability, Gardner was turned into a pile of meat without the chance to even speak.

「That was close.

If I didn't have this power, I would have been the one who was defeated.

Never underestimate the opponent! That was the lesson huh....

In order to teach us, did he..... purposefully pit us against opponents who would have the upper hand.....?

No way, I not buying it..... Even if this is Rimuru-sama we are

talking about.....」

Espirit felt a chill down her spine, while she was pondering over the matter.

Death is forbidden! This order, pretty much meant to attain the strength to “survive”.

「To defeat an opponent who is stronger than my current self, I have definitely become stronger.....」

Demons, being Spirit Forms, their emotions bring change to their strength.

It wasn't common, but to confront an opponent who had the upper hand, only to easily throw in the towel and end up in defeat was the usual case.

To implant the will to never give up, into the hearts of demons.....

Her heart began to fill with elation and admiration, but that was suppressed and she began to take action once more.

To make rid of those who insulted her master.

Veyron was second in terms of capability, among the 7 pillars of the Demon Nobles.

But despite that, he was unable to reach the warrior before him, tasting the humiliation, and the ground.

Royal Knight No. 3 Graneet, was a Hero.

He was one of the people who had laid the foundations of the Empire, and helped usher forth a millennia of peace.

Known by the title of “God of War” Graneet, he had retired from his public position and was now one of Emperor Rudra’s most trusted retainers.

His unmatched skill in spear techniques was like a form of art; to Veyron who was a demon, it looked as though he was trying to receive meteors flying towards him.

In addition, he was properly using Alternative, and had full control over his Energy.

The difference in their capabilities was like heaven and earth.

The only silver lining, would be that any of the others would have been defeated instantly.

Veyron took his stance, with the newly created spear via Matter Creation, as the one he was just using shattered in his hands.

「Hear Daemon, the result will be the same no matter how many times we do this. You will never grasp victory with your mimicry.)

Avoiding fatal wounds and clinging onto life so dearly, staying

hidden away from the beginning would have worked better.」

「My, how harsh. But, my role is to be the wall that shields the princess.

If there is no one to keep you in check now, even my lady would have a hard time with you.」

Veyron was Ultima's butler.

Being together for the longest time, he has always been there to take care of her.

Even now, he was suppressing this dangerous man, preventing him from causing unneeded problems.

And Veyron believed that his master(Ultima) would emerge victorious, so as long as he survived, they would be victorious.

However....

(As expected, this isn't fine at all. I would like to a comeback against him, if possible.....)

The magic he was depending on wasn't up to the task, so he lacked the means for a decisive move.

As he was totally overwhelmed in skill, avoiding fatal injuries was the best he could do.

Anyone else who didn't have Veyron's immense reserves of mana, would have long since been defeated.

The created spear in his hands, was the fourth already.

He understood he wasn't able to fully defend with only magic, so he had been using his last resort.

Copying his opponent's spear technique, with his unique skill 『Tracer』.

Being simply a copy, it won't bring him victory. Although he couldn't win, he was able to avoid fatal damage.

Sadly, he was unable to counterattack relying only on this ability.

Now then, what to do....

As he was thinking, a thunderous roar sounded; the emperor had stood up and had made his outburst.

Veyron's soul was boiling over in anger, but felt intense shame at the same time.

Despite his anger, he had no means to triumph over his adversary.

「His Majesty has given the orders.

It's time you stopped running, and prepare to meet your maker!」

The warrior Graneet, releasing the aura (haki) of his “God of War” days, proudly exclaimed.

Right after that,

「Hey boss, I just saw something super cool!」

His associate Zonda teleported over, while saying that.

「Zonda, what about your “job”?」

「Oh that, it's all good. Moss-sama told me that boss was in a pinch.

Also, I got to see something real amazing and thought of a great idea!」

If Veyron was the butler, Zonda was the page.

Although they were both demon nobles, the difference in class was apparent.

But, they both served the same master (Ultima), so they got along well.

Which was why, Veyron allowed Zonda to speak with him so casually.

「Oh...? That, is it something that can get me out of this “pinch”?」

To Veyron's repeated question,

「Sure it can!」

He answered confidently.

And,

「I shall show it to you now! This new ability of mine.

Unique Skill 『Change Weapon』 take that!!」

With his shout, his body began morphing into the form of a spear.

The highly condensed mana of a Demon Noble, all concentrated into the form of a polished spear.

It was only possible by Spirit Forms such as a demon.

(Heh, how's that? Veldora-sama became a weapon too!

I tried copying that. Boss' tendency to copy stuff rubbed off on me eh!)

Zonda's spoke casually, while sounding excited.

Why you little.....slacking off and watching Rimuru-sama's battle.... Thought Veyron, but this happened all the time so he mind too much.

And he turned the spear he created back into mana, and now grabbed ahold his new weapon, the transformed Zonda.

The crystallization of a demon's Energy.

Normally you would cloak yourself in mana for defense, but this spear uses all that mana and turns that into the form of a spear.

It was an incredibly dense amount of mana.

Graneet sensed the danger that spear posed, and his face twitched in response. And,

「I won't allow that!! Hagun・Gekishin Resshou!!」(EN: Anti-Army ・ Quaking Sweep)

He unleashed his killer move with all his might.

But, it was already too late.

With 『Demon Spear: Zonda 』 in his hands, Veyron directed all of his mana onto defense instead of offense.

Leaving the offense to Zonda, he decided to focus on defense.

With that, he managed to survive Graneet's finishing move.

Although he took great damage, he avoided death.

「Now then, it's our turn.」

Softly saying so, he perfectly traced of Hagun・Gekishin Resshou with his Unique Skill 『Tracer』 .

The body's movements, and strength in each movement.

Except, all of that using the physical abilities of a Demon, the difference was obvious.

Discarding thoughts of attacking, he became force itself. With that, unleashed the attack, filled with the great Energy of a Demonic Noble.

Although Graneet moved to intercept, as it was an attack he was very fluent at; he was unable to defend and ended up destroyed.

The overwhelming power of the attack, caused the destruction of Graneet's body almost instantly, and turned him to dust. And without losing momentum, it raced across the deck of the airship, and ended up destroying some of the airships nearby in it's wake.

Truly, it was a miniature version of the attack caused by the Veldora Sword.

「Good work, Zonda. This was first time you were actually of use.」

「Don't be so cold, Boss! I have always been of use.....」

It was the same old casual conversation.

At the same time, Veyron was mending the damage on his tailcoat along with the damage to himself.

And good as new in a matter of seconds.

This was where the real strength of Spirit Forms lied.

And so, the two of them, headed back to their master, Ultima.

Chapter 181: Towards the Final Stage

Sitting cross-legged, Moss had secured a position in the air overlooking the battle from above.

His size was smaller than usual, it looked like a child around that age of 10.

He achieved this by activating his Unique Skill 『Collector』 .

Its capability was highly versatile, and had practical application in almost every scenario.

It was often used to create miniscule clones of himself to spread calamity everywhere, its primary being the reaping of life.....

This time though, he stopped at only using it to monitor the situation within each individual Airship

However.....

(Good grief, looks like the strong ones are all concentrated at the flagship.....

How boring.

If it's like this, there isn't a single person we(I) can fight.

What's this? It appears my fellow Demon Nobles are in a challenging fight..... how enviable.

However, that Kondo's quite a bigshot.

To make Carrera-sama get serious, and yet still fighting on par with her.....)

He monitored every ongoing battle, recording them without negligence.

After all, what he was collecting was intelligence.

At the same time, he hadn't forgotten to transfer the collected intelligence over to Diablo.

Though he hadn't noticed that Diablo, acting as a relay point, was further sending that information to a certain someone.....

Zonda who was nearby a while ago, spectating the battle of their Demon Lord Rimuru, was informed of their colleague Veyron's struggle, and headed off to support him.

Witnessing Demon Lord Rimuru-sama's overwhelmingly powerful attack—— the "Veldora Sword" —— had left him brimming with excitement, and seemed to have awakened something in him, but it was likely a good thing to be of use to Veyron.

As he was thinking such things,

(Kufufufufu. Moss, we're progressing smoothly. What's the situation with the "Rat"?)

The message came from Diablo.

(No problems here.

It looks like it has been moving around several ships heading for their transfer devices, but it has failed to teleport outside.

Thanks to the Spatial Interference Barrier set up by the Greater Demons, teleportation is being successfully prevented.

Looks like Cien has done quite a fine job)

(All right. Having it darting around is quite a pain.

Anyways, he'll probably appear on the flagship reeled in by the bait(Emperor).

It appears several escape methods were thought out, but it's all pointless.

Kufufufufu. Destroy everything other than the flagship)

(Roger that. Now then, my clones shall——)

(Wait. After hearing those words of insult towards Rimuru-sama, your boss seems to be raging.

I think it's better if we left this to Testa. This would probably help her vent out some anger.)

(What?! Didn't you hear what I just said about the Emperor?

Before the "Rat" takes the bait(Emperor) we can't have the it killed.)

(Well, it'll probably be alright.

It's impossible for Testa to destroy that "Castle Guard".

However, I fear this may cause interference with surveillance of the “Rat”.

Please somehow calm her down, and help her regain her reason.)

(Wha? You mean me? What the heck, just unreasonable !!)

(Yes I mean you! Kufufufu. I’m leaving this to you then!)

(Ah, he hung up.

No matter how you look at it, it seems Diablo-sama’s no good at handling Testarossa-sama.....)

Thinking so at the back of his mind, Moss let out a big sigh.

Calm yet cruel.

Even so, he was still lenient towards the other Devil Lords.

However, towards Moss' master Testarossa, he seemed to actually act carefully.

Well, there isn't any reason in particular, maybe it's just Moss' imagination.

Changing his trail of thought with a "Good grief.", Moss contacted Testarossa.

He requested her to destroy all other Airships apart from the flagship.

(Leave it to me. Let's teach them what happens when they dare insult Rimuru-sama!)

Feeling the surge of her anger, Moss' face stiffened.

Wouldn't the "Rat" be accidentally grilled as well? He was worried for an instant, but even if that did happen, there were no problems.

He judged so, and began retrieving his clones.

Apart from a small number left at the transfer devices of each vessel, all the other clones were retrieved successfully.

At the same time, the battle on the decks had begun to reach their conclusions.

Zonda who had cheerfully headed off to offer his support, had helped Veyron by utilizing his ability to transform himself into a weapon.

(Right, as expected.)

Accepting the victory of his colleagues as the natural order of things, he returned to his own role of observing the "Rat".

Incidentally, the remaining small amount of clones were ordered to continually obstruct the Mages on board the ships to interfere with their Defence Magic.

There was probably no need for that, but weakening the multi-layered barriers even a bit would act as support for Testarossa.

Immediately after, the sound of a large explosion resounded. Around half of the remaining airships around the flagship——around 60 of them——had been raptured by a dragon of fire.

This was due to the exceedingly high temperature of the wide area magic——”Chain Prominence”.

The Airships whose defenses were weakened due to Moss’s interference couldn’t possibly resist, and were all burned to nothingness by the grand spell.

Thus, excluding the 200 captured airships, only the flagship, which carried the Emperor, was left in the air.

Moss had probed into the whereabouts of the “Rat”, confirming that it had transferred aboard the flagship.

At the same time, the teleportation magic formations of the captured Airships had all been erased by his clones.

All as per instructed.

As such, the battle plan had moved on to its final phase.

Ultima was purely enjoying her battle with Damrada.

Their strengths rivaling each other, a victor couldn't be easily determined.

Or so it seemed at first but.....

When it came to using magic, as a demon, she had complete mastery, enabling her to use it as she pleased.

However, when it came to acquired ability, in terms of proficiency, she lagged behind Damrada by several steps.

The quality of their mana was different, but when it came to the quantity of Energy, she should have had the overwhelming advantage.

And yet that Damrada, by focusing his attacks onto a single point, he had managed to offset all of Ultima's attacks.

That being the case, a multi-pronged attack was attempted, but then multiple simultaneous attacks, all with equal strength was initiated in retaliation, and Alternative had activated on all of them, offsetting the attacks once more.

His mastery was splendid, the very definition of model usage.

However, Damrada was aware of the fact he had been backed

into a corner.

Unwilling to show off his hand, every time he played a card, he clearly felt Ultima taking it in, and growing stronger.

(This is bad. At this rate I'll definitely be defeated.)

That was the harsh reality.

From a third party's point of view, they'd probably think their abilities are evenly matched.

However, as it was currently balanced, as one side continued to grow, the scales would begin to tilt.

and then,

「Aha, I'm starting to get it now! 」

Happily cried Ultima as 6 pairs of——12 individual——pitch black wings spread out, and simultaneously commenced their attacks towards Damrada.

An attack via the wings.

It, unlike the unstable Black Flame Whip up until now, it was a severe attack with refined strength.

Damrada mustered his strength, and focused on subverting the attack.

Did it! And after he felt relief for an instant,

「Poison Lunge Fist!」

The young lady (Ultima) had pierced through Damrada's Abdomen.

Her wrist clad in magic, the Ultimate Skill 『Poison King Samael』 was focused on the purple claws at her five fingers as it activated.

Its strength easily broke through Damrada's defenses, giving her the grasp of victory.

「Ughf!」

Damrada started vomiting blood, and collapsed on the spot.

However, still mustering his willpower,

「You idiot, that wasn't a lunge fist. It was a spear hand.....

But, the strike was flawless.....well done.....

It could be called “Bloody Bite (Crimson Serpent's Venomous Claws)” perhaps.....」

And saying that much, he collapsed.

Looking up towards the sky, he looked back at his entire life, and made a bitter smile with a hint of regret.

Your Majesty——

「Damrada, this time may be my last.

I am more than tired.

Suppressing Justice King Michael from going out of control has its limits.

When you think about this thoroughly, absolute “Justice” isn’t all that different from “evil”.

a justice that everyone acknowledges doesn’t exist after all.....

Therefore, while I'm still myself I command you.

『Seek out he who can defeat me ! ! 』

If I lose this battle against Guy, There probably wouldn't be anyone left with the ability to suppress the berserking Justice King Michael.

It pains me to ask you for this favor.

It's vexing to be unable to keep my promise with "Stellar Dragon King" Veldanava but.....

That's something I'll go apologize to him about on the other side.

This is an imperial order.

Find someone who can defeat me, and destroy Justice King

Michael!!」

——My sincere apologies.

I was unable to fulfill your imperial order.....

Regret.

However, there was also relief.

To find someone who could kill his master, to Damrada it was agonizing.

Guy wouldn't budge.

That Demon Lord was obstinate about rules, he would never make a move out of his own volition.

For that reason, after the Emperor's decree was issued, Damrada had left the Emperor's side and began his various activities around the world.

He had found some candidates.

Kagurazaka Yuuki and Demon Lord Rimuru.

Their existences were the buds of chaos, but at the same time they were also the rays of hope.

This battle had caused the decisive showdown against Guy to become an impossibility.

At this point it was already impossible to rebuild themselves. Emperor Rudra no longer had the spare energy to wait for another opportunity.

With his tenacious will, he had dominated and controlled the ultimate skill 『Justice King Michael』.

For Rudra who bore the flesh of man, it must have been a burden painful beyond imagination. However, Rudra had endured all the way till now.

He was idealistic, he wanted to unite the world, he wanted establish eternal peace.

A dream where no conflict and poverty, where mankind would develop.

When Rudra's sister Lucia first met Veldanava she made a promise; she had sworn to give it her all alongside Emperor Rudra to work towards "establishing a unified country".

However, that dream would end in failure.

That being that case, they needed to stop the rampaging of the Ultimate Skill bestowed by the "Stellar Dragon King" Veldanava, 『Justice King Michael』.

To be destroyed by the ability handed from a friend, it truly is

the greatest irony.

Before Rudra collapsed, Damrada had to fulfill the imperial decree, but.....

It seemed he had failed in his duty.

Defeated by Ultima, his life began to wane.

However, he believed this wasn't a worse case scenario.

「His majesty.....Rudra sama, I wish for him to be killed (released).....

can I ask that of you.....?」

「.....Yeah, alright. I planned to kill him anyways!」

Hearing Ultima's reply, Damrada felt relieved, his heart was liberated as he felt at peace.

「Your offering, is my soul..... I will pass on all the “techniques” I've forged.....

——Your majesty.....I'll be joining you now.....」

Those were his last words.

Damrada, took his last breath and descended into eternal slumber.

He who was the Prime Minister of the Nasca Kingdom, and the sworn friend of the unifying Emperor Rudra·Nam·Ul·Nasca.

The curtains had finally been drawn on the long life of the “Fist Saint” Damrada.

「A-ah, how boring. His Heart disappeared.

Especially after I thought about presenting it to Rimuru sama.....」

Looking uninterested, Ultima, absorbed Damrada's body that was altering into energy, his very soul, with her black tentacles.

The skills and strength Damrada had forged was being absorbed into her body.

And so, the battle between Ultima and Damrada reached its conclusion.

The life of one "Fist Saint" ended, and that of a new "Fist Saint" was born.

Damrada, in his final moments, had given his greatest power to one of the worst (strongest) of the demons.

Perhaps passing on without noticing this was, for him, a blissful thing.

Or perhaps, he was happy with the fact there was a successor for his skills.

Damrada passed away, and it was no longer possible to know the answer to this, for a method to do so didn't exist.

Carrera, who had just lost her left arm, was in a bind.

With an ability to convert her violence from within into strength, she could exhibit immense power, but the man before her stands in her way like a wall.

Kondo too, had miscalculated.

From the beginning, justice belonged to the victor, and to lose to an opponent while donning his uniform was inexcusable.

Wearing it meant that he would be giving it his all. Even if his opponent were a powerful one, he would never don his uniform unless he judged it necessary to quickly eliminate them.

And yet, even after firing several Remove bullets to destroy her barriers and multiple Necrosis bullets at her directly, she was still alive and kicking as she charged at Kondo.

In other words, she was a “threat” at a level that not even Kondo could easily handle.

(Such a pain. If only I still had the Judgment bullet.....)

Or so he thought, but just thinking about this would be no good, and he shot out an Eraser bullet once more.

The Judgment bullet, it was trump card that could only be shot once a day, but that also meant that it packed the strongest

punch.

However he had already used it earlier in order to weaken Veldora, he would have to wait until cooldown time was over, so there's no point thinking about it.

Against the Demon Carrera, Kondo had the upper hand in terms of battle tactics and proficiency over his abilities, however her overbearing Energy had forcefully evened the playing field.

In this battle, several bullet shots caused Carrera's magic circuits to go haywire, and an Eraser bullet by Kondo managed to erase her left arm before it had the chance to regenerate.

Even now Carrera took a hit from a maximum output Eraser bullet that managed to gorge out the left side of her abdomen.

「You bastard.....!!」

Carrera groaned as she used her right hand to mend the large

hole on her flank.

Normally, this level of injury is something she could passively heal, however due to the effects of the Necrosis bullets, her healing failed to function.

In a situation where her left arm wouldn't regenerate, Carrera was made aware of the graveness of the situation.

The stronger of mind could beat the stronger of power.

At this point, Carrera, whose body was tormented by pain, deeply understood this.

There was no point in merely having them.

When fighting true elites, similar to using magic as naturally as breathing air, one must also have complete mastery of their own abilities.

In a contest of power, Carrera had the overwhelming advantage.

However, she suffered a majorly in terms of will power.

(If this goes on, I'll lose.....?)

In other words.....I'll die?

We demons.....the strongest...

I, a Devil Lord, will!?)

This was something she would never acknowledge.

Above all, this would go against the order of Carrera's beloved master, Demon Lord Rimuru.

If something like that happened, Carrera feared that even if she couldn't atone for this disgrace even if she killed herself 10,000 times over.

Rather than death, she worried about being unable to follow Rimuru's orders.

「Such a thing is unacceptable ! 」

Shouting aloud, she braced herself as she forcefully tried to regenerate her left abdomen and left arm.

Activating the Ultimate Skill 『Extinction King Abaddon』 on both her hands, black and white lights filled up the space around Kondo and Carrera.

Colossal amounts of magic essence were being converted into energy, and the aftershocks had enough force to blow away Carrera and Kondo.

Carrera focused her will, and gained control of the Energy.

As for Kondo, he wanted to say ‘are you fucking kidding me’.

At the moment, if he attacked Carrera and disrupted her concentration, he feared the uncontrolled outburst of energy concentrated on her hands would blow away the entire Airship.

Perchance, if he didn’t survive the blow, he feared the Emperor would get wrapped up in it.

Due to the fact the surrounding Airships had all been annihilated, with the flagship as the only remaining vessel, he couldn’t disregard the risks.

His teeth grinding in frustration, it was as if the tables had turned in an instant.

Kondo wasn’t exactly at fault in this regard.

This was praiseworthy, to able instantly compress the mana that swelled out of nowhere, and leading to the current circumstances, reflected the precision of Carrera’s 『Mana

Manipulation』.

This was something that could be accomplished precisely because she was Carrera, who, among the 4 Devil Lords, boasted of Energy levels second only to Diablo, and prided herself on the precision of her control.

「I bestow upon you destruction. Be gone! “Abyss Annihilation”!!」

A substance called forth from the abyss, a torrent of Anti-Spirit Energy.

This was Carrera’s Ultimate Magic.

Realized through the use of the Ultimate Skill 『Extinction King Abaddon』, this was the greatest, the best Attack Magic.

Kondo quickly analyzed the situation and took action, invoking his Ultimate Skill 『Sandalphon the Executioner』.

With Kondo as the target, this was a spell that would destroy anything in its path.

He understood it as such.

At this rate, it would directly hit the bridge of the ship behind Kondo.

Therefore, in order to avoid affecting the bridge he'd have to go against, and suppress the Energy.

He determined it as such.

Emperor Rudra who was on the deck would probably be safe even if he took a direct hit. That being the case, protecting the flagship would be synonymous to protecting the Emperor.

And thus, Kondo, making good use of Sandalphon, attempted to tackle the force of extinction but.....

“Abyss annihilation” was Carrera’s strongest magic, and its power was likewise excessively overwhelming.

Despite being protected from head to toe by the God-tier armour that was used to its full potential, Kondo felt intense pain penetrating throughout his entire body.

But thanks to that, Kondo survived.

It was the result of protection from a God-tier armour on top of using Sandalphon the Executioner.

However he wasn’t unharmed, wounded all over his body, he was in a state where he was barely standing.

But, as a result of his actions, the bridge was splendidly protected.

He was relieved.

The battered Kondo turned towards Carrera,

「You are, unfair——」

He expressed his emotions for the first time.

Carrera seemed satisfied with his words,

「Ah, that's natural. We are of the strongest race after all.

But are you not very unfair yourself?」

She responded with a grin while laughing fearlessly.

For Carrera, this was the greatest compliment.

And then, she prepared herself vigilantly.

Kondo was wounded all over.

However, Carrera too had suffered heavier damage than how she appeared.

While the two mutually acknowledged each other, they began mustering their last ounce of strength for the final showdown.

Chapter 182: The Entrusted Will

Kondo and Carrera.

They remained standing with only will and pride.

A will to never accept defeat in his uniform, and a pride in her demonic strength which forbade the same action.

But in reality, both were in tatters.

Kondo inducted the “Abyss Annihilation”, and successfully redirected the flow of Energy.

The next time, he would have been able to do this much more perfectly, and without damage to his body.

But that time, was definitely not now.

To remain standing after a magic attack that was like the very incarnation of mayhem proved the sheer strength of his will.

Albeit consequently, all his chakra (spirit energy) had been drained, and he didn't even have the strength to manifest a single bullet.

In simpler terms, he had no power to fight back.

It goes without saying that his guard was still up. But at the moment, he couldn't nullify even simple attacks, and the next direct hit would definitely spell his defeat.

That was Kondo's situation.

As for Carrera, her state wasn't unlike Kondo's.

Both her arms were gone as a result of using "Abyss Annihilation".

Unable to properly control her Energy from the effects of Anti-Spirit Energy, the overwhelmingly adverse reaction disintegrated both her upper limbs.

She left a strange picture, standing straight with no problems even though various parts of her body were missing.

However, she was a Spirit Form.

So, she would not fall no matter how battered her appearance was.

From her 6 wings, only 2 remained, and held up her body.

Even with her enormous reserves of remaining mana, she couldn't really make use of them since her Magic Circuits were destroyed.

Regeneration would obviously take a lot of time, and she didn't have that time in the middle of battle.

Yet, Carrera faced her foe, and prepared for the showdown.

The one's watching over Carrera's faceoff.

These were Emperor Rudra, Major General Xam'd, and his subordinates, a few Elite Mages.

Though the Emperors defence was impregnable, the members of the bridge were not self-assured, and were busy maintaining the barriers from the deck to the upper levels.

The reason being, every other Airship had fallen, and this ship was their lifeline.

They had attempted to contact home for reinforcements, but communications were cut off by some kind of signal jamming.

This was obviously the work of the Greater Demons that surrounded them, and they suspected that Teleportation Magic had also been jammed.

Their escape from this ship had been blocked, and retreating towards the ships floating on the ocean also seemed hopeless.

Under those circumstances, protecting this ship was the best course of action.

However,

「Xam'd-kakka, if that impossibly destructive power from just now hit us, we wouldn't stand a chance.」(TN: -kakka is honorific like -sama)

One of the Elite Mages reported to Xam'd.

Which one do you mean..... Xam'd wanted to comment.

Because every one of the Demons' attacks were just ridiculous.

But, Xam'd knew what the Mage meant.

It was probably the one shot by Demon Lord Rimuru who was pitted against “Scorch Dragon” Velgrynd.

The Magic Attack from the Demon that First Lieutenant Kondo was fighting, or the spear attack from that butler Demon seemed out of this world, but the one by the Demon Lord had such fearsome power that it seemed out of this very reality.

Being an Elite Mage himself, Xam’d instinctively understood that this attack simply broke the laws of this world and surpassed reality.

The other attacks were similarly very strong attacks, but this attack just neglected reason.

「Don’t say it. We can only fulfill our assigned duties now.....」

With an unyielding spirit, Xam’d encouraged his subordinate.

They would protect the Emperor, and escape from this area. Then, they would meet up with the reinforcements who were

on their way, and ameliorate their conditions.

He understood how unrealistic the prospects for this plan was, but there was no other option.

This was their only plan, there was no plan B.

And now, in front of this troubled Xam'd, a single man appeared.

As if returning in the utmost urgency, his breathing was hoarse. His armour appeared damaged in many parts, as if he had just survived an intense battle.

「The Emperor, is he, is he alright!？」

Xam'd recognized the man as the Beast Corps captain, Gradim.

It was slightly dirty, but he could never mistake the brilliance of that God-tier armour.

His worry must have been the result of fatigue from enduring battle.

「Oh, Gradim-dono! You were alive!？」

Xam'd knew about the great mana released below, which had initiated the Beast Corps' battle with the Demons.

When those Demons were later heading up towards them, he had given up on any chance of Gradim's survival.

Among the countless fallen allies, a single survivor was a happy misprediction.

「Yes, somehow. I was conceited thinking I was that best; the enemy truly is strong.」

「Not your fault. Their strength is far beyond our estimated Energy calculations.

They may have multiple Demon Nobles.

On top of that, they were ones at the higher echelons.....

The one that lieutenant Kondo-dono is in battle with right now must be one of the best too.」

「I could say the same about the one I fought.

I just barely managed to escape using the transfer device.

Death is an honorable end for any soldier, and I believe it true for myself.

But, I couldn't rest in peace without making sure the Emperor was safe.

I must at least take my liege to safety.....」

「Indeed.....

Still, what can we even do now.....」

「Don't give in! If I protect the Emperor, can you move this ship at full speed?

we need to break through and get outside the range of the Demons' Spatial Interference Barrier.

If we do that, we can use the transfer device right?」

「I see..... Breaking though will be tough with just one ship.....

But we must.....」

Xam'd glanced at Emperor Rudra, and reaffirmed his determination.

Just recently, the Emperor had become very motionless, as if he had lost consciousness.

They were still unscathed thanks to the Emperor's Skill, but it was getting dangerous.

Ultimate Skill 『Justice King Michael's』 “Castle Guard” was an Absolute Barrier. However, that Skill needed certain conditions for its invocation.

Those conditions were known to a select few of the Royal Knights.

That being the case, Xam'd believed that the Emperor would be fine in any situation.....

But his sense as an Elite Mage would deny that presumption.

It's impossible. To have such a convenient Skill is just.....

And seeing how Kondo had defended the ship at the expense of his body only fueled his theory that there must be a weakness.

If this went on, even the Emperor himself would sustain damage.

Therefore, they had to act now.

「I'll leave him to you, Gradim-dono!」

Xam'd shouted, then headed into the bridge with his men to prepare moving the ship.

Gradim —— No, the thing shaped like Gradim —— bowed deeply while seeing off Xam'd.

And under that helmet which hid his face, there appeared a warped smile.

Kondo and Carrera's battle continued.

Both of them were unable to use any more mana, and it had become a battle of fists.

Parrying fatal attacks, then dealing them out in succession.

Kondo had used up most of his, and put his all of little remaining mana inside the God-tier gun — Sandalphon the Executioner—.

Meanwhile, Carrera regenerated one of her arms.

And concentrated the last of her own remaining mana into that one fist.

Even using up her defence magic, her main body was now defenceless.

For Kondo, it was high time he needed to retreat.

For Carrera, it was the most disgraceful moment in all her life.

However, not losing her pride, it was the best fight she had ever experienced; Carrera took that satisfaction and tightened her fist.

Damaged beyond belief, they moved their bodies through will power only.

The thing shaped like Gradim closely observed their battle.

Kondo was truly super-human; so close to death, yet his movements did not falter.

Carrera too was handling all of his attacks with only a single arm.

Though obviously it was the gun she should have been most wary of.

It seemed like a long time had passed, but in reality it was only a few seconds. Feeling its body move, the thing now looked at the conditions outside.

Just as planned, Xam'd was making a full scale assault on the Spatial Interference Barrier erected by the Greater Demons.

With a broad grin, the thing shaped like Gradim made it's move.

An armoured hand entered Kondo's chest.

And at the same time, An Energy Blast came at Carrera.

That attack on Kondo proved fatal.

And Carrera was down with no signs of movement.

The man kicked away a blood spewing Kondo, while cutting away his heart and putting it in his mouth.

「Guhahahahaha!!

Your's truly is the one brought down the famous, the super-human Kondo! In the end, your's truly is the one who was stronger!」

「Gu-hha..... B-bastard..... You're not Gradim 」

Facing Kondo who vomited blood,

「Don't put that weakling together with your's truly. Also, your's truly is busy so see ya!!」

The man answered mockingly.

Then, putting Energy in both his hands, and pointing towards the barrier in front of the Airship——

「Remove Blast!!」

—— made his attack.

An attack overlapped with the barrier piercing effects of lieutenant Kondo's Skill.

「Guhahahahaha!! Look at this power Kondo.

Even you proved useful right before death.

I'll take care of the Emperor for you. So be at ease.

And being at ease —— Die!!」

He released a series of Energy Blast towards the two on the ground.

Then, returned to the ship in a hurry.

He wanted to confirm their deaths, but the other Demons were heading over.

And more importantly, the Barrier would likely be repaired very soon.

His first priority was escape, and confirming their deaths was secondary.

The thing shaped like Gradim quickly entered the bridge, and erased his presence.

Kondo closed his hazy eyes, and lay on the ground.

This was his end, his body had given out.

(Pathetic——)

He spoke at himself.

In the end, he had accomplished nothing.

He could neither protect his homeland, nor his promise with the Emperor.

—— Become my friend, Tatsuya!

Ah..... I couldn't even fulfil my promise to you.

I couldn't bear your suffering, nor could I ease your pain—— I

couldn't do anything.

I couldn't even fulfil my promise of releasing you in the end.....

—— I requested this of Damrada, and I will also request it of you, Tatsuya.

If I ever show signs of breaking, kill me without hesitation; I allow it.

You must never let the Justice King break loose.

That thing probably sees everything in this world as evil.

This mad, mad world that took away Lucia, and the Creator Veldanava.

Returning all to none, it probably believes that those two

would return if we started back again from zero.

—— Hey Tatsuya. I reincarnated. I still remember you.

—— I'm fine. I can still handle it. This time, we'll definitely defeat Guy!!

—— Recently, the military affairs are being handled without me involved.....

Take care of me when the madness starts ok.....

Justice King Michael won't stop at just civilization, it will definitely destroy everything in this world.....

Conversations with the Emperor of days long past flashed across his mind.

The Emperor who had stopped Kondo from killing himself in

this world after failing his nation; The man who became his friend.

Repeatedly reincarnating to the point of exhausting his control over Justice King Michael, the man still displayed the Aura of a ruler.

The boy called Yuuki, who Damrada had brought along, seemed unreliable.

Or rather, dangerous.

Like himself, the boy also hid a deep darkness in his heart.

If it was before the Emperor was weakened, maybe he would have shone a light on the boys heart.

But that was impossible for the Emperor of present.

That being the case, Kondo took that task upon himself and eliminated the boy. To avoid unnecessary trouble, and to erase any seeds of disaster.

Even then, here he was, rotting away without holding up his promise to stop the Emperor.....

He grieved in his regrets.

All the failures were the result of underestimating Demon Lord Rimuru.

He should have followed his gut feeling, and stopped the Emperor's sortie.

Capturing Veldora had put him at ease. It was probably right then that the Justice King took control from the Emperor.

It was his failure.

One that he couldn't take back anymore.....

「Hey, enough sleeping. Get back up and fight me!」

Kondo heard a voice calling out to him.

Slightly opening his eyes, he saw an unhappy Carrera looking back.

Beautiful golden hair, a dazzling beauty.

And also, the Demon he was fighting to the death.

(—— Don't be unreasonable. I'm dying here, obviously I can't fight.)

「Ah? But there was no finisher. That just isn't right.」

(fu, fufu. A finisher, huh. You're, right.

—— As I thought. You're unfair.....)

Doubting if it reached her, hearing Carrera's words, Kondo had a weak chuckle.

Even though Carrera herself had sustained almost fatal damage with the previous surprise attack..... Kondo couldn't help but smile at the thought.

He attempted to get up, and failed.

Pathetic.

(I guess, I can't do anything now.)

Compared to him, the Demon was free in the purest sense.....

(—— Am I, jealous.....?)

「I h-have a request. Please kill..... Emperor..... this gun —— 」

(What am I doing. I can't leave this to a Demon.....) (TN: he says 'I' with 'ore' now.)

But, ah..... My consciousness is fleeting.

As a “Saint”, Kondo's body was the crystallization of Energy, but now his Central Core had been stolen.

Well, if he was in better health, he could restore the Core, but it was impossible now.

He felt himself grinding away from his extremities.

In fact, because his willpower and chakra had been exhausted, the destruction speed was considerably slowed down.

It was completely impossible to recover now, that was his self-analysis.

「Hmph. How boring. I finally had a good fight, but this is not fun at all.

I'll kill that intruder.

I guess I can kill the Emperor too on the way——」

(..... ?)

「You're so slow! Where's the offering? You want to made a deal with a Demon, you need a contract!」

Watching the fidgeting Carrera, Kondo couldn't hold back a smile.

It was a pleasant feeling.

This Demon, the enemy. Her shyly fidgeting figure.

(Everything, even my soul..... I'll hand over all so.....
Please.....!)

With the last of his will, Kondo opened his eyes, and looked at Carrera with all his strength.

He could no longer form words.

Thinking his will was properly entrusted may have just been his day dreaming.

Even so.....

He bet his last hopes on this pathetic salvation.

Trusting a Demon, he would have never imagined it.

「Thine request, we shall accepted it.

On the name of “Menace Lord” Carrera, this contract has been sealed.

Thine wish shall surely be granted.」

Carrera declared in a dignified manner.

Kondo smiled at her words, and using the last of his strength, handed his gun to Carrera.

The brilliantly shining God-tier gun.

As soon as she accepted it, Kondo’s body burst into light and was absorbed by Carrera.

However, even though she received his chakra, she didn’t get his Nucleic Heart.

She knew.

For humans on the level of “Saints”, even if their soul was captured, their Nucleic Heart would not.

Without fail, the Heart would escape from the cycle of reincarnation, and pass on.

「Hmph. Too bad. It's been a while since I fought someone with a bit of backbone..... 」

Carrera now focused her attention on the gun.

And suddenly, the Power (Skill) gushed in.

《Ultimate Skills 『Extinction King Abaddon』 and 『Sandalphon the Executioner』 successfully integrated. 》

Carrera understood the usage of her new powers from the

information sent to her brain.

And she instantly mastered the usage of the gun.

—— You're a bit sensitive, so your technique (mana) is too rough. Handle this with care——

She felt as if she heard Kondo again.

Cheeky till the very end, she thought.

Carrera stood up.

She saw Agera and Esprit heading her way.

Her recovery had already been completed.

「You're alright, Carrera-sama!」

They kneeled in front of Carrera who stood before them.

And congratulated her on being safe.

At a glance, they determined how their master's power had grown over her fight.

Satisfied,

「Let us go. We shall carve fear into the soul who dared look down on us.」

She walked.

Towards the fool who desecrated her sacred battle; to let him know true despair.

Also.....

Most importantly, towards the place where she would come to fulfill her contract.

Chapter 183: Establishing the Contract

Velgrynd and I faced each other, and unleashed our attacks looking to end this battle.

Our attacks clashed, and I got sent flying while a part of Velgrynd got sliced up.

The battle was turning into a stalemate of sorts.

But, results are starting to show.

At a glance, it looked like a furious exchange between us, but I had a fair amount of breathing room.

Although I got blown away by the clashes, I diverted most of the impact away, taking almost no damage.

Analysis of Velgrynd's abilities was complete, and just looking at the compatibility between us, it was clear that she's not a threat to me.

It's my win.

I am certain of it.

At this point, I received a telepathic message from Diablo.

(Kufufufufu. It looks like a "Rat" has crawled its way into our fight.

It has been cornered onto the flagship, what are your intentions sire?)

From just his tone, it sounded like getting rid of it was easy.

As for the results for the various battles, some were put into tough battles, but no fatalities so far.

The "Rat" was sneaking around among the battles the Devil Lords were in, observing the battle between Carrera and the guy

in uniform from the shadows.

He didn't look like he was going to assist his "allies", what a shady fellow.

Also, it seems like he ate one of his dead "comrades", looks like he had an ability of the "consumption" type.

So, was his aim the man in uniform?

Up til this point, on my orders, the surrounding space was within a field that interrupted teleportation.

I didn't want any unwanted guests, nor did I want anyone escaping.

If the "Rat" wanted to escape, his only option would be to move outside of the field that was set up.

To break through a hole in the field, and get an Airship out of the field. Then teleporting away from there.

Therefore..... his destination must be safe spot, which also means that's where his allies would be.

Should I round up all of them, or get rid of the "Rat" now?

Someone who moves around stealthily huh.

Yuuki may be involved.

If I got rid of the "Rat", the link to whoever is behind the scenes would be cut off.

If the Emperor is eliminated, the Empire will fall into chaos. Which also meant, other factions could take advantage of the situation and grow larger.

In any case, I shall set a trap for the “Rat”.

It would be best if it takes the bait (Emperor), and I get to reel them all in.

Although I have no way to confirm who is behind all this currently, it’s a good idea to cut the threat at it’s roots.

(Let the “Rat” scurry for now. It’s probably trying to escape via teleportation, so I want to know it’s destination.

After we come into contact with whoever is pulling the strings, we eliminate them. Put priority into finding out who is behind this!)

(Understood!)

To get all who are involved, including the “Rat”, in one fell swoop.

I gave the orders to Diablo, with such thoughts.

Even as I was communicating with Diablo, the battle with Velgrynd was still going on.

With support from Wisdom Lord Raphael, communication was easily possible as I still had lots of breathing room, even I was impressed at the current situation.

All of Velgrynd's attacks, were nullified with the Absolute Defense of Covenant King Uriel.

In comparison, my attacks using the "Veldora Sword", looked like they were doing damage as though it was ignoring any defenses on Velgrynd's large body.

The situation looked favourable for me, and seemed it would be difficult to overturn.

Velgrynd reverted from dragon, back to her human form.

As expected, it looked like it was hard to fully defend with that large body. If the aim was to improve her defenses, changing to her human form was a good choice.

But, that meant her offense would drop significantly.

Although there was no change in ability, the amount of base Energy that was at her disposal was now limited.

But well..... To me, since all attacks are blocked anyway, there's no doubt that she would be more of a pain to deal with in her human form.

As expected of Veldora's elder sister, she was a beauty with azure blue hair, having difficulty pointing my sword at that was also one of the reasons.....

Even so, that fella Raphael, wanted to take Covenant King Uriel away from me in this situation.

It's like telling me to devour her, as Gluttony King Beelzebuth

would be the only remaining option.

Velgrynd, after grazing past a few of my “Veldora Sword” attacks, looked exhausted.

If I keep up these attacks, it would result in my victory, but.....

「Da-damn you! To do this to us, “True Dragons”.....

To not only take away my little brother, but to also get in the way of Rudra and my wishes!!」

Velgrynd spewed another Cardinal Acceleration.

Although it looked like her output has decreased, with the increased focus she was putting into the attack, it was now a pinpoint attack; it could be said to be comparable to when she was in her dragon form.

It looked smaller, but I'm the only target anyway.

——but, this attack has already been analyzed, it won't work on me any more.

「Wasn't it you guys who took the initiative!?

You pit Veldora against me in the first place!」

「Shut up! My younger brother, hasn't fallen that low to be consumed by the likes of you!

Although he was an unreliable boy, to think he would be defeated by a puny Demon Lord.....

And ending up absorbed by that Demon Lord, and used to corner me like this.....」

It feels like she's really taking it out on me.

Drowned in anger, Blasts were forcefully released at me.

Too bad, those don't work against me.

But man, I'm stumped. If I continue attacking with this sword she might end up getting "erased", but well, she **is** Veldora's sister.....

(Hey, Veldora. Can't you talk to her and get her to calm down?)

(!? Don't ask something so scary! I almost forgot to breathe for a moment.

It's impossible for me to nonchalantly talk to her now, since she's actually angry for me!!

If she found out I was cooperating with you, and am totally alive and all.....)

Right.

I finally realised, Veldora can't be relied on, like at all.

But, man, this guy..... He's so unreliable at critical times.

This situation, happened because he ran away, and didn't want to meet his other elder sister.....

Huh? Then why am I the one doing all this jack?

I was slowly getting annoyed at something else.

(But, we can't just "erase" her, right?)

(.....u, Hmm. That would be bad, yea.

That's it! Let's change the setting to one which I was

forcefully consumed by you.

Just devour my sister too!

Then, get her into a position similar to mine.

If it's the current "you", it's definitely possible, even Wisdom Lord Raphael agrees!)

.....what is this fella saying?

This guy, just because he doesn't want to get scolded, he's the spoiled type who puts the blame on his buddy!

And from that train of thought, the bad guy is me isn't it!

Also, the plan to only have Gluttony King Beelzebuth remain supports this notion.

Raphael and Veldora are in cahoots! Was, what I have realised.

But, well.

Towards his elder sister who was so aggravated at his “death”, just appearing like nothing happened is not a good idea, even I could understand that much.

Even though I understood, it definitely feels like all the troublesome stuff was dumped onto me.

Also..... If Veldora, who merrily put so much power into the sword earlier gets found out and gets chewed out for it, he’s not going to put the blame for that on me too, right?

Change the setting to me being forcefully consumed! The moment he said that, he was definitely aiming to push all the blame onto me.

But wait a sec? A similar position.....

Against Veldora, there wasn't really anything I can "force" him to do.

I get his consent, then he works accordingly. More like he has a lot of freedom to do whatever he wants, that Veldora.

Basically, once he is "released", there isn't much of anything I can force Veldora to do.

If he wanted to take actions disadvantageous to me, I could just cut the Link; even if Veldora declines, it's not like he gets "erased" if the Link is cut.

If something happens and the "released" Veldora gets destroyed, whether he decides to return to his "real body" which is inside me or not, there's no "real" loss.

To put it simply, there is no restricting force whatsoever.

A position similar to Veldora's.

Simply means to devour Velgrynd, then “release” her.

That also means, the fact that Veldora wasn’t forced into anything would be proven, and I don’t get blamed at all.

A sibling-squabble? What’s that, is it tasty?

That’s not something within my “jurisdiction”.

I decided to devour Velgrynd, and put her in the same position as Veldora.

But, it’s bothersome if she rampaged after getting “released”.

Since I can’t force Velgrynd, is it even possible to do something like this?

《Solution. There are no problems. As a being similar to a “True Dragon” now, there is room to spare.

Also, it is possible to set conditions for “release”.

Regarding that, negotiation with individual: “Scorch Dragon” Velgrynd is required.》

Hmm?

So I have to devour first.

Then, set conditions when turning her into another “ability”?

In the worst case, if Velgrynd declines, I could just isolate her inside my 『Stomach』 without turning her into an “ability”.

I could also just let her out after the whole fiasco is over, it’s not like she “needs” to become another part of my abilities.

After my ascension into something similar to a “True Dragon”, I can feel my stats have definitely increased, there

should be no problems isolating a Velgrynd or two inside me.

The objective was decided.

Now to get to work.

「Whatever the case, gotta get rid of the threats! I'm not going to let you do something like this again.

Velgrynd, time for you to repent a little!!」

「Screw you, like hell I'm going down without a fight!」

The fierce battle with Velgrynd continued.

Holy crap she's fast. It's gonna be a real pain to capture her.

She's supposed to have less power in her human form, but the

battle isn't getting any easier.

Even then, using Covenant King Uriel, I cut her movements off with 『Insulated Prison』.

Through that, I managed to finally capture her.

「You bastard, Fuck you! Let me out, release me!!」

Velgrynd was rampaging.

And the suspicious figure moving towards that pretty lady, was me.

If my appearance was that of a slime, this would totally be a crime. But then again, my current form is that of a 16 year old-ish bishoujo, this set a different kind of mood.

Can't help that.

Gotta get rid of threats.

I put my hand in contact with Velgrynd, and devoured her body all at once.

With the “feel” of isolating the aggressive Energy, it was concluded with no problems.

But, as expected of a “True Dragon”.

There was difficulty in fully isolating her, even after fully consuming her “body”.

She was rampaging non-stop, even though she was surrounded with 『Insulated Prison』, it felt as though my body was going to be burnt asunder.

I had immunity to heat, so being able to feel heat at this point showed how bad this was.

Although there was no damage, if I were to lose mentally now, it feels like I would be utterly fried.

Right now, this was a battle of wills.

「I'm not as naive as my little brother, you dirtbag!

Also, Rudra is going to come to my aid any moment now.

This is the end for you, Demon Lord Rimuru!」

Nope, not happening.

The situation looked like it was checkmate for the Empire, the Airship which Rudra is on was attempting to escape.

「But from what I can tell, the Emperor Rudra you just talked about is leaving you behind and trying to escape.」

「Bullshit! Rudra is invincible as long as I'm still around. There's no way he's running.....」

Velgrynd's attempt to belittle me failed terribly.

As she has now noticed the Airship was increasing it's speed and attempting to leave.

「Th-that can't be..... Why? Why are you leaving me behind..... Rudra!？」

And then, she closed her eyes as though she had finally realized something.

Moments later, all resistance against my devouring disappeared.

Velgrynd stopped resisting, and was now motionless inside my 『Stomach』 .

——I see now..... You, have already broken haven't you.....
Rudra——

Only that murmur seeped out.

Velgrynd finally calmed down.

It felt like she had understood and given up on something.

It looked like she had no intention to resist, but I can't just absorb her as she is now.

Gotta negotiate with her first.....

But she now looked so despondent, it felt difficult to strike a conversation.

(Oi, do what you want with me. I admit defeat, and will not resist.

But, you better be prepared.

To have killed my little brother, and now me too.

Our elder sister, Velzard will never forgive you.)

(Ahh, right. About that.....)

(What? You got something you wanna ask?

But, too bad for you. I have no idea how to stop the impending Angel attack.

Even if I *did* know something, I have no obligation to tell you anything!)

(Well, that's not it.....)

To me who was kind of flustered, Velgrynd was rushing me to finish absorbing her.

It seems, she has misunderstood that I have killed Veldora after I consumed him, and looks like she is prepared for the same to happen to herself.

She was totally not listening to what I was saying, which was very troublesome.

(What is it that you want to say, you fiend!

Now that Rudra is “broken”, there’s no meaning in my existence.

I’m telling you to consume me or do whatever the hell you want to!)

Velgrynd got mad at me, she seems to be fairly short tempered.

Honestly, she's scary. I now kinda understood why Veldora had trouble with her.

(It looks like you are misunderstanding something, Veldora is still alive!

Why would I kill my friend in the first place? You need to listen to what I have to say first!)

(What!?)

After what felt like a long explanation—which in fact only took a few seconds in real time— Velgrynd finally understood the situation.

By the way, during that period of time, Veldora was completely silent. Looks like he's still pushing all the responsibility onto me.

Feeling exhausted, I continued the negotiation.

And so, if she was cooperative, I intended to let her have the same amount of freedom Veldora has.

If not, then I'll only release her after everything is over.

Velgrynd turned silent for a short while, it looked like she was thinking about it.

Then slowly opening her mouth,

(I have a condition. It's more of a favour than a condition. Mind hearing me out?)

She said to me.

I kind of expected this, looking at the flow of the situation, I decided to listen to what Velgrynd had to say.

Velgrynd's favour was, as expected, related to Emperor Rudra.

After apologizing for making the first move, Velgrynd began her explanation.

Emperor Rudra was slowly deteriorating because of the influence of Ultimate Skill 『Justice King Michael』 that he wielded, and was reaching his end.

Which is why, he was so fixated on gaining the victory against Guy this final time; it was also why he went to such lengths in preparation.

But that also meant he ended up being lax in his judgement somewhat, as he overlooked my rise to power, which became bad luck, and ended up causing all of his plans to fall apart.....

Back to the point, considering the Emperor's abilities, he was invincible as long as Velgrynd was close by, so he had no need to escape.

Seeing that he seemed to have forgotten this fact, proved that Rudra has reached the point of no return.

In addition to his impenetrable barrier, he had the ability to attack by changing the elemental properties of Velgrynd's powers with Justice King Michael, Velgrynd's explanation; his current course of action served to prove the point even more.

Most importantly,

(He can no longer hear my voice. That's why..... Rudra is most likely gone.)

Velgrynd heavy heartedly said. And,

(My favour, is for you to help release Rudra's soul from the shackles of his own fate.

He has, for the longest time, shouldered the wishes of many.....)

She made her request.

But that means, even if they did manage to emerge victorious, their future outlook was non-existent. (TN:I almost couldn't understand what this line meant..)

In any case, if it wasn't possible to stop Justice King Michael from running amok, it was kind of pointless even if they won against Guy.

Just as I was thinking that,

(Well, as long as we got the victory, we were intending to "return" Justice King Michael.

We wouldn't need it after we are victorious against Guy.)

Velgrynd answered my suspicions.

Since she said something about "returning", it seems possible to "erase" that Skill.

Using Justice King Michael, one can travel to the “Heavens” via “Heaven’s Gate”.

In that place, using the altar for worshipping “Stellar Dragon King” Veldanava, it was possible to seal the skill.

Their plan was to head to the altar to report their victory, and “return” the skill in the process.

Ultimate Skill Justice King Michael belonged to “Stellar Dragon King” Veldanava in the first place.

(No matter how much of a “Saint” Rudra was, there were limits to how much of the skill he could handle.

That was the reason he needed to “reincarnate” countless times, maintaining his ego while continuing to “live”.

Having retained control for more than 2000 years, showed just how strong his will was.....

But even that has come to it's end.

My wish, is simply to release Rudra from this endless cycle.)
(TN: a saint is something above a sage.)

Velgrynd thus ended her explanation.

At that point, Diablo's report came in with impeccable timing.

(Rimuru-sama, one of your acquaintances, Damrada has passed on.

It was the result of his deathmatch, with Ultima as his opponent.

After a magnificent battle, Ultima has emerged victorious.

And Ultima, during Damrada's final moments, accepted his "request".....

I shall send the details over.)

He reported.

Then, a compressed report was sent telepathically.

With that I understood the circumstances.

It seems that there is no other choice but for the Emperor to die.

Although I didn't know the details, I had thought of Damrada to be the loyal type ——well that dandy fella (EN: ossan) was the mysterious kind. Here I thought his loyalties lied with Yuuki but it seems I was mistaken—— he too wished for the Emperor's death.

Then, there's the stuff I just heard from Velgrynd.

The Emperor who *was* exalted, huh. Compared to his past achievements, I thought his current condition was more important.

While I was musing over such matters,

(Rimuru-sama, the battle between Carrera and the man in uniform has concluded.

Due to my lack of action, the “Rat” managed to butt in.)

(Did it escape?)

(No, I have its whereabouts.

Moss attached a “tracker” onto it, it will not escape even if it teleports.

It is lamentable however, as it spoiled the results of the duel

between Carrera and the man in uniform.)

Because of my order to leave the “Rat” be, he was indecisive on whether he should take action against the “Rat”.

As a result, Moss managed to neutralize the “Rat’s” attack, on the surface it looked like there wasn’t much impact on Carrera or the man in uniform.

But, despite both sides being injured all over, their duel was brought to a halt as a result.

This “Rat” is unforgivable.

Plus, Carrera accepted the “request” of the man in uniform too, which was also to end Rudra’s life.

Since it has been accepted, it shall be done.

I resolved myself firmly.

(Velgrynd, I hereby swear to release Rudra from his fate. Give me your cooperation!)

I declared.

Velgrynd showed no signs of hesitation, and give me her acknowledgement.

The Contract was now established.

And Velgrynd now began her integration within me, becoming another one of my Powers (Skills).

Chapter 184: The Faceoff

Having absorbed Velgrynd, the reconstruction began.

And then, leaving a busily working on something Raphael-san alone, I teleported onto the lone floating Airship.

It had already reached it's maximum speed, cruising at speeds beyond that of sound.

Although I could catch up, there's also the issue with the "Rat".

I thought it best to deal with problems swiftly.

Considering the fierce battle that had just taken place aboard this vessel, it's a miracle it could still fly in its sorry state.

The Demons who had made it in before me had knelt down, welcoming me.

Any remnants of battle couldn't be seen at a glance. The damages sustained had been beautifully healed, showing their usual, beautiful splendor.

However, looking through a highly proficient appraising eye, Their Power(Existence level) had undergone great change.

Perhaps an after-effect of completing a forced evolution, the slight magic turbulence they had was now in perfect control.

It would seem that they understood something from this battle. This is a good thing.

Above all everyone's all right, I felt relieved.

「Good work! It's great that everyone's all right.」

「My word! We're unworthy of such words.

We, as commanded by Rimuru sama, have survived and acquired strength!」

The demons that brought up these words bowed their heads in unison.

Eh? Although I did say don't die, I didn't tell them to survive to the very edge though?

To survive and become stronger, what are they, some battle race?!

I was shocked that they thought of me as a master who would give that kind of ridiculous command.

「Ah, Yeah. In any case, above all, I'm glad you're all safe.....」

The Demons looked happy from receiving my compliments.

Oh well, whatever.

I should probably pay more attention from here on out, but we were in fact currently in an emergency situation. I decided to reflect on it later.

I changed my mindset, and proceeded to confirmed the situation.

「What's the current situation of the “Rat”?」

「Kufufufufu. It seems the “Rat” has just arrived at the transfer device.」

Hmm.

If I wanted to stop it, now would be the time.

I considered killing the “Rat” then and there, and extracting

his memory.

However, individuals surpassing A rank have high resistances, and taking memories protected by the soul seemed difficult.

And as for those in possession of Ultimate Skills, it'd fail without a doubt.

The “Rat” had only been sneaking around, but according to Diablo a strong power was sensed from it.

This was evident from the fact he managed to steal a portion of Military Uniform's abilities. (EN: refers to Kondo. Rimuru refers to him as this.)

If you wanted to steal an ability (Skill) in the truest sense of the word, the other party's soul would be essential. Without that, if you only stole it from devouring a portion of the flesh, only be an inferior variant could be deconstructed.....

Even so to be able to break through a section of the Spatial

Interference Barrier set up by the 600 Greater Demons, he, without a doubt, wielded some sort of troublesome ability.

As initially planned, the strategy was to lure out the puppeteer behind the scenes with the Emperor as bait.

Thus uproot the evil at its roots.

The promise to release Emperor Rudra must, of course, definitely be achieved.

「I shouldn't have to worry about him escaping right?」

「Kufufufu. There is no problem!」

Good.

I've established my objective, and gave the command.

Let's clean this mess up quickly.

The “Rat”, taking the form of the man Gradim, Vega, pretended to protect Emperor Rudra while he activated the transfer device.

Nodding towards the small number of Elite Mages and Major General Xam'd staying behind to guard,

「I'll be going on ahead. You guys quickly make your escape too!」

Leaving behind these insincere words, Vega transferred, and escaped.

Naturally, He brought along Emperor Rudra.

After arriving at the transfer facility room within the deepest part of the Imperial palace of the Capital, Vega destroyed the transfer device.

The thin, shining and mysterious magic formation was blown to pieces from the shockwaves from Vega's power.

With this, connection between the Airships' transfer devices and the Imperial Capital had been severed. The demons would no longer be able to pursue Vega.

Those who stayed behind would be massacred, but that was something Vega wouldn't know to care about.

Vega took a breath, and a fearless, broad grin surfaced.

Vega had immense self-confidence in his powers.

However, he considered the Demons from earlier. The one who insta-killed Beast King Gradim, and the ones who fought with Kondo and Damrada; They were genuine monsters.

Beast King Gradim was a strong individual who surpassed the average Demon Lords.

However, Vega didn't think he'd lose to him, and if they actually fought, he was confident in his chances of winning.

However, those monsters easily surpassed Vega who had reached the upper limits of human strength as a Sage.

(Fuck 'em! Just fuck 'em to bits. Your's truly will get much stronger. Just you watch!)

Although his head was fuming to the point he felt welled up with seething wrath, having suppressed his anger, he had brought the Emperor to the designated location as initially commanded.

「You sure took your time, Vega. Is Emperor Rudra alright? 」

On the throne;

A chair that only the Emperor was permitted to sit on, a young boy sat on it with a relaxed look.

He called out to Vega, who had just arrived, with a light-hearted tone.

Black hair and Black eyes, a native Japanese look.....

He was someone who should have been exterminated by Kondo, Kagurazaka Yuuki.

And standing behind him was a stoic faced beauty.

But contrary to her appearance, she was the strongest Hero, Chloe O'bell.

Chloe was probably unwilling, as she unresponsively stood there with an uninterested look.

Acting per her contract, she left an impression of indifference.

「He's okay. Although his head had a few screws loose.

However, that Demon Lord Rimuru sure is a monster. That guy shut me down big time.

By the way, are things all right here?

The coup d'état was suppressed or something, I heard from Gradim and the others?

So you're alright?」

「Do I look like I'm alright?

I was in some serious shit over here you know?

I'd requested Chloe here to resurrect me on the off chance I died.

Thanks to that I barely made it alive, but I actually did die.

Well, thanks to that, the remaining Wishes (Commands) left on Chloe has dropped to one.....

It's all that Kondo and Damrada's fault.

Be it Damrada or Kondo, them hiding their true strength was seriously annoying. 」

Yuuki explained to Vega with exaggerated gestures.

While he continued on with his tale, suddenly, he fixated his gaze on Vega,

「Ah~man, Vega. Dude, you're being tracked aren't you?」

While letting out a sigh, he lamented.

And then, holding his hand over Vega's back,

「Eraser Shot!」

With a single hit, he eliminated Moss's clone who was performing reconnaissance on Vega.

The tiny fist-sized demon, forcefully split in half, was destroyed without being able to resist.

「That was a close one. A little more and they would have arrived at this place in hot pursuit.

Or rather, It seems Rimuru-san's subordinates are all horrifyingly excellent for no apparent reason.

We got careless for a bit there didn't we? Vega, get your act

together. 」

「Y-yeah. I got careless there, my bad.....」

Yuuki shrugged his shoulders.

Vega also looked as if he was scowling. However, in reality he wasn't reflecting at all.

In fact, he didn't notice it at the time since he was so wrapped up, but he felt his pride was trampled all over, he was furious to his very core. There was no room for reflecting.

Quite the annoyance, it seems one must not be careless with Rimuru's subordinates.

Yuuki moved to a different location.

Bringing Vega and Chloe along, he moved with transfer

magic.

At the Capital's outskirts, this was where corpses were organized.

The location where Velgrynd entrapped and delivered pain to the Mixed Corps in the "Crimson Purge", this was where the corpses of the elites directly under Yuuki lay.

The fires of purgatory that wouldn't clear up no matter what, after some time, had began to weaken, and had just finally extinguished.

Naturally, they looked like how they were moments before death, it looked as if they hardly managed to perform their duty.....

The royal knights No.11 and below that remained in the imperial capital, had been prepared as the raw materials for Armageddon (summoning the Angel Army).

If it is merely summoned, an Angel isn't a threat. Their average combat potential was only around a "B+" rank.

Although, generally since summoned greater demons were "A-" rank, they were sufficiently threatening to a human country.

Although they'd fall short against an elite Demon Lord, a force of over 1,000,000 "B+" ranks would be more than sufficient.

But, that's only considering the case of facing a human nation.

While there was no problem against an older Demon Lord class, the current members of Octogram were on a completely different scale in terms of quality.

Therefore this time, for the first time, Yuuki decided to try and incarnate the Angels using Emperor Rudra.

Up until now, this execution was a taboo, but considering the

fact he'd lost half his mind at this point, he could be tempted put Justice King Michael's proposal was into action.

The living and the dead, in order to determine the difference, both have been prepared.

This place also clicked well with Yuuki's objectives.

it served the purpose of cutting off pursuers, and as they had erased that tracking clone, now they felt safer.

Vega comprehended Yuuki's actions, and just as he was thinking that,

「What is this place? What happened to the battle.....?」

Emperor Rudra, who was in a dazed state up until now, opened his mouth.

While he was only half conscious, it seemed that he would be awoken before long.

Although a bit earlier than planned, Yuuki decided to move his plan to the next phase.

Yuuki gave Vega a wink, as he and Chloe hid themselves.

Seeing that, Vega understood Yuuki's intentions.

This was one of several pre-determined patterns.

Understanding this he quickly kneeled, and faced the emperor.

While accidents piled up, this was still within expectations.

Without any changes they'll be using the special Skill of Emperor Rudra's Ultimate Skill 『Justice King Michael』, and use

Armageddon.

This was Vega's predetermined role.

Yuuki was relieved that Vega understood.

(That guy, I was anxious that he'd forget since he's an idiot after all.....)

Contrary to his beliefs, Vega too had been equipped with the thing called "brains".

Albeit boastful of his strength, when he thought about it he only recalled a few individuals whose strength exceeded Vega's.

In any case, he heaved a sigh of seeing that the strategy was going well.

Vega, didn't actually listened to Yuuki's speculations in detail.

However, by using the Emperor's ability, their current goals would be accomplished.

In regards to Vega's role in the series of battles of the coup d'état, it was the actualization of their ultimate goal, making Emperor Rudra successfully use Armageddon.

Well, that was originally Yuuki's role, but since the coup d'état plans went awry, the baton was passed onto Vega midway.

If Yuuki died, then Vega would be the one to execute it.

In the original plan, they'd finish subjugating Ruminas, and execute it before the final clash with Guy, but due to several unforeseen incidents, the plan was pushed forward.

「Your Majesty, you're alright! This Gradim was so worried!」

While acting as Gradim, Vega explained the situation to the Emperor.

The army was wiped out, Kondo, Damrada and the other Royal Knights are expected to be annihilated as well.

While Velgrynd stalled for time, he somehow escaped with the Emperor; he recited the thought out scenario.

「What did you say!? Are you saying Damrada and Velgrynd are still fighting?」

「Yes, your Majesty! Kondo-dono as well as Damrada-dono are currently engaged in a fight to the death.....」

「——Is that so. Then, before it's too late, we must rescue them.

I'll summon the angels. Make the preparations!!」

「But, your Majesty.....!!」

Without letting it show, a smile surfaced on the face under that helmet.

Although he wondered would the Emperor would actually perform the angel summoning, it looked like things were going well.

‘Just a little more, and it’s over’ he thought, a natural smile broke through his façade.

But, that though was simply too naïve.

「Oh my? That would be troublesome. ——Besides, there’s no need to rescue them.

After all, those two are already dead.」

A beautiful voice resounded in Vega’s ears.

It can't be! Vega thought as he tried to deny the notion that just came to mind.

But, as if ridiculing his actions,

「Hey, you. You dare ruin Your's truly's fun?

Your life isn't enough to make up for this

So kindly cry out in pain and agony to sooth my heart.」

As if out of nowhere, somebody suddenly appeared behind his back.

And then, he notice the feeling of a muzzle thrust towards his head.

Despite there being a helmet over his head, for some reason he clearly felt it.

「W-wait!」

「Repent as you're trapped in fear! “Resentment Fear (Cursed Prison of Resentment and Fear)”」

With even his soul devoured, he faced endless torture by the ghoul horde.

The pinnacle of anti-individual mind break magic, a synthesis of Extinction King Abaddon, and a Necrosis bullet, was shot.

The pistol, large and crude in the hands of a lady, was fired.

Being an enlarged variant of the one Kondo once held, it's expected power would also increase.

The effects of the magic sealed within the bullets shot from the large pistol was released in the interior of Vega's skull.

With a single hit, Vega's flesh was corroded by the curse; His soul, becoming prisoner to endless agony.

Uo.....

Not given a chance to explain himself, he was shot without hesitation.....

As expect of Carrera.

Another name on the ranking of individuals to never, ever, anger.

Or rather, putting the gentlemanly Diablo aside, the ones like Testarossa and Carrera are pretty scary huh.

In that aspect, I'm so glad Ultima was calm and collected.

It's hard to believe she's a Demon.

She's been called 「Ojou-sama」 by her subordinates, her main aide was her butler too, she looks to have obviously been raised well.

She probably has all lot of influence.

Speaking of which, she might even be the Demon King's daughter.

This is no good.

Looking at Carrera hunting the “Rat” without hesitation, I began to wander away in thought.

They had requested to allow them to end the Emperor and the “Rat”, and I'd given them permission, but the result was this.

But well, the remaining one would be the one that bit the Emperor bait huh.

Ultima was fired up about killing the emperor, and came over to me, wishing to do it.

So I decided to hand it to her.

and Thus, my opponent would be the mastermind.

「Oy, stop hiding and come out. You're there aren't you? Yuuki!」

I asked facing the darkness,

「Good grief, was I exposed? Can't expect less of Rimuru-san.」

Yuuki said as he came out.

Just like how he was back in the Royal Capital, with a nonchalant look, and a light-hearted feel as if he was meeting an old friend.

But I can't leave him alone. He's too dangerous.

「I guess. It's good that you're doing well.

By the way, any last words before you die?」

「Ahahahaha. Straight to the point eh, Rimuru san. But you think I die so easily?」

「No I don't, but you've gone overboard.

But, if you don't do anymore than this, we could settle with just sealing you.....

So what do you say? Your freedom will be restricted, but it's

better than dying right? 」

「Naïve, still too naïve. You haven't changed at all, still a goodie too-shoes.....

But, it's best you stop thinking you've won! 」

it was impossible as expected huh.

I thought it was impossible right from the start.

However, there's the matter of freeing Chloe, and him making some strange Wish (Command) of her would only cause the situation to take a turn for the worse.

I wanted to try managing the situation in order to ensure this doesn't happen, but I guess it was impossible.

We faced each other, and quietly prepared ourselves.

Chapter 185: The Beginning of a New Game

I confronted Yuuki, and we began to size each other up.

And in the middle of the tense atmosphere,

「Oh yeah, I was wondering..... How did you find this place?」

Yuuki asked.

He seemed to be either bold or stupid.

Who even asks this kind of question to the enemy?

「I ain't supposed to tell you that man!」

「Ah, I guess that's right?

I didn't really expect an answer, and I guess Rimuru-san isn't that gullible huh.」

Yuuki shrugged as if disappointed.

Well, he probably isn't.

He probably kept talking, to try and find out my weaknesses.

Actually, just like Diablo said, Moss' recon was perfect.

He had sent out both an appropriately sized dummy body, and a mini body.

It didn't matter if the big one got found.

Rather, the plan was to let the enemy find it, and let their guard down, while the smaller clone would remain in contact without them suspecting a thing.

As one of them got found out and destroyed, the other would use that chance to get into camouflage.

Really, his abilities was excellent for this kind of work.

Now then, let's recap.

First, the strategic victory conditions from before recovering Veldora.

1. Recover Veldora.
2. Eliminate the threat.
3. Annihilate the Imperials.

Of those, most of the work was done.

One could say operation complete. The only thing left would be the releasing (finishing off) the Emperor.

In that case, the new victory conditions,

1. Recover Chloe.
2. Finish off the Emperor.
3. Finish off Yuuki.

Would become like that.

The most important and given most priority was the task of recovering Chloe.

But as long as there were the three Wishes (Orders), I couldn't just take her back.

Worst case, there was the option to eat Chloe and use Soul Analysis to try and find a way to break the curse.....

Even with Wisdom Lord Raphael doing the Soul Analysis, there was a big risk of failure.

If possible, only after eliminating the controller = Yuuki, should I calmly start working on the curse.

In any case, I wanted to finish things before Yuuki made Chloe do anything.

Similar to Rimuru planning his bout with Yuuki, the latter also, looking at the unexpected situation, let out a sigh.

When he noticed the spy, he did anticipate something like this, but of the things he anticipated, this was the worst of the worst, and he couldn't help but sigh.

(Geez, can't you just leave me alone.....)

In any case, he needed to do something about this.

In this situation, Yuuki's options were limited. It was pretty bad that Vega was eliminated in an instant.

Well, Vega didn't really matter that much.....

But, ordering Chloe now would be a bad move.

Currently those stronger than Yuuki would be : Guy • Crimson, Milim • Nava, and the one in front of him, Rimuru.

There was also Demon Lord Leon • Cromwell to whom he had suffered defeat once, and to whom his powers were known. But he was now someone Yuuki had some chance to win against the next time.

But against this Rimuru with his unusually high growth speed, he honestly couldn't predict anything.

If he made Chloe deal with Rimuru, in that instant she would be released.

Therefore, they would need to finish each other off. And in an ideal scenario, just before that happened, Yuuki himself would step in and steal their powers.

But failing to get the powers, he would then have to face an angered Milim.

It was good that Chloe wasn't hostile towards him, but he was running out of options.

If he atleast had 2 wishes (orders) remaining, he could order the elimination of Rimuru now, and somehow escape.....

His only saving grace was the fact that Rimuru and the rest didn't know that he had only one remaining.

Yuuki considered putting Chloe in hiding a good decision.

Rimuru would therefore take into account the possibility of him issuing an order to Chloe, and wouldn't be able to act carelessly.

Using that opportunity, he would somehow survive this event.

And in the worst case scenario, he would be forced to play his trump card, he expected.

(Yeah, I don't really wanna have to do that though.)

But as he thought so, there didn't seem to be any other means of him escaping his current trial.

The Demons working under Rimuru.

Yuuki truly understood the breadth of power of those elite Demons.

3 of those pillars had appeared.

Each, making even Demon Lords look like weak, were the very definition of danger.

(The hell. They're too OP.)

That was his honest feeling.

He could likely have faced one of them and won, but all three at once would spell certain defeat.

Demons never obeyed those weaker than themselves. And obedience time after a summoning would be shorter, the higher their Nobility.

It was unlikely that Rimuru had summoned all three and put them under leash. That left the possibility that Rimuru had become a much higher class than them.

Yuuki was on the fine line of actually just using his trump card right now without hesitation.

(Man, I could've atleast made the Emperor use Armageddon (Angel Army) before Rimuru-san came.....)

As he thought so, everything changed.

And it changed for the better, for Yuuki of course.

Testarossa surveilled the surroundings, making sure there were no threats lurking about.

There were none, she determined.

Around them were the outskirts of the Imperial Capital, with no signs of human presence.

Other than a line of corpses, 100,000 soldiers who seemed to

be in pain but not actually alive, there were no others.

Being wary of them without negligence, Testarossa assured Rimuru.

That they could promptly handle whatever Yuuki was planning on doing.

Being done with eliminating Vega, Carrera faced Ultima.

Releasing the Emperor was the wish entrusted to them; their contract. They had to accomplish this without fail.

Ultima would be the one to do it.

Since Rimuru had decreed so, Carrera had no complaints. That being the case, she was given the duty of eliminating Vega who had soiled her battle with Kondo.

That being done, it was only a matter of taking care of the Emperor and the mastermind.

At a glance, Yuuki, the mastermind, didn't seem so much a "danger". However, he exuded a presence that made her "uneasy".

Not "danger" but yet "uneasiness".

Carrera therefore judged Yuuki to be a genuine threat.

He could perhaps even have the might to oust her and her fellow Demons.

(I want to think that I'm just thinking too much. No, he might just be thinking of making us think like we're thinking like that.)

It was her first encounter with the boy named Kagurazaka Yuuki.

Even so, his cunning presence that didn't match his face had put Carrera's instincts on top alert.

Perhaps that vigilance and observant eye was something she inherited from the ever diligent First Lieutenant Kondo.

At present, the one who was on highest alert towards Yuuki was, unmistakably, Carrera.

As for Ultima,

She faced Emperor Rudra.

Hair turned pure white. Pallid skin. He had a sickly frail presence, but the strength of his will still shined brightly in those eyes.

She faced the young Emperor who could still be called a boy.

For a while now,

「What? just what nonsense do you speak?

Kondo Tatsuya and Damrada dead?

The hell is Velgrynd even doing.....

Damrada? And even Kondo Tatsuya?

.....No..... Impossible. If they're dead, why was I even.....」
(TN: fuck I'm sad again.)

He had been muttering deliriously.

The strength in his eyes began to flicker and fade, as if his heart was being reflected in them.

It was of no concern to Ultima, but seeing as he had calmed down,

「That Damrada guy asked me to kill you.

When I accepted, he'd seem to have died in peace.

Same for that Kondo guy.

He fought my fellow demon, Carrera, over there and fell valiantly.

The both of them were your underlings, so aren't happy you'll be joining them?」

She asked him in a carefree way.

It was her slight way of being considerate.

But those words had tremendous effects.

「I see. So they both fell with pride.

Therefore, I too shan't allow myself to fall in disgrace.

As a Ruler of this world, I shall persevere till the very end.

I shall make Justice King Michael bend to my will!」

Clad in the Aura of his former days, the Emperor declared with his will of Nobility.

As a ruler, who lived long, and wagered the fate of the world in his Game.

Unlike before, he released the chains on his powers, and wielded the Justice King with all his might.

To go berserk, and cause the erasure of civilization; to meet the expectations of his subordinates who had sacrificed themselves.

To meet the conditions of his final decree.

His loyal subordinates had kept their word.

So in the end, he would meet his demise as the Emperor.

..... The Emperor however, didn't realize that those thoughts were had been planted into him via Yuuki's Thought Manipulation.

His heart weakened, his mind damaged, he never realized that he had become vulnerable to Ultimate Skills.

In addition, there was fault in his reliance on the Absolute Defense of "Castle Guard".

Being protected from all fronts, he didn't have experience in safeguarding his mind.

The Absolute Barrier would project from all evils as long as those swearing fealty were nearby.

But without those loyal subjects, it had no effect at all.

He had only hoped to slightly influence him.....

But Yuuki's Thought Manipulation "Worm" had, facing no resistance, encroached the Emperor's mind, and made Yuuki's plans come to fruition.

In other words, Armageddon was unleashed.

Fuck!

Sensing danger, Ultima went into full gear.

「Oh no you don't! “Bloody Bite” !!」

But she was the slightest bit too late.

「Yield to my power! Armageddon Activate!!」

Using the last of his spirit, Rudra summoned the Angel Army.

Her claws were weakened by the sheer Holiness of that Skill, yet “Bloody Bite” still forced its way towards Emperor Rudra's heart.

However, using Rudra as the key, the Gates of Heaven spread open.

Ultima's “Bloody Bite” was nullified a single moment before reaching him.

The skies of the Imperial Capital became saturated with Holy

Aura.

And thus, the Ultimate Army against Demons, The Angel Army had begun to manifest.

The circumstances flipped.

Yuuki had made the first move.

The Emperor had exceeded his expectations in moving according to his plans.

The “Worm” he had unexpectantly used showed great results; it was a happy mishap.

Rather than the “Worm”, it was most likely because the broken Emperor couldn’t resist Justice King Michael’s temptation.

The current situation could be said to be born only because the goals of Yuuki and the Justice King were one in the same.

At any rate, it was Yuuki's move.

His goal.

Was that of stealing the Ultimate Skill 『Justice King Michael』 from Emperor Rudra.

Normally, one could only attain an Ultimate Skill with a strong will. However, in Rudra's case it was being borrowed.

Knowing this, Yuuki was determined to steal it.

Obviously, there were certain conditions. The soul needed to be expressly weakened or else it would be impossible.

Meaning, making him activate Armageddon which put him in

his weakest state, it was the perfect time to plunder the Skill.

「Ahaha! Sorry Rimuru-san. I'll be winning now!」

Yuuki activated his Ultimate Skill 『Greed King Mammon』 , and began approaching the Emperor.

「Steal Skill!!」

Turning the tables.

Stealing his Skill and putting the Angel Army under his command.

It was the only plan that he could use to overcome the current circumstances, but then.....

「Naive.」

He heard Rimuru mutter.

Ha-? Before even thinking of complaining, his cheek received a dizzying shock.

「Kufufufufu. Those actions are well within calculations.」

Yuuki was blown away by Diablo who had, completely erasing his presence, perfectly hidden himself.

That single attack, breaking through his multiple force fields, felt as if it was reaping his soul away.

Even then, the attack seemed to not be at full power.

After all, it was only a bare-handed strike using no weapon.

「—— Kpff!! The hell, there was another one.....!」

At this point, his composure had all but disappeared.

Yuuki changed his expression, and laughed.

「Ku, kukuku, ahahaha ha haha ha! Gimme a break!

Really, I need one..... So you really were my worst enemy huh.

Fucking bravo Rimuru-san.

I really did want to end the world with my own hands.

Yeah no.....

I really can't imagine myself winning against you. Not to mention, even that Demon over there——

—— You're power is just too insane. That chill I got when we first met was right on the money.

I should have ended you then.

Did I lose my marbles somewhere? Well, doesn't matter at all now.

No no, in fact, if you can stop me, that'd just be fate, the will of the world.

I guess ■■ will decide the rest.

Goodbye, Rimuru-san

I kinda liked you a bit too.

—— Honestly, we could've been pals you know.....」

And started saying incomprehensible garbage.

Did he break from getting hit too hard? I was thinking when,

「Move, Diablo!」

I shouted as my sense of danger went crazy.

Just then, Yuuki had made his move at a speed which I could barely follow.

And just barely, Diablo faced Yuuki's flexible serpentine attack Snake Sword, and dodged — failed to dodge it, removing the smile from his face.

Diablo's abdomen suffered a light slashing damage.

「To have injured me..... It seems I had taken you lightly.」

「No please, I praise you for being able to dodge. But well——」

But well——

Yes, Yuuki's goal wasn't to injure.

It was simply having Diablo, who blocked his way to the Emperor, move out of the way.

Carrera immediately shot her gun, but the flexible Snake Sword acted like a whip and thrashed all bullets away from Yuuki.

He repelled the bullets with overlapped effects of Ultimate Skills.

He nullified Testarossa's oncoming magic attack, and evaded Ultima's lunge.

With a technique surpassing that of Damrada, he shifted Ultima's center of balance and thrust his palm at her.

The sudden concentrated palm thrust sealed Ultima's movements in an instant.

And that instant was all that was necessary.

Moving at unfathomable speeds, easily doing away with the Demons who reacted——

Yuuki reached the Emperor.

「Come, Justice King Michael!」

Yuuki's hand made contact with Emperor Rudra.

And then, all went white.

Ordinarily, actually stealing an Ultimate Skill from its owner was impossible.

For that Skill would be born from oneself, deep from one's soul, and would be etched into their Nucleic Heart.

The Ultimate Skill was truly personal, as opposed to Normal Skills beat into the body, or Unique Skills engraved into the outer crust of the soul.

However, Rudra's 『Justice King Michael』 wasn't etched into the Heart, rather, only buried into his soul, and was only under control through the strength of his will.

And now, after activating “Armageddon”, his (spirit) Energy had been vastly depleted, and using the Steal Skill ability from Yuuki's Ultimate Skill 『Greed King Mammon』, it was possible to plunder the skill.

「!!」

The Emperor made a soundless scream.

The Skill buried into his soul was gouged out.

The unimaginable pain caused the already broken Emperor's mind to crumble even further.

And with an expressionless face,

「With this, I just summoned the Angel Army without using any of my own Spirit Power.

There were a few mishaps, but in the end, all according to keikaku.」

Yuuki muttered.

And then, as if it was the most natural thing in the world, he issued orders to the Angels.

Incarnate! He commanded.

As if it was his own from the start, Yuuki showed excellent control of 『Justice King Michael』.

The Angels which flooded the skies heeded Yuuki's orders, and to attain their bodies, began their incarnations.

However, the 100,000 prepared bodies were not enough for the 1,000,000 strong Angels.

To compensate, yes ——— innocent, uninvolved civilians, the citizens of the Capital were put forth as tribute.

Receiving such a report from Moss who was stationed at the Capital, I was infuriated.

「Yuuki, you bastard! Stop the Angels now! Don't get unrelated civilians involved dammit!」

Yuuki, with an emotionless face, only glanced towards my yells.

As if he had no idea what he was hearing. Or rather, it was completely unbecoming of the Yuuki who always made such rich expressions while ridiculing others.

As if he had nothing at all but his objective in mind..... for comparison, it was similar to Wisdom Lord Raphael or the “Voice of the World”, an emotionless instance of personality.

—— Goodbye, Rimuru-san ——

I remembered Yuuki’s words from just now.

—— I see, Yuuki was only the outer shell.....

Like the Wisdom Lord, Yuuki must have also had some kind of personality “existing” in him.

However, unlike Raphael, it was a cold, crude personality that didn't even try to understand human emotions.

Thinking back, Yuuki's actions were full of inconsistencies.

Even when sincerely wishing to end the world, he would hesitate and fail.

What that meant was that, inside him, there must be an unconscious "hesitation"; That, as he was acting so carefreely, there were seeds of worry and doubt under the cover.

And his final words, were his true feelings.

(You idiot..... You should have said something dammit.....)

Hesitating till the very end, he made his choice.

Between, ripping up his plans and giving up on ending the

world, and forcefully pulling the final trigger.....

And he had pulled that trigger.

He released (the Destructive Spirit) Angra Mainyu, residing inside him.

This spirit would, without the slightest hesitation, force the end of the world. It must not be left alone.

Yuuki had now changed to something completely different; he had become a “menace” to the world.

After his quick emotionless glance at Rimuru, he immediately faced the Angels performing their possession.

And then, he ordered.

「Feast on the Seraphim, and resurrect. Kagari, Vega. 」

Kagari's prepared corpse, and Vega's body, whose head was smashed, beckoned by Yuuki's words, began their rebirth.

Carrera's "Resentment Fire" that had entrapped Vega's soul was nullified with Yuuki's "Eraser Shot".

Normally the soul itself would have been eliminated, but Vega's soul was of a special genre which, Yuuki knew, could handle substitutes.

After all, they were the ones who had created Vega.

Vega was a Battle Creature, whom Yuuki had created taking inspiration from Rimuru's powers when they first met.

In terms of specs 『Plunder』 was better than 『Predate』 .

『Plunder』 could attain powers of the same level as the one it took, whereas 『Predate』 only got a degraded version.

But 『Predate』 had its advantages too.

This was its integration ability. It could make optimum use of the powers in its possession.

That led to the very real possibility of developing an Ultimate Skill after attaining and integrating multitudes of Skills.

This was the basis under which Vega was born.

Therefore, he could also receive substitute souls, and his body was now regenerating.

For this reason, he wasn't affected by Carrera's cursed bullet.

As for Kagari, she needed no explanation.

Kagari, or rather, Kazaream, the ex-Demon Lord, who held out even as a soul, believed in the success of their plan and was

diligently waiting.

Knowing the true nature of Yuuki, Kagari never once doubted that he would lose.

Kagari and Vega successfully completed their resurrection.

As holy beings, who ate the Seraphim, who rivalled the strength of even Awakened Demon Lords.

Confirming both of their revivals, Yuuki now turned to me, and spoke.

「Hey, let's play a Game.

If you can stop me, you win.

If not, you lose.

The prize for the winner will be: this world.

We start in one month.

You need not reply.

The countdown has already begun.

This is Yuuki Kagurazaka, my creator's, final desire.」

He selfishly declared.

Continuing, he called out to Chloe who was hidden away all this time.

And issued her an order.

「Go keep Guy busy.

I don't care if you kill him.

However, don't let him interfere with the Game!」

Chloe came out with a sullen face, and looked like she wanted to tell me something, but only nodded to Yuuki's order.

I too wanted to say something to her, but the timing wasn't right.

Thinking that Yuuki would send Chloe after me was one big cause for worry.

In any case, I was very glad I didn't have to fight Chloe here and now.

If that had happened, while I faced Chloe, the Devil Lords would have to deal with Yuuki, Vega, Kagari, and the whole Angel Army; not exactly a piece of cake.

I could call over the rest of the Demon Nobles, but the Angel Army would definitely still be troublesome.

This was, as Angra Mainyu had said, going according to Yuuki's wish of playing a Game with me.

He had made this his last order right before releasing Angra Mainyu, very Yuuki-like.

Was it to buy time against me, or for buying time to save me, I didn't know.

He was hesitant about ending the world, so I believe he wanted to settle everything with a game.

A very crazy-like, Yuuki-like idea.

At any rate, it was not time to fight just yet.

Even if I attacked now, it'd have not effect as Yuuki was now in possession of "Castle Guard".

We were the ones at a disadvantage, so I'll take this opportunity as a saving grace.

As if he had finished his work here, Yuuki took his two underlings, and the Angel Army, and teleported somewhere else.

They probably returned to the Heavens using Justice King Michael.

I wondered if you could go there with Bodied Angels, but they did do it, so yeah.

Anyway, a month remained till the game starts.

Yuuki probably needed more time to get used to the Angra Mainyu's powers, and give time for the Angels to get adjusted into their bodies.

As for me, I too gained the time to integrate my Skills, and wait out the ascension of my subordinates.

This time was very precious.

I should contact Ruminas, Leon, and Guy, and let them know about the happenings.

Throwing another Walpurgis (Demon Lord Festival) should be a good idea, I started planning for hereafter.

The results this time were good, that was without a doubt.

I didn't want to think my decision was wrong, but that could just be a failure caused by "self-conceit".

Or maybe it was because I had yet again attained new powers, overcome the worst case scenario, and still ended at a good position.

Though I did have “Soul Protect”, just to be safe, I had only brought along those with Ultimate Skills to fight the mastermind.

It’s because I suspected Yuuki to be the one behind it all, and feared he might take away my subordinates.

But being wary of Yuuki was a good decision.

We were completely prepared.

Except, I didn’t think the Emperor would be broken, and would actually use Armageddon.

No —— I had considered even that possibility not to be much of a problem.

I had somehow gained such tremendous strength that my bar for threat was raised much higher.

And also, according to Velgrynd, there was no need to worry about the angels.....

That precisely was my worst mistake.

Prioritising Yuuki and ignoring the Emperor was the very reason the situation took a turn for the worse.

But still..... If everything was within expectations, we could handle it.

Unfortunately, there was one thing that was far beyond my imagination.

That was: Yuuki's true power.

The hidden personality that could be called another Yuuki, had power far beyond my expectations.

That result was, as expected, the worst case scenario.

It was what the result of him exhausting all other options.

Just that.

The Emperor's funeral was conducted.

Among the 3 million, or rather, because a third of them were sacrificed to Angels in an unprecedented "genocide", the remaining civilians of the Imperial Capital.

Velgrynd oversaw the event.

After being summoned by me, she cremated the corpse with her Flames of Purification.

It was a mournful event marking the end of a long lived Hero, but he was probably glad to be seen off by his sworn friend

Velgrynd.

Me talking about his (Rudra's) life would be presumptuous.

So, I won't say anymore.

Just one thing, it was a fact that the "contract" had been fulfilled.

Thereafter, I declared my reign of the Capital, and expressed my condolences to the public.

I decreed to eliminate all insurgencies, and put priority in public peace.

Also, I contacted Krishna at Tempest, and told him to come to the Capital with an army.

He should be travelling at full speed so, it would take 5 more

days.

I planned to leave the rest to Krishna.

I had planned to destroy the Empire in retaliation to the attack on Tempest, but somehow or other, had taken control of it.

But it couldn't be helped at this point.

The Empire's ruling party was eliminated, and only the Nobles remained.

Leaving them alone would destroy public order, and cause civil wars.

I wanted to at least abide by Rudra's wish for the citizens' happiness.

Not as a Demon Lord, but as one “Ex-” human.

When Krishna arrived, it came time for me to return to Tempest.

I had already put in many orders.

They must be busy preparing.

For the final battle.

—— A month had passed.

A war that engulfed the whole world broke out.

Intermission: -Guy Crimson-

His birth (manifestation) happened in the distant past.

Born as an absolute being, he had sway over other beings with his Charisma.

The embodiment of Pride.

If he had grown like that, he could have been a being who would be called the King of the Underworld.

It was somewhat of an accident for a being such as he to be brought into the over world, but this was an event that will end up changing his fate significantly.

After arriving, he surveyed his surroundings.

He understood immediately, that he had been summoned.

The man who looked like the magician who summoned him was annoyingly spewing prideful words.

His wish was to destroy the opposing country which his side was warring against.

That was a simple matter.

Using the wide range destruction magic ——Death Streak—— without hesitation, he spread death easily.

Millions perished and cities of death were created. He felt nothing from what has been done.

But, attaining massive quantities of souls, he noticed he has ascended to a True Demon Lord.

It seemed, just reaping ten thousand human souls, was enough to reach ascension.

Then, what would happen if I collected even more souls? He was curious.

Also, he wanted to “repay” the person, who decided to give him such a “chore”.

He summoned two retainers ——Arc Demons—— and gave them orders.

Swiftly erase this country from the face of this world.

He was currently in a good mood, having ascended.

The point was that he had destroyed the residents of the country, that the magician who summoned him and gave him such a “chore” resided in, with no pain or suffering. That alone, proved how much of a good mood he was in.

Also, the demons he summoned had the honor of being granted physical bodies.

Thus, a once flourishing, but having been divided, great country, that wielded ancient super technologies, met its demise.

Such had happened thousands of years ago.

Although a country ended up destroyed as his idea of an experiment and “payback”, he collected even more souls, but there weren’t any more changes.

Which led him to understand, he cannot be strengthened any further.

This marked the start of boring days to come, but Guy didn’t mind.

He roamed about everywhere, focused on enjoying the world for what it is.

His life wasted on only battles and refining his Soul in the underworld, now seemed bleak in comparison to the

stimulating outside world.

Having fistfights with gigantic demon beasts, decimating self proclaimed monster kings with his magic.

To the native humans, he was viewed and known as both as a God and a Devil at the same time, it was such a period.

And then, they met.

The one who created the world, the ultimate existence.

“Stellar Dragon King” Veldanava. He who had created the world they live in.

Guy, who undoubtedly prided himself as one of the strongest alive, chose to challenge this being without any hesitation.

And ended up utterly defeated.

Guy was sent to the ground, as though there wasn't any resistance whatsoever.

Never once doubting his was the strongest, his pride at that time, was utterly shattered.

「End me. I am satisfied.

I now understand, that there will always be someone more capable out there in this world.

In the ever continuing and unbreakable logic of this world, my existence too, is but a small part of it.」

「Little one.

You see, I love all that have been born from me.

This monotonous world, has been slowly but surely

progressing.

Intelligent beings are born, and they have now managed to attain the means to communicate with me.

And now, beings that have the ability to go against me have emerged.

A being such as you.

But, if they keep progressing at their current pace, this world will be destroyed in but a few thousand years.

For that, are you interested in cooperating with me?

Cooperate with me, and become an “Arbitrator”.]

The magic kingdom that he destroyed came to mind.

Vying for authority, the foolish scene of strife despite being of the same kind.

(I see, **that** was definitely deplorable.)

There was nothing to hesitate about.

As Guy had also grown fond of this world.

「Why not. What should I be doing?」

「To be as you are. I would like for you, to take the throne as a “Demon Lord”.

To show the world what it means to be feared, so that man will not grow to be overly “prideful”.」

Pride.

Looking back, this role perfectly fits me.

It was a request, that obviously took into account that Guy wielded the unique skill 『Pride』 .

「Very well then. I shall take that throne, as a “Demon Lord”.

If man were to grow too proud, I shall judge them in your stead.」

Guy dove deeper down now that his pride has been shattered once.

And attained ultimate skill 『Pride King Lucifer』 .

A Demon Lord who had the power to rival God was born at this moment.

「Yeah, I leave it to you.」

Hearing Guy's reply, "Stellar Dragon King" Veldanava chuckled happily.

This was the moment, that Guy and Veldanava accepted each other as friends.

Guy now lived his life as a Demon Lord as promised.

But, that didn't actually mean he had much to do.

Turning his attention to gathering intelligence, he now gave orders and received reports from his underling demons.

Beside him stood the White Dragon.

It was a beautiful Dragon, with Blue Diamond eyes.

Perhaps having misunderstood something,

「I'm not accepting this, even if my elder brother has!」

She detestably complained, seeming like she wanted a fight.

Guy was feeling bored recently, so he decided to face her seriously.

After battling for 3 days & 3 nights, Guy's base of operations turned into a silver world blanketed in ice.

Guy simply laughs it off, but for everyone else who lived there, it was a disaster.

She was Veldanava's younger sister, and seemed to be jealous of Guy as he had been accepted by her brother.

But, the seed of jealousy hadn't shown itself inside of her, so her real motive was probably to test Guy.

In the end, she seemed to have found something interesting, and now followed alongside Guy.

This, was how Guy met “Frost Dragon” Velzard.

He shifted his headquarters to the Northern Continent.

It was because the Aura (youki) leaking out from Velzard dropped the surrounding temperature.

Since there was less impact on the surroundings up north, he decided to move his base there.

At that time, Velzard had just learned to transform into her human form, but even more Aura was leaking because of that.

It was the right decision to move his home base. But that place had now become a land of permafrost that was void of any life, that was the only thing that was regretful.

To distract himself away from his boredom, he began surveillance on a larger scale, focusing on locations which showed large scale advancement in livelihood.

Although they looked scrawny when compared to “that place with super technology”, the knowledge of magic and skills which were passed down, slowly began to resurface in their advancement.

It was amusing to watch the humans.

In time, villages became countries, and small scale skirmishes started to show up.

Is it time for me to appear?

As a warning, some countries were destroyed.

The humans, in the face of the threat Guy posed, slowly gained the mentality of working together.

(That's good. Unless you get on my nerves, I won't be destroying your country!)

Guy was fairly fulfilled, with his job as "Arbitrator".

Time passed, and a few hundred years went by.

On a certain day, to the bored Guy, a party came to challenge him.

These intruders, managed to overcome the frozen lands which no man dare tread.

「Your's truly is Rudra. Rudra・Nasca!

A Hero of mankind, one who has shouldered the wishes of his people.

Vile Demon Lord, time to meet your end! Also, give this one

all of your treasures!!」

「Rudra nii-sama, you're acting like the demon lord now!」

「Ahh, that's no good. He's getting blinded by greed.

He's definitely gonna get his ass whooped.」

Having such a conversation, a weird trio.

Hero? What's that?

Guy has been bored for so long, those words piqued his interest.

「Fufun! Coz Your's truly is the strongest, I won't be needing help from you guys.

Hey Demon Lord, I challenge you to a one-on-one battle!」

The good-looking young man who can be called a biseinen, charged in wearing his intricate full-body magic armor. (TN:maybe pretty boy for biseinen? lol)

Should I easily evade or receive the attack. Maybe I should counterattack and make him regret his choice.

Guy thought with Thought Acceleration, while looking at the 3 of them.

But,

「Nii-sama! At least have some support magic ——Holy Blade—— !!」

The magic released from the silver haired girl, who looked to be his younger sister, enveloped Rudra's sword in light.

It was a dazzling, eye catching light, which exudes a radiance that seemed to destroy evil.

(Shit. That light could cut through all barriers!)

Plus, he has been hiding his true strength, the young man's swinging sword accelerated towards Guy.

At the last second, Guy parried the blow with his Demon Sword "Tenma".

The young man, with his vivid sword techniques, gave Guy problems even when predicting his moves using "Clairvoyance".

「Hey, you're good! You are the first who managed to make me draw my sword!」

「Hah! To think you would parry the attacks of Your's truly! This is gonna be fun, Demon Lord!

Before this one destroys you, how about he hears your name?」

「How brazen, for a human....

I'm Guy.

All who have faced me, end up screaming Giyaa-----.

Does that work as my name?

It was a pain to think about, so I shortened it to Guy for my name.」

「.... Wait a sec.

That's not how names work. Names don't work that way at all!

It won't be awesome if your's truly defeats a Demon Lord with such a weird name....

Come to think of it, your hair's a beautiful Cardinal Red color——」

「Hold up. If you talk about Cardinal, you think of me. What are you doing giving away my name!？」

「Nn? Ahh, I get it, what a noisy fella....

Alright, Crimson then! How's that, no more problems right?」

「.... it's kinda similar, but that's good i guess. Words don't really go into that thick head of yours....」

「Great! Then it's decided. From today, you shall be “Demon Lord” Guy・Crimson!」

Thus, “Demon Lord” Guy•Crimson was born.

Because of what he did, the young man ——Rudra—— lost consciousness, and ended up wandering the borders of life and death; his battle with Guy ended up getting delayed....

Thinking back, Guy and Rudra’s entwined fates may have started here.

After Rudra recovered, they battled countless times.

Rudra was powerful, calling himself a Hero was no fluke.

The awakened Hero Rudra, and the ascended Demon Lord Guy.

Rudra battled with the pinnacles of technique and skill, while Guy used his overflowing power and Skills.

Although it was a stalemate for a period, it can be said Guy slowly was gaining the upper hand.

Rudra's little sister, Lucia, and the beauty with the azure hair, "Scorch Dragon" Velgrynd, speechlessly watched over the two of them.

This has become something of a daily occurrence, since god knows when.

On one such day,

「Hey you! Even though you said to battle fair and square, isn't what you are doing too devious!？」

After obstructing his(Guy's) vision, Rudra cut Guy's stats down with a Holy Barrier, so Guy was voicing his complaints.

「Justice goes to the victorious! No, without victory, it is justice no more!

That's why, Your's truly shall attain victory by any means!

Also, that move you just used, that was a move this one used last time!

Going around stealing other's moves.... You're the devious one!!」

Retorted Rudra.

Recently their strength has been comparable, being on the back foot probably made Rudra anxious.

His declaration at the start was blown off elsewhere, and he was gunning for the victory by any means now.

Though Guy looked like he was sighing, on the inside he was enjoying such conversations too.

Having someone comparable as a sparring partner was amazing as it is, and just as Rudra said, he could vividly feel himself improving with each battle.

Just attaining an Ultimate Skill isn't the end, mastering it's usage is where the real challenge lied.

Although he was battling Rudra at his level, using only his sword, Guy was slowly overpowering Rudra.

At this point, with Rudra pulling small tricks every so often, they ended with a tie, having no conclusion.

But, if they went on like this, sooner or later Guy is going to emerge victorious.

But....

Guy felt something out of place.

「Oi.... You, during our first battle, why did you not defeat me then?

If you didn't name me, and just came at me with everything you had, you would have won, right?」

Proud as he is, as much as he didn't want to admit it, Guy still chose to ask Rudra this question.

Just as Guy wielded 『Pride King Lucifer』 , Rudra wielded 『Justice King Michael』 .

If he went all out from the very start, he had a definite chance of doing damage to Guy.

It was a fact, that Rudra had his chance at victory.

「You dumbass! There's no meaning if Your's truly just *defeats* you!

Getting you to acknowledge how awesome this one is, then turning over and becoming my ally.

Your's truly, is the *Man* who's gonna rule the world.

That, was his promise to his master “Stellar Dragon King” Veldanava.」

That was his answer.

To bring even himself(Guy) under his wing, the *Man* Rudra.

Guy, was now conscious of the fact that he *liked* Rudra.

That said, if he didn't, he would've killed him immediately, it felt kind of moot at this point.

「Well that's that, on a serious note.... If Your's truly went all out, he wouldn't be able to control it.

Well, this 『Justice King Michael』 , is a power borrowed from Veldanava....」

After listening to what Rudra had to say, although it was unexpected, Guy found himself accepting the circumstances.

If... It was a power that was a part of Veldanava, having the capability to defeat me isn't hard to imagine.

「What the. That would make this——」

Meaningless, was what Guy was about to say, but his voice was muffled by the roar of an explosion.

The cause, was a fight among sisters, between Velzard and Velgrynd.

It seems, that due to their newborn brother's selfishness, he was out rampaging about as he liked.

They were pushing the responsibility onto each other, saying Velzard's severe discipline being the cause, and Velgrynd's spoiling him being the cause.

This was something he was used to already, but Guy thought it would be nice if they could do it somewhere else so as not to be a nuisance to others.

Guy and Rudra took cover so they won't be dragged in.

He kinda lost interest in their fight.

His position as Demon Lord, was something that he was doing for Veldanava in the first place.

It couldn't be helped that he was unable to get serious about his battles with Rudra, who was also Veldanava's friend.

「We're done here! I really like you.

That's why, I won't be killing you, nor will I fight you for real.

But, to stop the world from falling apart, I'll stay in my position as Demon Lord.」

Just as Guy said that while looking Rudra in the eyes,

「So, then. Why don't we have a "Game"?」

Rudra said that, while trying his hardest to hide his half embarrassed half laughing face.

「A "Game"?」

「Yeah.

This one and you, with our respective pawns, we fight for conquest of this world.

Your's tru-... I believe that it is possible to unite the humans.

I was able to become friends with someone like you.

There's no need for a "Demon Lord" or "Arbitrator".

Veldanava was being obstinate with his ideals.....

But I have persuaded him and got his approval.

Even though the chances are amazingly close to zero, I'll be doing everything I possibly can.

『Justice King Michael』's Armageddon, will bring forth an army of angels that will destroy everything.

But, I'll give it my all to control this power.

If humans advance too much, military power and civilization will become collateral.

And, I shall unite this world, and create a utopia!

So, I would like you to stop going around slaughtering humans.」

「Hah! It's not as though mindless slaughter is a hobby of mine.

I only kill those who annoy me.

It matters not whether they are kind or villainous.

If I like them I let them live, I kill them if I don't.

But, well.... Why not?

I'm bored anyway.

I shall not take the field personally, and instead I'll gather up other Demon Lords, and they shall represent me.

Now, your goal is to conquer the world before it becomes one that is under total control of the Demon Lords.

I give you my word that I will not directly interfere.

But, I will continue my work as the "judge".

It is my promise with Veldanava as the "Arbitrator".

Also, as a "Hero", you should already know right?

Heroes, are they who wield the greatest power, the avatars of justice.

Armageddon as it is, is a greater deterrent compared to the threat of Demon Lords.

It is a “program” meant to destroy the world, prepared for when the “Arbitrator” abandons his job.

Veldanava is a perfectionist, not a romanticist.

After seeing intelligent beings finally being born after several hundred million years, he sees the need to manage them so they don't end up destroying themselves.」

「But, even so!

I, have the obligation to bring him peace of mind.

Veldanava, has consummated with my sister.

And, Lucia has been blessed with Veldanava's child.

Veldanava now, is no different from a normal human.

He had always been alone, as someone who wasn't bound by the concept of a lifespan; that Veldanava confided to me while smiling.

He has found happiness being together with Lucia, but even now he still worries for the future!

Ever more so, for the future of his child....

That is the reason why I need to let him settle down.

To let him see, how much this world that he has created, has matured, has become a wonderful balanced world——」

To Rudra's words, Guy had none to return.

In his head, although he thought of and denied multiple

possibilities, he ended up understanding Rudra's feelings.

He was vexed, at his own brilliant mind.

(What the hell man, you idiot.... Doesn't that mean, that you'll be the one shouldering everything....?)

Guy was at a loss for words, towards this foolish man, who he saw as his greatest friend.

Guy then processed, and calculated the chances in his mind.

The possibility of success was abysmally low.

This man(Rudra), who Guy saw as his best friend had, at his own convenience, decided to shoulder all the trials of establishing this utopia he so sought.

But, if it was this man, then maybe....

It was a fact, that there was something in Rudra that made you think as such.

In the end, Guy accepted Rudra's "Game".

If all of Guy's representatives are defeated, it's Rudra win. If that happens, Guy will follow Rudra.

But, until that condition is met, as promised with Veldanava, Guy will continue his work as "Arbitrator".

There was little merit for Guy to win.

At most, he gets to stop Rudra's reckless plan, and returns to his work as "Arbitrator" and stop the other Demon Lords from getting out of hand.

But, that was enough for Guy.

To his hard-headed friend, words will not be enough to get him to back down.

And so, this “Game” between Guy and Rudra, which would span more than 2000 years, began.

the result....

Was a cycle of tragedies.

Shortly after Milim was born, Lucia and Veldanava perished in a magic attack caused by another country plotting against the Nasca Kingdom.

Milim grew up without knowing her parents’ faces. Also, not knowing of her relation to Rudra.

Milim’s pet too, perished at the plot of a certain country.

To calm down the vehemently enraged Milim, Guy had to take her on with everything he had.

The repeated tribulations.

The ugly truth of the human world that was shown.

After shaving off his Holy powers through countless rebirths, he lost his qualifications to be a “Hero”.

Even so, Rudra remained a Saint, through sheer force of will.

But——

After a certain point, Rudra’s heart began to be tainted, as he began utilizing means that strayed from his past idealist self.

Cold, cruel means.

Attaining victory against Guy became the only goal, but that, only caused more tragedies.

「I said it already didn't I, you foolish blockhead....

That kind of stuff, is more suitable for us Demons, who are capable of fully controlling our emotions....」

As he mumbled such, he was unconscious of the things that flowed down his cheeks....

As he quietly, gave his once greatest friend, his prayers.

And so, the Game between Guy and Rudra that had spanned eternally, came to it's end.